TOEFL HOUSE

GRAMMAR FOR SPECIAL SPEAKING

A practical grammar course for accurate, natural, confident speech

Learn the grammar. Use it in conversation. Make it part of your speech.

A classroom and self-study course for real spoken communication

16 lessons · 3 review tests · final assessment · 5 reference appendices

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Grammar for Special Speaking — TOEFL HOUSE

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Where to find the answers

The complete answer key for learners appears in Appendix 5 at the back of this book. Instructors teaching with this course should use the companion Teacher's Book, which provides complete lesson procedures, answer notes, acceptable alternatives, model conversations, timing plans and classroom guidance.

INTRODUCTION

Why knowing a rule on paper is different from owning it in speech

Most English learners have had the same frustrating experience. You study a grammar rule, you complete a page of exercises without a single mistake, and you feel ready. Then someone asks you an unexpected question in a real conversation — and in that split second, the rule disappears. You hesitate, translate in your head, or fall back on the same safe, simple sentences you were using two years ago.

That gap between what you recognize on paper and what you can say out loud is not a lack of intelligence or effort. It happens because most grammar books teach grammar as a set of abstract formulas for your eyes, whereas speaking requires fast, meaningful choices in your voice.

In real life, grammar is not decoration. It is how you signal what you mean. The difference between 'I lived in Herat for three years' and 'I have lived in Herat for three years' tells your listener whether you still live there today. The difference between 'You mustn't be late' and 'He can't be late' separates a strict rule from a logical guess. When you understand what a structure actually does for your listener, you stop memorizing charts and start making clear, confident choices.

This book is built around one simple habit: speak first, see the principle clearly, hear the difference, and immediately use the pattern in real conversation. Every small improvement in how you connect tenses, frame questions, compare ideas, or soften a claim compounds over time. Fix one recurring habit in each lesson, and within sixteen lessons your spoken English sounds noticeably clearer, more natural, and more persuasive.

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- choose the right tense to describe habits, ongoing projects, past stories, and life changes;
- ask natural questions, soften polite requests, and keep a real conversation moving;
- express advice, certainty, possibilities, wishes, and regrets with the exact shade of meaning you intend;
- compare options persuadably and connect your ideas into clear, logical arguments;
- shift focus smoothly using the passive voice, causative patterns, relative clauses, and participles;
- report what others said accurately and control your tone with hedging and natural emphasis;
- catch and repair your own slips in the middle of a conversation without losing your flow.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

A practical guide to turning grammar into automatic speech

Four habits that make this book work

1. Always speak before you read the rule. Every lesson begins with The Speaking Hook — a short situation or question to discuss with a partner right away. Do not worry about perfection in those first two minutes. Speaking first wakes up your ear; when you read The Simple Rule a moment later, you will immediately recognize the exact tool you were just reaching for.

2. Read the side-by-side contrasts aloud. In See the Difference, you will see pairs of sentences that look similar on the page but send very different messages in conversation. Say both sentences out loud and notice where your voice stresses the words. Your ear remembers contrasts far better than definitions.

3. Stretch your answers to match your voice. Everyone in your class works through the same lessons and conversations together. In every speaking activity, start by making your core point clearly and accurately. Once that feels comfortable, push yourself one step further: add a concrete example, explain the reason behind your choice, address another point of view, or try one of the sharper patterns in Part 6 (Say It with Greater Precision).

4. Close the book for the final recall check. At the end of every lesson, cover the page and answer the retrieval prompts out loud from memory. Calling a pattern up from memory without looking at the page is what moves grammar from short-term recognition into long-term speech.

How each lesson moves from curiosity to confident speech

Lesson step	What you do	Why it matters
Part 1 · The Speaking Hook	Discuss a real-life situation or short contrast with a partner.	Activates your own ideas so the grammar answers a real need.
Part 2 · The Simple Rule	Learn how the pattern works through meaning and natural examples.	Gives you a clear mental picture instead of a dry rule to memorize.
Part 3 · See the Difference	Compare easily confused forms side by side in the same situation.	Shows you how a small change in grammar changes what people hear.
Part 4 · Practice the Pattern	Complete, repair, and transform sentences — saying each one aloud.	Builds accuracy before you have to think on your feet.
Part 5 · Pair Speaking	Use the grammar in a guided back-and-forth conversation.	Turns controlled sentences into responsive dialogue.
Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision	Explore ways to add nuance, detail, and sharper focus to your ideas.	Helps you express more sophisticated thoughts naturally.
Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge	Plan briefly with keywords and speak for 1–2 minutes without notes.	Builds real-world fluency and independence under time pressure.
Part 8 · Review and Self-Check	Test your memory with the page covered and check your progress.	Locks in the core insight and spots any habit that still needs attention.

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DIAGNOSTIC TEST

Find your starting point — 25 questions · no time limit

Complete this test before Lesson 1 without studying first: the purpose is simply to see which patterns already feel natural and which ones deserve extra attention. Mark your score out of 25 and keep your notes. This is a broad starting snapshot, not a parallel form of the 30-item Final Assessment; do not interpret the difference between their raw totals as a learning gain. For a direct before-and-after comparison, complete the speaking sample in Part D and score it with the same four-criterion rubric used at the end of the book.

Part A — Tenses and time (10 questions)

1. I _____ (see) that film last week.
2. She _____ (work) here since 2021.
3. While I _____ (cook — ongoing background), the phone rang.
4. They _____ (work) there for ten years before they moved to Kabul.
5. At sea level, pure water _____ (boil) at 100°C.
6. They _____ (build) a new bridge when we visited.
7. I _____ my keys — I can't get in. (lose)
8. Last summer we _____ (go) to Herat.
9. How many books _____ you _____ (read) so far this month?
10. When I arrived, the train _____ already _____ (leave).

Part B — Structures (10 questions)

11. If it _____ (rain), we'll stay home.
12. I wish I _____ (know) the answer.
13. My phone needs _____. (repair)
14. The report _____ (write) by the team last week.
15. He suggested _____ early. (leave)
16. Could you tell me where _____ ? (the station / be)
17. The girl _____ helped me was very kind. (who / that / whose / which)
18. I'd rather you _____ (not, smoke) here.
19. Ali is _____ than his brother. (intelligent)
20. Not until midnight _____. (she / finish)

Part C — Use and communication (5 questions)

21. I _____ find my passport anywhere. (mustn't / can't)
22. _____ being very tired, he finished the race. (Despite / Although)
23. She asked me, "Where do you live?" → She asked me _____.
24. It _____ rain later — take an umbrella. (may / might / could)
25. I _____ my hair cut yesterday. (had / got)

Part D — Baseline speaking sample (not included in the 25-point written snapshot)

Speak for two minutes

Choose one topic. Prepare for two minutes, then speak for two minutes without reading a script:

- A decision that changed your life — and what you would do differently today.
- One change that would improve education or work in your country.
- A person who influenced you, and the advice they gave you.

After your talk, a partner asks two follow-up questions. Answer them, then ask one relevant question in return. If you get stuck, repair and continue. Record the topic and, if possible, save an audio recording. At the end of the course, repeat this task under the same conditions. The Final Assessment uses the same task and four-criterion rubric so you can compare your baseline and final scores directly.

Criterion	4 — Strong	3 — Good	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Grammatical accuracy	structures are consistently accurate; occasional slips do not affect meaning	generally accurate; some errors, meaning always clear	frequent errors; meaning sometimes unclear	errors dominate; meaning often unclear
Appropriate structure selection	wide range used naturally (tenses, conditionals, linkers, hedging…) for the intended meaning	good range; choices usually match the meaning	limited range; some structures forced or inappropriate	basic structures only; frequent wrong choices
Clarity	ideas well organised and easy to follow; effective linking	clear overall; some linking	ideas loosely connected; hard to follow at times	ideas listed without clear connection
Successful communication	message fully delivered; natural delivery, relevant follow-up exchange and self-repair	message delivered; answers and asks relevant follow-ups, with some hesitation	message partly delivered; responses are limited or pauses are long	message largely not delivered; little response to questions

Baseline speaking score: ____ / 16. Keep this page for your end-of-course comparison.

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answer key is kept at the back of the book so you can complete the diagnostic first.

What your snapshot means: 21–25 — strong foundation; pay special attention to nuance, register, and the precision patterns in Part 6 of each lesson. 15–20 — solid core; study the side-by-side contrasts in Part 3 carefully and speak every practice item aloud. Below 15 — take your time with the core explanations in Part 2, repeat Practice A and B aloud, and build clean, accurate sentences first.

LESSON 1 · TENSES FOR REAL COMMUNICATION

Part 1 — Build Strong Sentences | Speaking goal: talk about habits, experiences and changes accurately

Imagine two candidates in a job interview. The first says, 'I worked at a city clinic for three years.' The second says, 'I have worked at a city clinic for three years.' Only one small word changed, yet the interviewer hears two completely different life stories: the first person no longer works there, while the second still walks through those clinic doors every morning.

Tenses are not a chart of endings to memorise for a test. They are the camera lens you choose every time you open your mouth — telling your listener whether something is a permanent routine, a temporary project, a closed chapter in the past, or a change that still shapes your life today.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these two pairs of sentences aloud with a partner:

• 'I live with my cousin.' vs. 'I'm living with my cousin until my flat is ready.'

• 'I lost my keys yesterday.' vs. 'I've lost my keys — can you let me in?'

Without using grammar terms, explain to your partner what changes in the real-world situation between the left sentence and the right sentence. Then take one minute each to answer:

• What does a normal weekday look like for you, and what is one temporary project you are working on this month?

• What is one important thing that has changed in your daily life over the past year?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Present tenses: habits, facts and what is happening now

When you talk about the present, English asks a simple question: are you describing your normal baseline, or are you shining a spotlight on something temporary happening around now?

Use the present simple for your baseline — habits, routines, permanent facts, fixed timetables, and mental states. Use the present continuous when an action is in progress right now, when a project is temporary around this period of your life, or when a situation is gradually changing.

Pattern:

Present simple: Subject + base verb (+ s/es for he/she/it) → habits · facts · fixed timetables · states
Present continuous: Subject + am/is/are + verb-ing → happening now · current projects · temporary situations · changing trends

Natural examples:

• I work in a medical clinic, and our morning shift starts at eight. (permanent routine and fixed timetable)

• I'm working on my pronunciation this month by recording myself for five minutes a day. (temporary current project)

• More professionals are learning English online every year. (an ongoing trend)

• I know the answer, and I believe your plan will work. (mental states stay in the present simple)

Keep in mind:

→ Add -s or -es with he, she, and it in the present simple: he works, she studies, it matters.

→ Stative verbs describe a state rather than an active process (know, believe, understand, own, belong, seem, prefer). They normally stay in the simple form: say 'I understand the problem' (not 'I am understanding').

Rule 2 — Past simple vs present perfect: closed time vs connected to now

Many speakers hesitate between 'I did' and 'I have done' because both refer to something that happened before now. The real difference is not how long ago the event happened — it is whether the time period is closed or still connected to the present.

Use the past simple when you name or think of a finished time period (yesterday, last summer, in 2020, when I was a student). That chapter is closed. Use the present perfect when the time period is still open (today, this week, so far this year), when a past event has a clear result right now, or when a situation began in the past and continues up to today (often with since or for). 'Recently' can take either tense, depending on the time focus and variety of English.

Pattern:

Past simple: Subject + past verb (verb-ed / irregular) → a finished, closed time in the past

Present perfect: Subject + have/has + past participle → open time period · life experience · present result · continuing to now

Natural examples:

• I visited Bamyan last summer with my classmates. (finished time: 'last summer' is over)

• I have visited Bamyan twice in my life. (life experience up to now — no finished time is named)

• Nadia has lived in this neighbourhood since 2021. (she moved here in 2021 and still lives here today)

• I've sent the application, so we can relax now. (past action with a direct present result)

Keep in mind:

→ Once you attach a finished time stamp (yesterday, two days ago, in 2019), close the door with the past simple: 'I saw him yesterday' (never 'I have seen him yesterday').

→ With 'recently', either tense can be natural: 'I've spoken to her recently' (focusing on the recent link to now) or 'I spoke to her recently' (thinking of that specific recent occasion).

Rule 3 — Talking about changes and the future

English does not have just one future tense because we do not think about every future event in the same way. Whenever you talk about tomorrow or next year, you are showing your listener how prepared that future is.

Choose 'be going to + base verb' when you have already made a decision or plan before speaking, or when you can see clear present evidence of what is about to happen. Choose 'will + base verb' when you make an instant decision while speaking, make a promise, or state a general prediction. Choose the present continuous (with a future time expression) when you have a fixed arrangement with another person or organisation.

Pattern:

am/is/are going to + base verb → prior plans and intentions · predictions from visible evidence

will + base verb → decisions made while speaking · promises and offers · general predictions

Present continuous + future time word → fixed personal arrangements already on the calendar

Natural examples:

• I'm going to take the TOEFL exam next spring — I've already bought the study guide. (decided plan)

• Those bags look heavy — I'll carry one for you. (instant offer made at the moment of speaking)

• We're meeting the new instructor on Thursday at ten. (fixed arrangement with a specific time)

Keep in mind:

→ In future time and condition clauses starting with if, when, as soon as, before, or after, use the present simple: 'When the results arrive, I'll call you' and 'If it rains tomorrow, we'll stay indoors.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Present perfect vs past simple — the choice is about TIME

Look at how the same verb changes meaning when you shift from the past simple to the present perfect. In each pair below, ask yourself: is the speaker looking back at a finished moment, or looking at how the past touches right now?

Past simple (closed past time)	Present perfect (connected to now)	What your listener hears
I lost my keys yesterday.	I've lost my keys.	The left sentence reports when it happened (perhaps I found them later). The right sentence is about right now: I am standing outside the door and cannot get in.
She worked at the hospital for five years.	She has worked at the hospital for five years.	Past simple means her five-year period is finished — she works somewhere else now. Present perfect means she started five years ago and still works there.

Past simple (closed past time)	Present perfect (connected to now)	What your listener hears
Did you eat breakfast this morning?	Have you eaten breakfast this morning?	We ask 'Did you eat?' when the morning is over. We ask 'Have you eaten?' while it is still morning and there is still time to make you some toast.

State verbs vs action verbs — when a verb changes its job

Most state verbs (know, believe, understand, belong, own, seem, prefer) describe a steady condition, so they stay in the simple form: 'I understand the rule' — never 'I am understanding the rule.'

However, a few everyday verbs have two meanings: a state meaning (simple) and an active meaning (continuous). Compare: 'I think this course is practical' (my opinion — state) versus 'I'm thinking about applying for a scholarship' (an active mental process happening right now). Likewise, 'She has a small car' (ownership) versus 'She's having lunch with her supervisor' (an action in progress).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. I _____ (see) that documentary last week, and we talked about it for hours.
2. Nadia _____ (work) at the children's hospital since 2022.
3. We _____ (meet) the new course director tomorrow morning at ten. (fixed arrangement)
4. Look out of the window — it _____ (snow)!
5. My older brother _____ (believe) that consistent daily practice beats last-minute cramming.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Correct the mistake and explain why: 'I have finished my assignment last night.'
2. Correct the mistake and explain why: 'She is knowing three foreign languages.'
3. Choose the natural form: How long (do you know / have you known) your closest friend, Sara?
4. Rewrite using going to so it sounds like a decided plan: 'My intention is to study medicine next year.'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Interview your partner using the four questions below. Do not treat this as a checklist — listen closely to the details in every answer and ask at least one natural follow-up question before moving to the next prompt.

- What does a typical weekend look like for you when you have no urgent deadlines?
- What is something new or different you are doing these days that was not part of your routine six months ago?
- What was the best part of your last weekend, and who were you with?
- What has changed most in your work, studies, or daily habits since last year?

How it sounds in conversation:

A: What are you doing these days that wasn't part of your routine six months ago?
B: I'm walking to class every morning instead of taking the bus. It takes forty minutes, so I listen to English podcasts on the way.
A: That's a great habit. How long have you been doing that, and have you noticed a difference in your listening?
Your conversation goal: Both partners answer all four questions, exchange at least four follow-up questions in total, and can report one interesting answer about the other person to the class.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ uses present simple for regular habits and routines
✓ uses present continuous for current projects and temporary changes
✓ uses past simple for finished past moments and present perfect for changes continuing to now
✓ asks natural follow-up questions that react to what the partner actually said

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Once your tense choices are accurate, you can express richer shades of time by showing continuous effort, contrasting past setbacks with present growth, or highlighting a milestone.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Link every time expression directly to its natural tense: finished markers (yesterday, two weeks ago, in 2020) close the action in the past simple; open bridges (since 2021, for three months, so far this week) connect to now with the present perfect.

• Say three true sentences about your own week aloud: one permanent habit, one temporary project you are doing this month, and one experience you have had this year.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use the present perfect continuous (have/has been + verb-ing) when you want to emphasise the ongoing effort or visible effect of an activity: 'I've been revising all morning, so my eyes are tired.'

• Combine past simple and present perfect in a single sentence to show growth from a past event: 'I failed the driving test twice last year, but I've learned from both mistakes and I feel ready now.'

• Use milestone frames such as 'It's the first time I've ever...' or 'This is the most challenging project I've worked on' to highlight a standout experience.

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to jot down three keywords only (do not write full sentences): one past turning point (past simple), one change that has happened up to now (present perfect), and one habit or focus you are working on these days (present simple / continuous).

Speak without reading: Speak for one full minute: How has your English — or another practical skill you value — improved over time? Name one specific past moment that helped you, explain what has changed since then, and describe what you are actively working on right now.

Model response — speak first, then compare

I've been studying English seriously for about two years. Last year I joined a weekly speaking club, and that was the moment things really changed for me — I learned to respond in English right away instead of translating every word in my head. Since then, my confidence has grown a lot, and I've spoken in front of visitors twice at work. These days I listen to a short news podcast every morning while I walk, and I'm focusing on making my pronunciation clearer.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ past simple used for the specific turning-point event

✓ present perfect used for progress and changes up to now

✓ present continuous used for what the speaker is focusing on these days

✓ time expressions match the chosen tenses naturally (last year, since then, these days)

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Present simple describes your permanent baseline (habits, facts, states); present continuous spotlights what is in progress or temporary around now.

• Past simple closes the door on a finished time (yesterday, in 2020); present perfect connects the past to the present moment.

• For the future, use 'going to' for decided plans, 'will' for spontaneous decisions and predictions, and the present continuous for fixed arrangements.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'I have seen him yesterday.' → 'I saw him yesterday.' (A finished time stamp requires the past simple.)

→ 'I am knowing the answer.' → 'I know the answer.' (State verbs stay in the simple form.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Describe your last weekend in four connected past-simple sentences, then add one sentence in the present perfect about how your week has gone so far.

• Explain three things that have changed in your town, work, or studies since 2020.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can talk about a routine, a current project, and a past experience in one smooth answer.

☐ I can hear the difference between a finished past event and a situation that continues up to now.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 1 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. saw · 2. has worked / has been working · 3. are meeting · 4. is snowing · 5. believes

Practice B: 1. I finished my assignment last night. ('last night' is a finished time) · 2. She knows three foreign languages. ('know' is a state verb) · 3. have you known · 4. I'm going to study medicine next year.

LESSON 2 · TELLING STORIES AND DESCRIBING EXPERIENCES

Part 1 — Build Strong Sentences | Speaking goal: tell a story with background, sequence and clear focus

Have you ever listened to someone tell a story that sounded like a flat shopping list? 'I woke up late. I ran outside. It rained. I missed the bus. My phone died.' Every sentence is grammatically correct, yet the story feels lifeless because every action is painted on the exact same flat surface.

Skilled storytellers use grammar like a film director uses cameras. One tense paints the atmosphere in the background, another drives the main events forward step by step, and a third flashes back to something that had already happened before the scene began.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Compare these two openings to the same story:

• Version A: 'I walked home from work. The lights went out. I realized my keys were on my office desk.'

• Version B: 'I was walking home from work when the street lights suddenly went out — and that was the moment I realized I had left my keys on my office desk.'

Read both versions aloud with a partner. Why does Version B pull the listener in? Then take 30 seconds each to tell a brief true story about a small surprise, delay, or lucky moment from your own life.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Past continuous: painting the background scene

Before an audience cares about what happened, they need to see where you were and what was going on around you. That is the job of the past continuous (was/were + verb-ing).

Think of the past continuous as a wide-angle background shot that is already rolling when a sudden, shorter action (in the past simple) steps into the frame: 'I was waiting at the pharmacy when my old teacher walked in.' The waiting was already in progress; the entrance interrupted or punctuated it.

Pattern:

Past continuous: Subject + was/were + verb-ing → ongoing background scene · action in progress at a past moment

Scene + interruption: While + past continuous, past simple / Past continuous + when + past simple

Natural examples:

• I was walking across the campus when I ran into an old classmate.

• A cold wind was blowing and shopkeepers were closing their shutters as we reached the market.

• While I was preparing the slides, the projector suddenly stopped working.

Keep in mind:

→ Use 'while' before the ongoing background action (past continuous) and 'when' before the shorter interrupting event (past simple): 'While I was cooking dinner, the lights went out' / 'I was cooking dinner when the lights went out.'

Rule 2 — Past perfect: stepping one level further back

Stories do not always unfold in strict 1–2–3 calendar order. Often you start your story at an exciting moment — arriving at the airport gate, opening an exam paper, meeting someone — and then you need to point back to something that happened earlier.

If you keep using the past simple, your listener thinks the events happened one after another ('When I arrived, he left' means my arrival caused him to walk out). When you switch to the past perfect (had + past participle), you signal a flashback: 'When I arrived, he had already left' (the room was already empty when I got there).

Pattern:

Past perfect: Subject + had + past participle → an action completed before another past moment

Natural examples:

- By the time we reached the cinema, the film had already started.
- She looked relieved because she had finally submitted her thesis.
- I recognized the street immediately because I had visited the neighbourhood years earlier.

Keep in mind:

→ Do not overuse the past perfect for every sentence in a story. Use it only when you jump backwards from your main past storyline to an earlier event: 'By the time the taxi arrived (main past), we had packed everything (earlier past).'

Rule 3 — Signposting the sequence and landing the ending

In written English, paragraphs show the reader how a story is organized. In spoken English, your listener cannot see paragraphs — your sequence phrases are their only map.

Clear time signposts (At first, A few minutes later, Suddenly, By the time, In the end) guide the listener from the opening scene to the turning point, and a final reflection shows why the experience mattered.

Pattern:

Opening & sequence: At first … · A moment later … · After that … · All of a sudden … · Finally …
Tight time links: Earlier that morning … · By the time … · As soon as …

Natural examples:

- At first, everyone at the table stayed quiet. Then, all of a sudden, my grandfather started laughing.
- As soon as I opened the envelope, I knew the hard work had paid off.
- Looking back, that mistake taught me to check the schedule twice.

Keep in mind:

→ 'As soon as' shows that the second action happened immediately after the first, with no gap in between.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Three camera angles in the past: event vs scene vs earlier flashback

Notice how changing the tense in the second clause completely changes the timeline of the meal in these three sentences:

Past simple (next event)	Past continuous (in progress)	Past perfect (already finished)	How the timeline changes
When my sister arrived, I cooked dinner.	When my sister arrived, I was cooking dinner.	When my sister arrived, I had cooked dinner.	1. Past simple: she arrived first, and then I started cooking. 2. Past continuous: I was in the middle of cooking when she walked in. 3. Past perfect: the food was already cooked and waiting on the table before she arrived.
He took a taxi when the rain started.	He was taking a taxi when the rain started.	He had taken a taxi before the rain started.	Each tense places his ride at a different point relative to the rain: after it started, during it, or before it.

The three-part architecture of a memorable spoken story

When you tell an anecdote in conversation or in a speaking exam, give it a clear three-part shape: 1. Set the scene (past continuous: where you were, what was happening). 2. Tell the key events in order, flashing back only when needed (past simple + past perfect). 3. Land the ending with what changed or what you learned (past simple or present perfect): 'It was pouring with rain… I slipped on the steps because I had rushed out in smooth shoes… I've checked the weather before leaving the house ever since.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. While I _____ (study) for the final exam, the electricity suddenly went off.
2. We _____ (already / eat) dinner by the time our cousins arrived.
3. First, I _____ (call) the clinic, and then I _____ (take) a taxi across town.
4. She _____ (walk) along the riverbank when she _____ (see) smoke rising from the warehouse.
5. By 2019, he _____ (finish) his engineering degree and started his first job.
6. The children _____ (play) in the courtyard while their mother _____ (rest) indoors.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Combine into one sentence using while: 'I read the contract. The office printer jammed.'
2. Combine using by the time and the past perfect: 'We reached the station. The train left.'
3. Correct the timeline mistake: 'When I arrived at the hall, the speaker already left.'
4. Use sequence signposts (At first, Suddenly, In the end) to tell a three-sentence story about nearly missing a bus or flight.
5. Choose the natural connector: The doorbell rang (while / when) I was drying my hair.
6. Rewrite this flat list as a vivid two-sentence story scene using past continuous and past perfect: 'It rained hard. I forgot my umbrella at work. I got soaked.'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Take turns telling a two-minute true story from your own life. While you listen to your partner, picture the scene and prepare two genuine follow-up questions about details that make you curious.

• Choose one prompt: a journey you still remember clearly · a day when plans went wrong in an unexpected way · an important decision you had to make quickly.

• Include all three story layers: a clear opening scene (past continuous), at least one earlier detail that had happened before the main moment (past perfect), and a closing line that explains why the moment mattered.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: It was a cold Tuesday morning in January, and I was waiting for a shared taxi outside the university. I had stayed up until two in the morning finishing my project, so I was half asleep...

B: Oh no — did you make it to the presentation on time, or had the professor already started when you walked in?

Your conversation goal: Each partner tells a two-minute story that the other can retell in three sentences, and asks two genuine follow-up questions about it.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ opens with a clear background scene using the past continuous

✓ guides the listener with natural sequence signposts

✓ uses the past perfect accurately to mark an earlier action

✓ ends with a clear reflection on why the experience mattered

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Once your three basic narrative tenses work smoothly together, you can add texture to your storytelling by showing repeated past routines, highlighting how long an earlier activity had been going on, and connecting a past story to who you are today.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Before you start speaking, picture the three layers of your story: what was happening in the background (was/were + -ing), what happened next (past simple), and what had already happened earlier (had + past participle).
• Practise telling a compact 30-second anecdote aloud that includes one 'while', one 'when', and one 'by the time'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use 'would + base verb' (or 'used to') to paint nostalgia or repeated past habits at the start of a story: 'On summer evenings in my hometown, we would sit in the orchard and listen to my uncle's stories.'
• Use the past perfect continuous (had been + verb-ing) to show how long an activity had been in progress before the turning point: 'We had been waiting in the rain for forty minutes when the bus finally appeared.'
• Close your story by bridging back to the present with the present perfect: 'That afternoon taught me a lesson I've never forgotten.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take ten seconds of silent mental planning (write nothing down): picture your opening background scene, the two main events in order, one earlier detail that explains why it happened (had + participle), and your closing reflection.

Speak without reading: Tell a two-minute story about a memorable day in your life — a small crisis, an unexpected kindness, or a lucky break. After your partner gives feedback, switch partners and tell the same story a second time, making the sequence and ending even sharper.

Model response — speak first, then compare

It was a Friday afternoon in May. I was walking home from the bookshop when I suddenly realised I had left my phone on the counter — I had only been walking for ten minutes, so I turned back at once. At first I checked my coat pockets twice; then I hurried back down the street. By the time I reached the shop, the owner had already answered a call from my cousin: he had won two tickets to the championship final and needed my answer straight away. I called him back from the shop counter, and we went to the stadium that evening. I've checked my pockets before leaving every shop ever since.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ clear three-part story shape (background scene → main events → closing reflection)

✓ natural sequence signposts (at first, then, by the time, in the end)

✓ past continuous and past perfect used accurately to separate time layers

✓ the listener can easily retell the main events in the right order

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Past continuous paints the background scene in progress; past simple moves the main events forward; past perfect flashes back to an earlier past action.
• Sequence signposts (at first, suddenly, by the time, as soon as) keep your listener oriented.
• Strong spoken stories end by showing what changed or what the speaker learned.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'When I arrived, he left.' (means he left after I arrived) → 'When I arrived, he had already left.' (means he was gone before I arrived).

→ 'While I was walking, I had seen an old friend.' → 'While I was walking, I saw an old friend.' (Use past simple, not past perfect, for the main interrupting event.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Tell a 30-second true or invented story aloud that uses both 'while' and 'by the time'.

• Name the three layers of a well-structured story and give one example sentence for each.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ My spoken stories have a clear background scene, logical sequence, and meaningful ending.

☐ I can use the past perfect naturally to show which of two past actions happened first.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 2 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. was studying · 2. had already eaten · 3. called / took · 4. was walking / saw · 5. had finished · 6. were playing / was resting

Practice B: 1. While I was reading the contract, the office printer jammed. · 2. By the time we reached the station, the train had left. · 3. When I arrived at the hall, the speaker had already left. · 4. answers vary · 5. while · 6. It was raining hard, and because I had forgotten my umbrella at work, I got soaked. (answers vary)

LESSON 3 · QUESTIONS, AUXILIARY VERBS, AND FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS

Part 2 — Express Ideas Clearly | Speaking goal: ask clear questions and keep a conversation alive

Why do some English conversations feel effortless while others feel like a stiff border-control interview? Usually it comes down to how people ask questions. When a speaker drops auxiliary verbs, uses direct interrogation word order with strangers, or jumps from one unrelated topic to the next, the conversation stalls.

When you master three habits — clean question word order, polite indirect openings, and follow-up questions that build on what the other person just said — you can keep any conversation alive and make the other person feel genuinely heard.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Compare these two short exchanges:

• Exchange 1: A: 'Where you work?' B: 'At a bank.' A: 'What is your favourite food?'

• Exchange 2: A: 'What kind of work do you do?' B: 'I work at a bank.' A: 'Really? What part of banking do you focus on?'

With a partner, find out three things about each other: their favourite way to unwind after a busy week, something they are trying to learn this year, and one place they hope to visit. Rule for this warm-up: after every answer, you must ask ONE follow-up question about what your partner just said before changing the subject.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Forming direct questions: auxiliaries and the subject-question exception

Most direct English questions put an auxiliary verb (do, does, did, am, is, are, have, has, will, can, should) in front of the subject: 'Where do you live?' or 'Have you finished the report?' Once 'do', 'does', or 'did' carries the tense, the main verb returns to its base form: 'Did she call?' (never 'Did she called?').

There is one crucial exception that trips up even experienced speakers: when the question word itself (Who, What, Which) is the subject of the verb, there is no inversion and no 'do/did'. Compare: 'Who called you?' (Someone called you — 'Who' is the subject) versus 'Who did you call?' (You called someone — 'you' is the subject).

Pattern:

Yes/No question: Auxiliary + subject + main verb …? → Do you agree? · Have they arrived?
Wh- object question: Wh- word + auxiliary + subject + main verb …? → Where did she go?
Subject question (Who/What = subject): Wh- subject + verb …? → Who wrote this? · What happened?

Natural examples:

• Where do you usually study in the evenings?
• Did the coordinator send the new timetable yesterday? (base verb 'send' after 'did')
• What happened at the end of the meeting? ('What' is the subject — no 'did')
• Who organised the workshop, and who did you invite to speak? (subject question vs object question)

Keep in mind:

→ After do, does, or did, always use the base verb: 'Where did you buy that?' (not 'Where did you bought that?').
→ Test whether Who or What is the subject by answering the question in your head: 'Who broke the cup?' → 'Ali broke it' (subject = no 'did').

Rule 2 — Polite indirect questions: softening the approach

Walking up to a professor, a client, or a stranger and asking 'Where is the office?' or 'How much does this cost?' is grammatically correct, but it can sound abrupt. To sound polite and composed, English speakers wrap the question inside a soft opening phrase such as 'Could you tell me…?' or 'Do you know…?'

Here is the golden rule of indirect questions: the opening phrase already does the work of asking the question, so the second half switches back to normal statement word order (subject + verb) and drops 'do/does/did'.

Pattern:

Direct question: Wh- word + auxiliary + subject + verb? → Where is the bank? / When did he leave?
Indirect question: Polite opener + Wh- word (or if/whether) + subject + verb → Could you tell me where the bank is? / Do you know when he left?

Natural examples:

• Could you tell me where the registration desk is?
• Do you happen to know what time the library closes on Fridays?
• I'd like to know when the interview results will be announced.
• I was wondering if you could look over my draft this afternoon.

Keep in mind:

→ Never invert twice! Say 'Do you know where the bank is?' (not 'Do you know where is the bank?').
→ For Yes/No indirect questions, connect with 'if' or 'whether': 'Do you know if the bus has left?'

Rule 3 — Follow-up questions: the engine of real conversation

Good conversationalists do not memorize a list of twenty questions. Instead, they ask one clear opening question, listen for an interesting word or feeling in the answer, and ask a follow-up question about that exact detail.

Content follow-ups show your partner that you are actually listening to their story, not just waiting for your turn to talk.

Pattern:

Quick reactions + follow-ups: Really? What happened next? · How did you decide to do that?
Digging deeper: You mentioned it was challenging — which part was hardest? · What would you do differently next time?

Natural examples:

• A: I switched from engineering to teaching last year. B: That's a big step — what made you decide to change?
• A: I took the speaking test twice before I got the score I needed. B: What did you change between the first attempt and the second?

Keep in mind:

→ Build your follow-up from the content of your partner's sentence rather than switching topics: echo one key idea they mentioned and ask 'Why?', 'How?', or 'What was that like?'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Direct vs polite indirect questions in the same situation

Notice two changes when you move from the direct column to the polite column: the tone becomes much more respectful, and the verb moves back after the subject.

Direct (quick / casual)	Indirect (polite / professional)	What changes in the grammar
Where did you buy that dictionary?	Could you tell me where you bought that dictionary?	After 'Could you tell me where', we drop 'did' and put the past tense back on the verb ('you bought').
What time does the clinic open?	Do you know what time the clinic opens?	After 'Do you know what time', we drop 'does' and use statement order ('the clinic opens').
Why was the flight delayed?	Would you mind telling me why the flight was delayed?	The auxiliary 'was' moves after 'the flight' so the embedded clause reads like a statement.

Subject questions vs object questions — why "Who" works two ways

Compare two questions about the same phone call: suppose Mariam called Tariq.

• If we ask 'Who called Tariq?', the answer is Mariam (the subject). Because 'Who' stands in the subject's shoes, the verb follows directly: 'Who called Tariq?'

• If we ask 'Who did Mariam call?', the answer is Tariq (the object), and Mariam is the subject. Because 'Mariam' is the subject, we need the auxiliary 'did' before her name: 'Who did Mariam call?'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. _____ you ever _____ (try) traditional Kabuli palaw cooked over wood fire?
2. What _____ (happen) at the end of the department meeting yesterday?
3. Do you know where _____ ? (the main library / be)
4. Could you tell me how much this course _____ ? (cost)
5. Who _____ (write) this summary on the board?
6. Who _____ you _____ (speak) to at the admissions office yesterday?

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Make this question polite for a stranger: 'Where did you park your car?'
2. Make this question polite for an administrator: 'When will the exam results be ready?'
3. Correct the word-order mistake: 'Do you know where is the nearest pharmacy?'
4. Write two natural content follow-up questions for a partner who says: 'I'm planning to change careers next year.'
5. Correct the verb mistake: 'Did she called you after the interview?'
6. Write one question starting with 'How long…' to ask a classmate about a skill or hobby they have.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Run a three-minute conversational interview with your partner. Partner A starts by asking about one of the topics below, but every conversation must stay on that single topic for at least three follow-up exchanges before moving on. Then swap roles.

• Choose three topics from: learning English · a moment you felt proud of your work · a difficult decision you had to make · a plan for the next two years.

• Each partner must use at least one polite indirect question ('Could you tell me…', 'I was wondering…') and at least three content-based follow-up questions.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: I was wondering what your biggest goal is for the next year.

B: I'm hoping to apply for a master's programme abroad.

A: Really? Do you know which university you want to apply to, or are you still comparing options?

Your conversation goal: A three-minute exchange per pair in each role: three answers, at least three content-based follow-ups, one indirect question — then a one-sentence summary of what you learned about your partner.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ question word order is accurate in both direct and indirect questions

✓ follow-up questions build directly on details the partner just shared

✓ the conversation flows naturally without abrupt topic jumps

✓ both partners speak and ask questions in balanced measure

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

In real conversation, questions do more than request missing facts — they also express surprise, check shared understanding, and invite agreement.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Contrast direct and embedded order aloud until your ear catches inversion errors automatically: 'Where did you go?' versus 'Do you know where you went?'

• Keep five polite openers ready for formal and professional situations: 'Could you tell me…', 'Do you happen to know…', 'Would you mind telling me…', 'I was wondering if…', 'Do you have any idea…'

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use negative questions to express surprise or polite expectation: 'Haven't we met before?' or 'Didn't you receive the schedule I sent?'

• Use short echo questions when a detail surprises you and you want the speaker to elaborate: 'You waited how many hours at the airport?'

• Use natural question tags with falling intonation to invite agreement and keep the listener engaged: 'It's been a busy week, hasn't it?' · 'You've worked with Dr Rahimi before, haven't you?'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to prepare: write down one single-sentence story opener of your own (for example, 'I almost missed an important flight last year' or 'I tried cooking for twenty guests last month'), plus two polite indirect question frames you can use during the conversation.

Speak without reading: Two-minute conversation challenge: Partner A says only their one-sentence opener. Partner B must keep the conversation going for two full minutes by asking natural follow-up questions, reacting genuinely, and using at least one indirect question — while Partner A answers naturally and asks questions back.

Model response — speak first, then compare

A: I almost missed my flight last week.
B: Really? What happened?
A: The main road to the airport was closed, so I reached the check-in desk twenty minutes before boarding. Do you travel often, or do you prefer staying close to home?
B: I fly for work a few times a year. Could you tell me how you managed to get through security in time?
A: One of the staff saw my boarding pass and took me to the front of the queue. Have you ever missed a connection?
B: Not a flight, but I missed the last bus from Herat once. How did you feel when you finally sat down on the plane?

Partner listening checklist:

✓ asks genuine follow-up questions that react to content rather than switching topics

✓ uses at least one polite indirect question with statement word order

✓ maintains accurate auxiliary and subject-question grammar throughout

✓ keeps the two-minute exchange lively and balanced from start to finish

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Most direct English questions put an auxiliary before the subject — except when Who or What is the subject of the verb ('Who called you?').

• Polite indirect questions ('Could you tell me…', 'Do you know…') switch to statement word order and drop 'do/does/did'.

• Follow-up questions that react to specific details turn a dry Q&A into a real conversation.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'Do you know where is the bank?' → 'Do you know where the bank is?' (Use statement word order inside an indirect question.)

→ 'Did she called you?' → 'Did she call you?' ('Did' already carries the past tense.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Take one question about your city or school and say it twice: first as a direct question, then as a polite indirect question.

• Say one subject question ('Who…') and one object question ('Who did…') using the same verb.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can ask polite indirect questions without accidentally inverting the verb.

☐ I can keep a conversation moving for two minutes using natural follow-up questions.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 3 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. Have / tried · 2. happened · 3. the main library is · 4. costs · 5. wrote · 6. did / speak

Practice B: 1. Could you tell me where you parked your car? · 2. Do you know when the exam results will be ready? / Could you tell me when the exam results will be ready? · 3. Do you know where the nearest pharmacy is? · 4. answers vary (e.g. 'What field are you thinking of moving into?' / 'What made you decide to make a change?') · 5. Did she call you after the interview? · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'How long have you been studying English?')

LESSON 4 · MODAL VERBS FOR REAL-LIFE SITUATIONS

Part 2 — Express Ideas Clearly | Speaking goal: express ability, advice, obligation, permission, possibility and certainty at the right strength

Suppose a colleague shows you a draft of an important email that has several confusing sentences. If you say, 'You must rewrite this,' you sound like a strict commander. If you say, 'You might want to make the second paragraph a little clearer,' you sound like a helpful teammate.

Modal verbs (can, could, should, must, might, would) are the volume controls of English. They let you adjust the exact social strength of your advice, requests, obligations, and logical guesses so your listener hears both your message and your respect.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Imagine two real-life moments with a partner:

• Situation 1: A close friend tells you, 'I study English for two hours every night, but I still freeze when I have to speak.' Give them two pieces of helpful advice.

• Situation 2: You need to leave today's class or work meeting fifteen minutes early for a medical appointment. How would you ask the instructor or manager?

Compare the exact words you both chose. Which words made your advice sound encouraging rather than bossy, and which words made your request sound polite?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Choosing modals by meaning and social strength

Structurally, core modal verbs are the simplest verbs in English: they are followed directly by the base verb for every person, with no '-s' in the third person and no 'to' ('She can swim', 'He should wait').

The real skill is choosing the right modal for the relationship. 'Must' and 'have to' express necessity or strong obligation; 'should' and 'ought to' offer advice; 'can', 'could', and 'may' handle ability, possibility, and permission.

Pattern:

Modal + base verb (never add -s or 'to': he can speak · she should wait · you mustn't touch)

Obligation: must / have to · Advice: should / ought to · Possibility: may / might / could · Ability & permission: can / could / may

Natural examples:

• All applicants have to submit their transcripts by Friday. (external institutional rule)

• You really must try the fresh bread from that bakery! (speaker's personal enthusiasm / strong recommendation)

• You should take a short break before you drive home. (supportive advice)

• We could meet on Wednesday, or we might wait until the report is ready. (open possibilities)

Keep in mind:

→ 'Have to' usually points to an external rule or situation ('I have to wear an ID badge at work'), whereas 'must' often expresses the speaker's own authority or personal conviction ('I must remember to call my mother tonight').

→ In the negative, their meanings split completely: 'don't have to' means it is not necessary ('You don't have to bring food'), while 'mustn't' means it is forbidden ('You mustn't park in front of the ambulance bay').

Rule 2 — Degrees of certainty: reading the evidence

We also use modal verbs when we look at clues in front of us and make a logical guess (a deduction). Suppose you knock on a colleague's office door and nobody answers.

If her coat is on the chair and her computer screen is on, you say, 'She must be in the building' (you are almost certain it is true). If you have no idea where she is, you say, 'She might / may / could be in a meeting' (it is one possibility). If you just saw her drive out of the car park, you say, 'She can't be in her office' (you are almost certain it is impossible).

Pattern:

Present deduction: must be (almost certainly true) · may / might / could be (possible) · can't be (almost certainly not true)
Past deduction: must have + past participle · may / might / could have + participle · can't / couldn't have + participle

Natural examples:

• He has been travelling for fourteen hours — he must be exhausted.
• Take a warm jacket; the temperature might drop after sunset.
• That can't be Bilal at the door — he's in Kandahar all week.
• She isn't answering her phone; she must have left it in her bag.

Keep in mind:

→ For negative logical deductions, always use 'can't be' (never 'mustn't be'): say 'He can't be at home — all the lights are off' (deduction from evidence), whereas 'He mustn't leave the room' is a prohibition.

Rule 3 — Diplomatic and polite framing in real life

When you ask a favour, make a complaint, or suggest a change at work, stepping back from 'can/will' to softer forms ('could', 'would', 'might') gives the other person room to say yes comfortably.

Pattern:

Polite requests: Could I possibly …? · Would you mind + verb-ing …? · I was wondering if I could …
Diplomatic suggestions: It might be worth + verb-ing … · We could always … · You might want to …

Natural examples:

• Would you mind moving your bag slightly so I can sit down?
• Could I possibly have an extra day to check the figures?
• I was wondering if we could reschedule our meeting for Thursday afternoon.

Keep in mind:

→ Because 'Would you mind…?' literally means 'Would it bother you…?', a polite 'yes, go ahead' answer uses a negative word: 'No, not at all' or 'Of course not — go right ahead.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

must vs have to vs should — choosing the right weight

Hear how the social pressure changes across these three ways of talking about seeing a doctor:

must / mustn't	have to / don't have to	should / shouldn't	What the listener hears
You must see a doctor today.	You have to see a doctor to get a medical certificate.	You should see a doctor if that cough continues.	'Must' carries urgent personal insistence from the speaker; 'have to' states an external requirement; 'should' gives sensible, non-pushy advice.
You mustn't work on Saturday.	You don't have to work on Saturday.	You shouldn't work every Saturday.	'Mustn't' forbids it; 'don't have to' says it is optional; 'shouldn't' advises against it for your well-being.

can't (logical deduction) vs mustn't (prohibition)

This is one of the most important contrasts in spoken English:

• Deduction ('can't'): 'The restaurant can't be open yet — the chairs are still on the tables.' (I am judging from the evidence that it is impossible.)

• Prohibition ('mustn't'): 'You mustn't use your phone in the examination hall.' (It is against the rules.)

can't = logically impossible	mustn't = forbidden by rule	Why the difference matters
He can't be home yet — his car is gone.	He mustn't leave yet — the guests are arriving.	Using 'mustn't' for a guess makes you sound as if you are giving an order rather than drawing a conclusion.

could vs was able to for past achievements

Use 'could' for general past ability ('I could swim when I was six'), and also with verbs of perception ('I could hear the music from outside'). When you talk about managing to succeed in one specific, difficult past situation, use 'was/were able to' (or 'managed to'): 'The road was blocked, but after an hour we were able to find another route' (not 'we could find another route'). In the negative, both forms work everywhere: 'We couldn't / weren't able to find it.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. You look exhausted after that double shift. You _____ get some rest tonight. (supportive advice)
2. My grandmother _____ speak four languages fluently when she was a young teacher. (general past ability)
3. Dr Karimi _____ be in the clinic today — his car is parked right outside the entrance. (strong positive deduction)
4. Visitors _____ touch the laboratory equipment — it is high-voltage and dangerous! (prohibition)
5. Take an umbrella just in case; it _____ rain later this afternoon. (possibility)
6. _____ you mind _____ (open) the window for a few minutes?

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite this blunt command as a polite request: 'Open the window.'
2. Rewrite using a modal of deduction: 'I am almost certain she is at home right now.'
3. Rewrite using a past modal of possibility: 'Perhaps he missed the early train.'
4. Correct the modal mistake: 'He mustn't be at home — all his lights are off.' (intended meaning: I'm sure he isn't)
5. Write a natural, polite reply agreeing to this request: 'Would you mind waiting five minutes?'
6. Give gentle, diplomatic advice to a classmate who has a bad headache (write two sentences using different modals).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Work with your partner as two colleagues on an organising committee. Your department has a small budget and one free weekend, and you must agree on ONE shared option from the three choices below.

• Options: (1) a two-day communication workshop, (2) upgrading the student study lounge, or (3) a one-day team excursion outside the city.

• Negotiate naturally using modals at different strengths: make suggestions (should / could), point out rules or budget limits (have to / mustn't), make logical guesses about how people will react (must be / might), and use polite requests (Would you mind... / Could we...).

How it sounds in conversation:

A: I think we should invest in the study lounge — the current chairs must be ten years old, and students use that room every day.

B: That's true, though a communication workshop could help everyone before the exam period. Would you mind if we priced the chairs first to see if we might afford a half-day workshop too?

Your conversation goal: One agreed decision per pair, justified with at least three different modals, plus two polite request forms used naturally during the negotiation.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ chooses modal strength that fits the situation (gentle advice vs firm rule)

✓ uses polite request or suggestion frames at least twice (Would you mind... / Could we...)

✓ uses deduction modals accurately based on evidence (must be / might be / can't be)

✓ reaches a clear joint decision and explains the reasoning

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

To sound truly natural in professional and academic speaking, notice how modals extend into the past and how subtle phrases soften suggestions when speaking to senior colleagues or clients.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Sort modals by the job they do in context rather than on a single mechanical scale: must be = strong logical deduction from evidence; should be = reasonable expectation ('The bus should be here soon'); may / might / could be = open possibilities.
• Look around the classroom or out of the window and make three spoken deductions right now: one with 'must be', one with 'might be', and one with 'can't be'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use past deduction forms (must have / might have / can't have + past participle) to interpret past events: 'You must have been relieved when you saw your name on the list.'
• Use 'would' to soften preferences and recommendations: 'I'd suggest waiting until Monday' · 'Would you prefer morning or afternoon?'
• Use diplomatic obligation frames when proposing changes to a team: 'We really ought to consider…' · 'It might be worth reviewing the schedule before we commit.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take one minute to choose your role and prepare three keywords: your main problem or goal, two polite modal frames you will use ('I was wondering if…', 'Could we possibly…'), and one deduction you can make about the situation ('There must have been…', 'You must be…'). Swap roles after one minute.

Speak without reading: Role-play a real-world problem call: one partner is a client or student dealing with a problem (a delayed book order, a double-booked room, or a missed registration deadline); the other is the professional resolving it. Explain the issue politely, make deductions, propose options, and agree on a solution. Then switch roles.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Client: Good morning — I was wondering if I could speak to someone about my textbook order. It was due on Tuesday, and it still hasn't arrived.
Professional: I'm very sorry about that. You must be frustrated, especially with classes starting this week. Let me check the tracking number… Ah, it looks as if the parcel was sent to the wrong district depot.
Client: In that case, could I possibly have it delivered tomorrow? I have to teach until four, so it might need to arrive in the evening.
Professional: That should be possible. We could book an evening courier slot for you, or I could have the main bookshop hold a fresh copy for you to collect today. Which would you prefer?

Partner listening checklist:

✓ modals match the intended social strength (polite request, gentle advice, firm obligation)

✓ maintains a composed, polite tone even while explaining a problem

✓ includes at least one natural deduction (must be / must have been / can't be)

✓ arrives at a practical solution that both speakers accept

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Core modals are followed directly by the base verb (no -s, no 'to') and let you adjust the strength of advice, obligation, and possibility.
• Use 'must be', 'might be', and 'can't be' for logical deductions from evidence; never confuse 'can't be' (impossible) with 'mustn't' (forbidden).
• Softening frames ('Could I possibly…', 'Would you mind + -ing…', 'I was wondering if…') keep requests and negotiations polite.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'He mustn't be at home.' → 'He can't be at home.' (Use 'can't' when you mean 'I am sure it isn't true'.)
→ 'Would you mind to open the window?' → 'Would you mind opening the window?' ('Mind' takes the -ing form.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Make three logical deductions about people or things around you using 'must be', 'might be', and 'can't be'.

• Ask a partner for a small favour in two different ways using polite modal openings.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can adjust how strong or polite my advice and requests sound in conversation.

☐ I can make present and past deductions accurately using must, might, and can't.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 4 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. should · 2. could · 3. must · 4. mustn't · 5. might / may / could · 6. Would / opening

Practice B: 1. Could you open the window, please? / Would you mind opening the window? · 2. She must be at home. · 3. He might have missed the early train. / He may / could have missed the early train. · 4. He can't be at home — all his lights are off. · 5. No, not at all. / Of course not — take your time. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'You should drink some water and rest your eyes. You might also want to step outside for some fresh air.')

REVIEW TEST 1

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–4 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. I _____ (not/see) him since Monday.
2. While we _____ (wait — ongoing action), the announcement came.
3. At standard atmospheric pressure, pure water _____ (freeze) at 0°C.
4. She _____ (study) medicine these days.
5. By the time we arrived, the guests _____ (eat) everything.
6. Look at the sky — it _____ (rain).
7. How long _____ you _____ (know) Nadia?
8. Before the meeting _____ (start), we had already discussed the plan.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. You _____ wear a seat belt; it's the law. (must / might)
2. _____ you mind _____ (close) the door?
3. Do you know where the post office _____ ? (be)
4. You _____ bring any food; we will provide everything. (not / have to)

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Give advice: A friend is exhausted but has a long drive. (use should)
2. Make it polite: 'Where did you park?' (Could you tell me...)
3. Give a deduction: You see a colleague carrying a tennis racket. 'You _____ (be) on your way to a game.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 5 · CONDITIONALS FOR DECISIONS AND POSSIBILITIES

Part 3 — Think Beyond the Present | Speaking goal: talk about consequences, alternatives and hypothetical situations accurately

Listen to two managers discussing a project delay. The first says, 'If we get the parts tomorrow, we'll finish on Friday.' The second says, 'If we got the parts tomorrow, we'd finish on Friday.' Both sentences talk about tomorrow, yet the first manager expects the parts to arrive, while the second manager doubts they will show up at all.

Conditionals are how English speakers weigh decisions, test possibilities, and learn from past mistakes. By shifting the verb tense in the 'if' clause, you tell your listener immediately whether you are dealing with a real plan, a hypothetical daydream, or a past event that cannot be undone.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these three sentences aloud with a partner and notice how your view of the situation changes:

- 'If I have free time this evening, I'll call my brother.'
- 'If I had more free time these days, I'd learn photography.'
- 'If I had known about the traffic this morning, I would have left home half an hour earlier.'

Which sentence talks about a real possibility today? Which one imagines a different present? Which one looks back at a past moment that is already over? Now tell your partner one real plan for this week (using the first pattern) and one change you would make if you had an extra free day every week.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Zero and first conditionals: real facts and real future possibilities

When you talk about the real world — things that always happen or things that can genuinely happen tomorrow — keep the 'if' clause in the present tense.

Use the zero conditional (If + present, present) for scientific truths, rules of nature, and automatic habits. Use the first conditional (If + present, will + base verb) when a future condition is genuinely open and you are predicting or promising the result.

Pattern:

Zero conditional (always true): If / When + present simple, present simple
First conditional (real future possibility): If + present simple, will (or can / may / should) + base verb

Natural examples:

- If you heat ice above 0°C, it melts. (general law of nature)
- If I drink coffee after dinner, I don't sleep well. (personal habit that always holds true)
- If the weather stays clear tomorrow, we'll hike up to the ridge. (real future possibility)
- If you finish the draft by four, I can check it before I leave. (real condition with a modal result)

Keep in mind:

→ In an ordinary future condition, use the present simple in the if-clause: say 'If it rains tomorrow, we'll stay home' (do not use 'will' just because the event is in the future). Will can occur in if-clauses with a special meaning such as polite willingness ('If you will wait a moment, I'll fetch the director'), but ordinary future conditions take the present simple.

Rule 2 — Second conditional: imagining a different present or unlikely future

What if you want to talk about a situation that is not true right now, or a future scenario that you consider unlikely? English steps one tense back into the past simple in the 'if' clause, and uses 'would' (or 'could / might') in the result clause.

The past tense here does not point to yesterday — it signals distance from reality. When you say 'If I had her phone number, I would call her right now,' your listener immediately knows two things: you do not have the number now, and therefore you cannot call.

Pattern:

Second conditional: If + past simple, would / could / might + base verb → unreal present · unlikely future · hypothetical advice

Natural examples:

- If I had an extra hour every morning, I would read in English before work. (reality: I don't have that hour now)
- If I were you, I'd accept the fellowship offer immediately. (hypothetical advice)
- If public transport were faster, fewer commuters would drive into the city centre.

Keep in mind:

→ In advice and careful English, 'If I were you…' (and 'If he/she/it were…') is the conventional standard form. 'Was' also occurs in informal conversation ('If I was you…'), but 'If I were…' works well in every setting.

Rule 3 — Third and mixed conditionals: looking back at the past

The third conditional is our time machine for hindsight. Because the past is already finished, we step one level further back to the past perfect (If + had + past participle) and use 'would have + past participle' for the imagined past result.

Sometimes, however, a past choice still shapes your life right now. When a past event has a present result (or a permanent present trait caused a past action), we mix the two halves into a mixed conditional.

Pattern:

Third conditional (both halves in the past): If + past perfect, would / could / might have + past participle
Mixed (past cause → present result): If + past perfect, would + base verb (now)
Mixed (present trait → past result): If + past simple (always), would have + past participle (then)

Natural examples:

- If we had left ten minutes earlier, we wouldn't have missed the train. (third: we left late, and we missed it)
- If I had accepted that job in Herat, I would live there now. (mixed: past decision → present life)
- If she weren't so organized, the conference wouldn't have run so smoothly last week. (mixed: permanent trait → past result)

Keep in mind:

→ In natural spoken English, both 'had' and 'would' contract to 'd: 'If I'd known you were waiting, I'd have called.' Never put 'would have' inside the if-clause (say 'If I had known', not 'If I would have known').

Rule 4 — Beyond "if": unless, as long as, and provided that

You do not have to begin every condition with 'if'. When you want to set a clear boundary or exception, 'unless' means 'except if / if not', while 'as long as' and 'provided (that)' mean 'on the condition that'.

Pattern:

unless + affirmative verb = if … not · as long as / provided (that) = only if

Natural examples:

- You won't notice progress unless you practise speaking out loud. (= if you don't practise)
- I'm happy to lend you my notes as long as you return them by Thursday.
- Provided that everyone arrives on time, the meeting will finish by eleven.

Keep in mind:

→ Because 'unless' already means 'if not', do not add a second negative inside the unless-clause: say 'Unless you hurry, we'll be late' (not 'Unless you don't hurry').

Part 3 · See the Difference

First vs second vs third conditional — one situation across three worlds

Compare how a speaker uses three different conditionals depending on whether the opportunity is still open, unlikely, or already gone:

Option A	Option B	What changes in the speaker's mind
If I have time this afternoon, I'll help you.	If I had time this afternoon, I would help you.	1st conditional = real possibility (my schedule might allow it). 2nd conditional = unreal present (my afternoon is already full, so I am politely apologizing that I cannot).
If I knew her email, I would write to her.	If I had known her email yesterday, I would have written to her.	2nd conditional = present gap (I don't know it now). 3rd conditional = past hindsight (yesterday's chance has already passed).

Third conditional vs mixed conditional — where does the result live?

When you start a sentence with 'If I had slept earlier last night…', pause for a split second and ask: is the result also in the past, or is it happening right now?

Third conditional (past result)	Mixed conditional (present result)	How to choose
If I had slept earlier last night, I would have caught the eight o'clock bus.	If I had slept earlier last night, I wouldn't feel so tired right now.	Left (3rd): catching the bus was this morning (past). Right (mixed): feeling tired is right now (present).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. If you _____ (heat) pure water at sea level to 100°C, it _____ (boil).
2. If it _____ (rain) heavily tomorrow morning, we _____ (cancel) the outdoor training session.
3. If I _____ (be) in your position, I _____ (apologise) to the client in person.
4. If she _____ (leave) home fifteen minutes earlier, she _____ (not/miss) the train yesterday.
5. If I _____ (know) his new phone number, I _____ (call) him right now.
6. We _____ (go) for a walk along the river as long as the weather _____ (stay) dry.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite using unless: 'If you don't register before Friday, you can't attend the seminar.'
2. Rewrite as a third conditional: 'He didn't check the timetable, so he missed the ferry.'
3. Rewrite as a mixed conditional (past cause → present result): 'She didn't save enough money last year, so she can't buy the car now.'
4. Correct the mistake: 'If I will have free time tonight, I will review the vocabulary.'
5. Use a second conditional ('If I were you…') to advise a friend who wants to quit their job tomorrow without another offer.
6. Answer in your own words with a full second conditional sentence: What would you do if you were given a one-year scholarship to study anywhere?

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play a cause-and-effect chain game with your partner. You will build two short stories together, sentence by sentence, where the result of one speaker's conditional becomes the 'if' clause of the next speaker's sentence.

• Chain 1 (looking back and connecting to now): Start with 'If I had woken up an hour earlier this morning…' Build at least six connected sentences together, including both third and mixed conditionals.

• Chain 2 (imagining a change tomorrow): Start with 'If the internet stopped working across the whole city for a week…' Build six connected sentences exploring what people would do.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: If I had woken up an hour earlier this morning, I would have caught the early bus.

B: And if you had caught the early bus, you wouldn't have run into the morning traffic jam — so you would feel much more relaxed right now!

Your conversation goal: One shared story of at least six linked conditional sentences per pair, including one third and one mixed conditional, that both partners can retell in summary.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ conditional verb forms match the intended time (real future, unreal present, unreal past)

✓ includes at least one third conditional and one mixed conditional accurately

✓ each sentence builds logically on the partner's previous idea

✓ both partners contribute equally without reading from notes

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

In formal presentations, debates, and storytelling, English speakers often vary their conditional openings so they do not repeat the word 'if' in every sentence.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Keep one clear anchor sentence in mind for each conditional pattern: 'If you heat ice, it melts' (zero) · 'If it rains, we'll cancel' (first) · 'If I were you, I'd wait' (second) · 'If I'd known, I'd have come' (third).

• Practise saying the natural spoken contractions aloud ('If I'd known…', 'We'd have waited…', 'She wouldn't have minded') so three-part verbs roll off your tongue smoothly.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use inverted conditionals in formal talks by dropping 'if' and placing Should, Were, or Had at the start: 'Should you require any further details, please let us know' · 'Had we known about the shortage, we would have ordered earlier.'

• Use 'but for + noun phrase' as a compact alternative to a negative conditional clause: 'But for your timely advice, we would have signed the wrong contract.'

• Use 'suppose' or 'supposing (that)' when inviting a listener to explore a scenario with you: 'Suppose our budget were cut by twenty percent — which project would we protect first?'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to assign each conditional a clear job for your talk: a first conditional for the realistic outcome of your choice, a second conditional for an option you are rejecting, and a third or mixed conditional for a lesson learned from last year. Jot down only three or four keywords.

Speak without reading: One-minute decision talk: Imagine your school or workplace has received a special grant. You must choose ONE of three investments: (1) staff training, (2) new computer equipment, or (3) a student resource library. Explain what will happen if you choose your top option, why the second option is less effective, and what you would have done differently with last year's budget.

Model response — speak first, then compare

If we invest this grant in staff training, our whole team will improve their teaching skills, and students will feel the benefit within a month. Buying new computers would look impressive at first, but if I were leading the committee, I would put people ahead of hardware every time. In fact, if we had set aside a small training fund last year, we wouldn't be facing such a steep learning curve with the new curriculum right now. Provided that we schedule the workshops before the new term starts, training is by far the smartest choice.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses a first conditional for realistic future consequences

✓ uses a second conditional to weigh a hypothetical alternative or give advice

✓ uses a third or mixed conditional to reflect on a past decision

✓ connects the options into a persuasive, logical recommendation

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Zero conditional states general truths; first conditional predicts real future possibilities (using the present simple after 'if').

• Second conditional ('If + past, would + verb') imagines an unreal present or unlikely future; 'If I were you…' is the classic advice frame.

• Third conditional ('If + had + participle, would have + participle') looks back at an unchangeable past; mixed conditionals connect a past cause to a present result.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'If it will rain tomorrow, we'll stay in.' → 'If it rains tomorrow, we'll stay in.' (Use present simple for ordinary future conditions.)

→ 'Unless you don't hurry, you'll miss the bus.' → 'Unless you hurry, you'll miss the bus.' ('Unless' already means 'if not'.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Say one sentence of your own for each conditional type: zero, first, second, third, and mixed.

• Take one real mistake or delay from your past month and turn it into a third conditional sentence.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can distinguish smoothly between an unreal present (second conditional) and an unreal past (third conditional).

☐ I can link a past decision to a present result using a mixed conditional.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 5 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. heat / boils · 2. rains / will cancel (or: 'll cancel) · 3. were / would apologise · 4. had left / wouldn't have missed · 5. knew / would call · 6. will go / stays

Practice B: 1. Unless you register before Friday, you can't attend the seminar. · 2. If he had checked the timetable, he wouldn't have missed the ferry. · 3. If she had saved enough money last year, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy the car now. · 4. If I have free time tonight, I will review the vocabulary. · 5. answers vary (e.g. 'If I were you, I wouldn't resign until I had a signed offer in hand.') · 6. answers vary

LESSON 6 · WISHES, REGRETS, AND HYPOTHETICAL SITUATIONS

Part 3 — Think Beyond the Present | Speaking goal: express preferences, dissatisfaction, regrets and imagined alternatives naturally

When you hope something will happen tomorrow, you stay in the real world: 'I hope the bus comes soon.' When you wish something were different right now, you already know reality is the opposite: 'I wish I had an umbrella with me' (said while standing in the rain with no umbrella).

Because wishes, regrets, and polite preferences often describe a world that does not match reality, English uses the same clever device you saw in conditionals: stepping one tense back in time to signal that you are imagining an alternative.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Compare these three sentences spoken by a student on the morning of an exam:

- 'I wish I knew the answer to question four.' (during the exam)
- 'I wish I had studied chapter seven last night.' (looking back at yesterday evening)
- 'I wish the person behind me would stop tapping their pen.' (reacting to an annoying noise)

With a partner, discuss how the speaker feels in each sentence and what time each sentence points to. Then share one skill you wish you had right now and one small decision from the past year you would handle differently.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Wishing for a different present: wish + past simple, could, or would

When you want your current reality to be different right now, follow 'wish' (or the more emphatic 'If only') with the past simple: 'I wish I spoke Arabic fluently' means 'I do not speak it fluently right now.'

When the wish is about your own ability, use 'could' ('I wish I could stay longer'). When you want someone else — or an outside situation — to change their behaviour, use 'would' ('I wish you would listen before interrupting').

Pattern:

Present state wish: wish / if only + past simple → I wish I knew her address. (reality: I don't know it)
Present ability wish: wish / if only + could + base verb → I wish I could join you.
Desired change in behaviour/situation: wish / if only + somebody/something + would + base verb

Natural examples:

- I wish our flat were closer to the university. (were is the traditional subjunctive and common in careful English; was is also widespread informally: I wish our flat was closer.)
- I wish I could remember where I put that folder.
- I wish the neighbours wouldn't play loud music after midnight.

Keep in mind:

→ Use 'wish + would' when you want someone else's behaviour or an outside situation to change (it often carries a note of impatience or complaint). We do not say 'I wish I would…' about ourselves — for our own ability, use 'I wish I could…'.

Rule 2 — Wishing for a different past: regrets with wish + past perfect

When a moment is already in the past and you regret what happened (or didn't happen), step one level further back to the past perfect: 'wish + had + past participle'.

'If only…!' uses the exact same grammar as 'I wish…', but adds stronger personal emotion.

Pattern:

Past regret: wish / if only + had (not) + past participle → I wish I had started earlier.

Natural examples:

• I wish I had asked more questions during the training week.
• She wishes she hadn't spoken so sharply during the argument.
• If only we had checked the road conditions before setting off!

Keep in mind:

→ Never use 'wish + past simple' for a finished past event: for yesterday's mistake, say 'I wish I hadn't said that yesterday' (not 'I wish I didn't say that yesterday').

Rule 3 — Expressing preferences and overdue actions: would rather and it's time

'Would rather' changes its grammar depending on who is doing the action. When you talk about your own preference, use the base verb: 'I'd rather walk than wait for the bus.' When you want someone else to do something, introduce a new subject and step back to the past simple: 'I'd rather you didn't mention this to anyone yet.'

Similarly, 'It's time' (or 'It's high time') followed by a subject and a past simple verb means an action is already overdue — it should have happened before now: 'It's ten o'clock — it's time we headed home.'

Pattern:

Same subject (my own action): would rather (not) + base verb (than …) → I'd rather stay in tonight.
Different subject (someone else's action): would rather + person + past simple → I'd rather you called me tomorrow.
Overdue action: It is (high / about) time + subject + past simple → It's high time we made a decision.

Natural examples:

• I'd rather cook a simple meal at home than wait an hour at a crowded restaurant.
• I'd rather you didn't park in front of the gate — the delivery lorry needs to get through.
• It's high time the city council repaired this bridge.

Keep in mind:

→ Do not confuse 'would rather' (preference) with 'had better + base verb' (strong urgent warning: 'You'd better leave now or you'll miss your flight').

Rule 4 — Comparing preferences and describing impressions: prefer and as if / as though

With 'prefer', watch how you connect the two options: 'prefer A to B' (with nouns or -ing forms) versus 'would prefer to do A rather than do B'.

With 'as if' and 'as though', use the past simple or past perfect when the comparison is unreal or exaggerated: 'He gives orders as if he owned the company' (he does not own it).

Pattern:

General preference: prefer + noun/-ing + to + noun/-ing · Specific choice: would prefer + to + verb + rather than + base verb
Unreal impression: act / look / talk + as if / as though + past simple (present unreal) or past perfect (past unreal)

Natural examples:

• I generally prefer reading printed books to reading on a screen.
• Today I'd prefer to walk rather than take a taxi.
• She walked back into the meeting room calmly, as though nothing had happened.

Keep in mind:

→ If what follows 'as if' is a real, likely fact based on evidence, keep the normal present tense: 'Look at those dark clouds — it looks as if it is going to pour.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Present wish vs past regret — stepping back in time

Notice how the verb form after 'wish' tells the listener immediately whether the situation can still be changed today or belongs to the past:

wish + past simple (present reality)	wish + past perfect (past regret)	What the listener understands
I wish I had a quieter room to study in.	I wish I had chosen a quieter room when we moved in.	Left (past simple): my room is noisy right now. Right (past perfect): I am looking back with regret at the past choice I made.
I wish I knew how to fix this engine.	I wish I had learned how to fix engines at college.	Left: I am stuck in front of the engine right now. Right: I regret missing the opportunity years ago.

wish + could vs wish + would — ability vs willingness

wish + could (personal ability)	wish + would (other person's choice)	Why the choice matters
I wish I could come to your graduation.	I wish you would come to my graduation.	'Could' points to inability (I have an exam that day, so I am unable to attend). 'Would' appeals to the other person's willingness (you are free, and I want you to decide to come).

Three ways to use 'It's time' — from neutral to urgent

Compare the tone of these three sentences:

1. 'It's time to leave.' (neutral statement — the scheduled moment has arrived).
2. 'It's time we left.' (gently insistent — we are already a little late).
3. 'It's high time he took responsibility for his work.' (emphatic criticism — this is long overdue).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. I wish I _____ (know) her email address so I could send her the invitation right now.
2. I really wish I _____ (not/say) that careless remark during yesterday's meeting.
3. He gives everyone instructions as if he _____ (own) the entire department.
4. It's high time we _____ (make) a firm decision about the autumn budget.
5. I'd rather you _____ (not/tell) anyone about the job offer until the contract is signed.
6. If only I _____ (be) a little more patient when traffic slows down!

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite as a past regret using wish: 'I didn't study harder at school, and now I regret it.'
2. Rewrite politely using would rather: 'Please don't smoke near the doorway.'
3. Correct the tense mistake: 'I wish I have more free time this semester.'
4. Correct the tense mistake: 'It's already midnight — it's time we will go home.'
5. Choose the natural forms: I generally prefer (reading / to read) historical novels to (watch / watching) television.
6. Write one vivid sentence with 'as if' or 'as though' describing a friend who arrived late and out of breath.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'The Constructive Adviser' with your partner. Partner A shares three honest frustrations or regrets from everyday life using 'I wish…', 'If only…', or 'I'd rather…'. Partner B listens, asks one clarifying question, and offers a practical step forward using 'It's time…', 'You could…', or 'If I were you…'. Swap roles after two minutes.

• Choose three areas from: study habits · work-life balance · health and sleep · learning English · technology use.

• Include at least one present wish (wish + past simple/could/would), one past regret (wish + past perfect), and one response with 'It's time we/you…' or 'I'd rather…'.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: I wish I didn't spend so much time checking my phone late at night — I always wake up tired.

B: I know that feeling. It's about time we both left our phones in another room after ten o'clock. If you bought a simple alarm clock, you wouldn't need your phone beside your bed at all.

Your conversation goal: Three complaint–solution exchanges per role: each complaint uses a correct wish form, each solution a natural modal or 'it's time', and partners swap roles smoothly.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ distinguishes accurately between present wishes (wish + past) and past regrets (wish + past perfect)

✓ uses 'It's time + past simple', 'would rather', and advice modals naturally

✓ reacts thoughtfully to the partner's situation rather than reading a list

✓ both partners complete all three exchanges in each role

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Notice how skilled speakers use these same hypothetical patterns to soften workplace requests, add emotional colour to stories, and express diplomatic dissatisfaction.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Separate your own real-life wishes into two clear mental buckets: what you wish were different today ('I wish I knew / had / could…') versus what you wish had happened differently in the past ('I wish I had known / done…').

• Say three true sentences aloud right now: one with 'I wish I knew…', one with 'I wish I had known…', and one with 'I'd rather you…'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use 'If only…!' when you want to convey stronger personal feeling or dramatic emphasis in a story: 'If only we had backed up the files before the power cut!'

• Use past-continuous framing ('We were hoping…', 'I was wondering…') to express diplomatic wishes in professional settings: 'We were hoping the figures would be ready before Friday.'

• Use 'as though' with the past perfect to describe revealing body language in a narrative: 'He greeted everyone cheerfully, as though the argument the night before had never happened.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to note three keywords: one genuine past regret that taught you something useful (wish + past perfect), one present habit or skill you still wish to change (wish + past simple / could), and one practical piece of advice for someone younger.

Speak without reading: Speak for one full minute: 'A mistake or regret that taught me an important lesson.' Describe what you wish you had done differently in the past, what you still wish you could do better today, and what advice you would give a younger student facing the same choice.

Model response — speak first, then compare

I wish I had taken spoken English seriously during my first two years at university — I wasted countless classes staying silent because I was afraid of making small grammar slips. Even today, I sometimes wish I could express complex technical ideas as effortlessly as my mentor does. But that regret taught me something valuable: fluency only grows when you use the language out loud. It's high time we stopped treating mistakes as failures. If I were advising a first-year student today, I'd tell them to record themselves speaking for two minutes every week — within a month, you can hear the difference.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses 'wish + past perfect' (or 'If only + past perfect') accurately for the past regret

✓ uses 'wish + past simple' or 'wish + could' for the present situation

✓ turns the regret into constructive advice using a conditional, modal, or 'It's time…'

✓ speaks naturally and reflectively without reading from notes

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Use 'wish + past simple / could' for present situations you want to be different; use 'wish + past perfect' for regrets about a finished past.

• Use 'wish + person/thing + would' when you want someone else's behaviour or an external situation to change.

• When 'would rather' or 'It's (high) time' is followed by a subject, step back to the past simple ('I'd rather you waited' · 'It's time we left').

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'I wish I have more time.' → 'I wish I had more time.' (Present wishes step back to the past form.)

→ 'I'd rather you don't mention this.' → 'I'd rather you didn't mention this.' (Use past simple after a new subject.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Say one honest present wish and one honest past regret from your own life.

• State one preference about your own evening ('I'd rather…') and one polite preference about someone else's action ('I'd rather you…').

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can express both present wishes and past regrets without mixing up their verb tenses.

☐ I can use 'would rather', 'It's high time', and 'as if' naturally in conversation.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 6 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. knew · 2. hadn't said · 3. owned · 4. made · 5. didn't tell · 6. were (or: was in informal speech)

Practice B: 1. I wish I had studied harder at school. · 2. I'd rather you didn't smoke near the doorway. · 3. I wish I had more free time this semester. · 4. It's already midnight — it's time we went home. · 5. reading / watching · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'He burst through the door out of breath, as if he had run all the way from the station.')

LESSON 7 · COMPARISONS BEYOND THE BASICS

Part 4 — Compare and Persuade | Speaking goal: compare clearly and support comparisons with reasons

When someone says, 'Option A is better than Option B,' they have stated an opinion, but they have not yet persuaded anyone. Compare that with: 'Option A is far more reliable than Option B because it costs half as much to maintain, and the longer we use it, the more money we save.'

Every real-world recommendation — choosing a university course, hiring a candidate, defending a budget — is built on comparison. When you combine accurate comparative forms with precise degree words and clear reasons, your opinions turn into persuasive arguments.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these two pairs of claims aloud with a partner:

• 'Train travel is better than flying.' vs. 'On short routes, train travel is far more relaxing than flying because you avoid airport security queues.'

• 'Vocabulary is important.' vs. 'The more actively you use new vocabulary in speech, the faster it becomes permanent.'

Now take one minute each to compare two ways of learning (studying alone vs studying in a group, or learning online vs in a classroom). Give at least one specific reason for your choice.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Comparatives and superlatives: comparing choices vs identifying an extreme

Comparatives compare two people, things, or sets ('shorter than', 'more practical than'), while superlatives single out an extreme within a group ('the shortest', 'the most practical'). Use a comparative to compare two people, things or sets. Use a superlative to identify an extreme within a group, which often contains three or more. The exact number is a guide, not a grammatical rule: context and meaning decide.

Short one-syllable adjectives (and many two-syllable adjectives ending in -y, like easy → easier) take '-er' and 'the -est'. Longer adjectives of two or more syllables take 'more' and 'the most' (or 'less' and 'the least').

Pattern:

Short adjectives: adj-er + than · the + adj-est (fast → faster → the fastest · busy → busier → the busiest)
Longer adjectives & adverbs: more/less + adj/adv + than · the most/least + adj/adv
Irregular forms: good/well → better → the best · bad/badly → worse → the worst · far → further/farther → the furthest/farthest

Natural examples:

• Taking the ring road is quicker than driving through the old bazaar.

• She explained the financial plan more clearly than the previous consultant.

• That was the most challenging — and the most rewarding — project of my career.

Keep in mind:

→ Never stack 'more' and '-er' together: say 'much taller' or 'far better' (never 'more taller' or 'more better').

→ Spell and pronounce the comparison link as 'than' (not 'then', which refers to time).

Rule 2 — Equality, multiples, and linked change: as … as and the more …, the more …

Not every comparison says one thing is bigger or better than another. Sometimes you want to show that two options are equal ('as effective as'), that one falls short ('not as expensive as'), or that one is a specific multiple of the other ('twice as fast as').

When two changes move together in cause and effect, English uses the double-comparative frame 'The + comparative …, the + comparative …': 'The more you speak out loud, the more natural the grammar feels.'

Pattern:

Equality & gap: (not) as + adjective/adverb + as · twice / three times / half + as + adj/adv + as
Linked change: The + comparative …, the + comparative …
Continuous trend: comparative + and + comparative (faster and faster · more and more competitive)

Natural examples:

• This compact dictionary is just as comprehensive as the heavy two-volume edition.
• Practising aloud for twenty minutes is twice as effective as rereading notes silently for an hour.
• The earlier we leave tomorrow morning, the less traffic we will face on the highway.
• Solar panels are becoming more and more affordable every year.

Keep in mind:

→ Inside 'as … as', keep the adjective or adverb in its base form: 'twice as expensive as' (not 'twice more expensive than').
→ In 'the more …, the more …', both halves must use a comparative form: 'The harder you prepare, the calmer you feel.'

Rule 3 — Calibrating your comparison: degree words that persuade

Saying 'Course A is better than Course B' leaves your listener wondering: is it 2% better or 200% better? Adding a precise modifier in front of your comparative or superlative ('far more practical', 'slightly more expensive', 'by far the best') shows that you have weighed the evidence carefully.

Pattern:

Large difference: far / much / a great deal / значительно → significantly + comparative
Small difference: slightly / a little / marginally + comparative · almost / nearly as … as
Emphatic superlative: by far + the + superlative · easily + the + superlative

Natural examples:

• The evening train is slightly slower than the express bus, but it is far more comfortable.
• This year's results were not nearly as predictable as last year's.
• Deliberate speaking practice is by far the most effective way to build fluency.

Keep in mind:

→ Always compare like with like: compare one city's climate with another city's climate ('The winter here is milder than in Bamyan' or 'than Bamyan's winter'), and back up every major comparison with 'because…'.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Comparative vs superlative — weighing two options vs crowning a standout

Comparative (weighing choices)	Superlative (extreme in a group)	How the meaning shifts
This textbook is clearer than the one we used last term.	This is the clearest textbook in the department library.	Comparatives weigh options against each other; superlatives identify an extreme within a whole group or category.
The northern route isfar safer than the mountain pass in winter.	The northern route is by far the safest option in winter.	'Far' intensifies a comparative ('far safer'); 'by far' intensifies a superlative ('by far the safest').

Small modifiers that flip the meaning of "as … as"

Expression A	Expression B	What your listener hears
The second exam was just as difficult as the first.	The second exam was not nearly as difficult as the first.	'Just as' means 100% equal in difficulty; 'not nearly as' means the second exam was much easier.
The sooner we start, the better.	Sooner or later, we will have to start.	'The sooner, the better' links speed to a better result; 'sooner or later' simply means 'eventually'.

Turning a flat opinion into a persuasive comparison

Whenever you compare two ideas in a speaking test or meeting, use this three-step formula: 1. Degree modifier + comparative ('Studying in short daily sessions is far more effective than weekend cramming…') 2. Concrete reason ('…because your brain consolidates memory between sessions…') 3. Linked outcome ('…and the more consistently you review, the less you forget under exam pressure.')

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. Taking the side street is _____ (short) than waiting at the main roundabout.
2. Waiting six hours at a freezing bus station was _____ (bad) travel experience of my life.
3. The _____ (much) you read in English, the _____ (fast) your vocabulary grows.
4. She presented the team's findings _____ (confidently) than anyone expected.
5. Repairing the old generator is not _____ expensive _____ buying a brand-new one.
6. He is by far the _____ (talented) debater in our graduating class.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite using twice as … as: 'The new battery lasts two times longer than the old one.'
2. Correct the mistake: 'My younger brother is more taller than me now.'
3. Strengthen this comparison with 'far' and add a 'because' reason: 'Practising with a partner is better than studying alone.'
4. Build a 'The more …, the more …' sentence of your own about building confidence in speaking.
5. Correct the spelling/usage mistake: 'This dictionary is much clearer then my old one.'
6. Compare three cities or towns you know: use a comparative to contrast two of them, and a superlative to name which one you would most like to live in and why.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'The Persuasive Recommender'. Each partner has 30 seconds to recommend one choice in the same category (for example, the best time of day to study, the best way to travel across the country, or the most useful skill for a young graduate). Then debate your choices politely and agree on one joint recommendation.

• In your recommendation, include at least: one comparative with a degree word (far, much, slightly), one superlative (or 'by far the…'), and one 'as … as' or 'the more …, the more …' sentence.

• Every comparison must be supported by a concrete reason ('because…'). Finish by agreeing on one winner together.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: Studying early in the morning is far more productive than studying late at night because your mind is fresh and the house is quiet.

B: Morning study is quieter, that's true, but for me evening study is just as effective as long as I turn off my phone. Still, I agree that the earlier you finish your hardest task, the better the rest of your day feels.

Your conversation goal: Two 30-second recommendations, each containing at least three accurate comparisons with reasons, followed by one agreed joint choice stated aloud.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ comparative and superlative forms are accurate (no double comparatives)

✓ every comparison is backed up by a clear reason

✓ uses at least two degree modifiers (far, much, slightly, by far, not nearly)

✓ reaches and states a polite joint recommendation at the end

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

In academic discussions and professional presentations, speakers rarely make one-sided comparisons; instead, they acknowledge what the other option does well before showing why their choice is stronger.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Master the irregular trios aloud until they are automatic: good / better / the best · bad / worse / the worst · far / further / the furthest.

• Practise pairing degree modifiers with real items in front of you: 'slightly heavier than', 'far more durable than', 'not nearly as complicated as'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use emphatic superlative frames for confident evaluation: 'by far the most practical solution' · 'the single most important factor' · 'the least likely outcome'.

• Use concessive comparisons to sound fair and persuasive: 'While Option A is slightly cheaper upfront, Option B is far better value in the long run.'

• Use 'Compared with…' or 'In contrast to…' at the start of a sentence to frame evidence cleanly: 'Compared with five years ago, access to online courses has grown dramatically.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to pick one topic below and jot down three comparison keywords: one 'far / much + comparative', one 'by far + superlative', and one 'the more …, the more …' or 'twice as … as' pattern, plus one brief reason for each.

Speak without reading: One-minute persuasion talk: Argue for your view on ONE of these questions — (1) What is the best age to start learning a second language? (2) What is the most effective way to prepare for a high-stakes speaking test? or (3) What is the smartest investment of one free hour every day?

Model response — speak first, then compare

In my view, early childhood is the easiest age to pick up natural pronunciation, because young children imitate sounds far more effortlessly than adults and are much less afraid of making mistakes. However, when it comes to using one hour a day as an adult learner, deliberate speaking practice is by far the most valuable investment you can make. Speaking aloud with a partner is twice as effective as silent review because you get immediate feedback when a sentence is unclear. Compared with memorizing word lists alone, real conversation builds habits that last — and the more regularly you speak, the more natural your grammar becomes.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ accurate comparative, superlative, and equality forms throughout

✓ every comparison is supported by a clear reason or example

✓ uses degree words naturally to calibrate strength (far, much, twice as, by far)

✓ closes with a memorable conclusion that answers the prompt directly

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Comparatives compare two choices; superlatives identify an extreme within a group; 'as … as' expresses equality or multiples ('twice as fast as').

• 'The + comparative …, the + comparative …' links two changing processes together.

• Degree modifiers ('far', 'much', 'slightly', 'by far') and 'because' reasons turn flat opinions into persuasive arguments.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'She is more taller than me.' → 'She is taller than me.' (Never use 'more' with an -er comparative.)

→ 'This route is faster then the highway.' → 'This route is faster than the highway.' ('Than' compares; 'then' marks time.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Make one comparison using 'far more … than' and one sentence using 'The more …, the more …'.

• Name three skills or subjects you have studied, rank them using superlatives, and give one reason for your top choice.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can use comparatives, superlatives, and 'as … as' patterns accurately with degree modifiers.

☐ I can support my spoken comparisons with clear reasons and 'the more ..., the more ...' sentences.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 7 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. shorter · 2. the worst · 3. more / faster · 4. more confidently · 5. as / as · 6. most talented

Practice B: 1. The new battery lasts twice as long as the old one. · 2. My younger brother is taller than me now. · 3. Practising with a partner is far better than studying alone because you have to respond in real time. (answers vary) · 4. answers vary (e.g. 'The more often you speak in class, the more confident you feel.') · 5. This dictionary is much clearer than my old one. · 6. answers vary

LESSON 8 · LINKING IDEAS AND BUILDING ARGUMENTS

Part 4 — Compare and Persuade | Speaking goal: organise opinions into coherent, well-linked spoken arguments

Have you ever listened to a speaker who had intelligent ideas, yet after thirty seconds you lost track of what they were trying to prove? Usually the problem is not their vocabulary — it is that their sentences arrive with no turn-signals.

Linking words (although, despite, because of, therefore, for instance, to sum up) are the turn-signals of spoken English. They warn your listener in advance whether your next thought is a reason, a concrete example, a concession to the other side, or your final conclusion.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Listen to the difference between these two ways of expressing the same view:

• Speaker A: 'Online courses are popular. Some students drop out. They miss classroom discussion. Online courses save travel time. I think blended learning is best.'

• Speaker B: 'Although online courses save valuable travel time, many students drop out because they miss live classroom discussion. Therefore, I believe a blended approach works best.'

Read both versions aloud with a partner. Then speak for 30 seconds each on 'Why people in our city learn English' while your partner counts how many different linking expressions you use naturally.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Contrast and concession: although vs despite vs however

When you want to show an unexpected contrast between two facts, English gives you three tools — and each tool requires a different grammatical package after it.

Use 'although' or 'even though' before a full clause (subject + verb). Use 'despite' or 'in spite of' before a noun phrase or an -ing verb form (never a bare subject + verb). Use 'however', 'nevertheless', or 'on the other hand' to open a brand-new sentence (or clause after a semicolon), followed by a comma.

Pattern:

Clause linker: Although / Even though + subject + verb, main clause
Noun / -ing linker: Despite / In spite of + noun phrase or verb-ing, main clause
Sentence connector: First sentence. However, / Nevertheless, / On the other hand, second sentence.

Natural examples:

• Although the snow was heavy, the morning bus arrived on schedule. (subject 'the snow' + verb 'was')
• Despite the heavy snow, the morning bus arrived on schedule. (noun phrase 'the heavy snow')
• Despite waking up with a migraine, she delivered her presentation clearly. (-ing form)
• The proposal involves some initial risk. Nevertheless, the committee voted to approve it.

Keep in mind:

→ Never mix 'despite' and 'in spite of' into 'despite of' — say either 'despite the delay' or 'in spite of the delay'.

→ If you want to put a subject + verb after 'despite', insert 'the fact that': 'Despite the fact that it was snowing, we went out.'

Rule 2 — Cause, result, and purpose: matching the grammar to the linker

Just like contrast linkers, cause linkers divide into a clause family and a noun family. Use 'because', 'since', or 'as' before a full clause (subject + verb); use 'because of', 'due to', or 'owing to' before a noun phrase.

To introduce a logical consequence, use 'therefore', 'as a result', or 'consequently'. To express the purpose of an action, use 'in order to / to + base verb' or 'so that + subject + modal verb'.

Pattern:

Cause (+ clause): because / since / as + subject + verb · Cause (+ noun): because of / due to + noun phrase
Result: therefore / as a result / consequently · Purpose: in order to + verb · so that + subject + can/could/will/would

Natural examples:

• We postponed the match because the pitch was flooded. (+ full clause)
• We postponed the match because of / due to the flooded pitch. (+ noun phrase)
• Public libraries extended their evening hours; as a result, student attendance doubled.
• I recorded the lecture so that my classmate could listen to it while recovering at home.

Keep in mind:

→ Keep 'because' and 'therefore' in separate jobs: 'because' introduces the reason, while 'therefore' introduces the result. Do not use both to join the same two clauses.

Rule 3 — Building an argument you can deliver out loud

When you are asked for your opinion in a meeting, interview, or speaking exam, do not just state what you think and stop. Give your listener a clear four-step architecture: state your Point, explain your Reason, make it concrete with an Example, and close with a short Link or Summary.

Three well-connected sentences with a real example are far more persuasive than ten disconnected claims.

Pattern:

1. POINT: I firmly believe that … / In my view, … → 2. REASON: This is mainly because …
3. EXAMPLE: For instance, … / To give a concrete example, … → 4. ADDITION: Moreover, … / What is more, …

Natural examples:

• In my view, every university course should include short weekly presentations. This is mainly because graduates need to explain their ideas clearly at work. For instance, in my cousin's engineering firm, junior staff present project updates every Monday. Moreover, regular practice removes the fear of speaking in public.

Keep in mind:

→ Acknowledge the other side briefly before stating your main point ('Although exams test individual memory, presentations prepare students for real teamwork') — a speaker who addresses counterarguments sounds fair and authoritative.

Rule 4 — Ordering points and landing a memorable summary

When your listener cannot see your notes, verbal signposts ('First of all…', 'Another key factor is…', 'To sum up…') act like headings for the ear and make your conclusion stick.

Pattern:

Sequencing points: First of all, … · Secondly, … · Another key point is that …
Closing summary: To sum up, … · All in all, … · In short, …

Natural examples:

• To sum up, the long-term benefits of staff training clearly outweigh the initial cost.
• All in all, I would recommend starting with a two-week pilot programme.

Keep in mind:

→ Listeners remember the last sentence you say best — always finish an opinion talk with a crisp summary line.

Part 3 · See the Difference

One contrast, three grammatical packages: although vs despite vs however

See how the exact same idea changes its grammatical shape depending on which linker you choose:

although + clause	despite + noun / -ing	however + new clause	How the grammar works
Although the traffic was heavy, we arrived on time.	Despite the heavy traffic, we arrived on time.	The traffic was heavy; however, we arrived on time.	'Although' takes a subject + verb ('the traffic was'); 'Despite' takes a noun phrase ('the heavy traffic'); 'However' opens the second independent clause.

because (+ clause) vs because of (+ noun)

because + subject + verb	because of + noun phrase	What changes
Because she worked tirelessly, the clinic succeeded.	Because of her tireless work, the clinic succeeded.	Adding 'of' turns 'because' into a prepositional phrase, so it must be followed by a noun phrase ('her tireless work') rather than a verb.

Direct contrast (while / whereas) vs concession (although)

Use 'while' or 'whereas' when you are simply placing two different facts side by side on a scale: 'My brother enjoys bustling city life, whereas I prefer quiet mountain towns.'

Use 'although' or 'even though' when the first fact makes the second fact surprising: 'Although I usually prefer quiet mountain towns, I really enjoyed my year working in the capital.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. _____ the heavy morning traffic, everyone arrived at the examination centre on time. (Despite / Although)

2. _____ feeling exhausted after the night shift, she stayed to brief the morning nurse. (Despite / Although)

3. He failed his first driving test; _____, he practised every afternoon and passed the next month. (however / despite)

4. We left home at six in the morning _____ we could cross the pass before midday. (so that / because of)

5. The main highway was closed by snow. _____, all flights out of the valley were fully booked. (As a result / Although)

6. I prefer working in a quiet library, _____ my study partner learns best by discussing ideas aloud. (whereas / despite)

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Combine into one sentence using although: 'The assignment was challenging. Every group finished on time.'

2. Combine into one sentence using despite + -ing (or a noun phrase): 'She was not selected the first time. She applied again the following year.'

3. Correct the mistake: 'Despite of the high cost, the hospital purchased the new scanner.'

4. Build a three-sentence spoken argument (Point → Reason → Example) supporting the statement: 'Reading widely improves spoken English.'

5. Correct the mistake in two different ways: 'Although the rain, the football match continued.'

6. State two brief advantages of technology in education, then close with a summary sentence starting with 'To sum up,' or 'All in all,'.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Hold a polite two-minute mini-debate with your partner on the motion below. First, Partner A argues in favour and Partner B argues against; after two minutes, switch sides and argue the opposite position so you practise seeing both sides of an issue.

• Debate motion: 'Written homework in language classes should be replaced by daily recorded speaking practice.'

• In each turn, follow the argument skeleton (Point → Reason → Example), acknowledge one point from your partner's side using 'Although…' or 'Despite…', and close with a clear summary sentence.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: I believe daily speaking recordings are far more useful than traditional worksheets. This is because learners need active retrieval under real-time pressure. For instance, when I started recording a two-minute voice note every evening, I noticed my hesitation dropping within two weeks.

B: Although voice recordings build fluency, written homework is still essential because it gives learners time to notice spelling and complex sentence structure...

Your conversation goal: One two-minute mini-debate per role: a clear point with reason and example, one answer to the other side, and a closing summary — followed by a one-sentence verdict you both accept.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ uses contrast and concession linkers accurately (especially despite + noun/-ing vs although + clause)

✓ follows a clear Point → Reason → Example structure

✓ acknowledges and responds to the partner's counterargument

✓ lands a clear closing summary before agreeing on a balanced verdict

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Strong speakers do not use more linking words — they use the exact right linker to show how two ideas relate, and they use concessive balance to win over skeptical listeners.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Group your linkers by their job in conversation: contrast (although, despite, however, whereas) · cause (because, since, due to) · result (therefore, as a result) · example and summary (for instance, to sum up).

• Practise expressing the same real-life contrast in both grammatical shapes aloud: 'Although the course was demanding…' and 'Despite the demanding course…'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use 'Not only … but also …' (with inversion when placed at the start of a formal sentence) to build momentum: 'Not only did the programme reduce costs, but it also improved staff morale.'

• Use two-step concessive frames to sound fair and measured in debates: 'It is certainly true that…; nevertheless, …' or 'Admittedly, the initial cost is high; even so, the long-term savings are substantial.'

• Use ', which…' at the end of a clause to comment on the whole consequence of an event: 'The director answered every question openly, which immediately put the staff at ease.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 45 seconds to write down four keywords only: your main claim, two reasons (with one real personal example in mind), and one concession to another viewpoint. Choose your four linkers before you start speaking (for example: because · for instance · although / despite · to sum up).

Speak without reading: Ninety-second opinion talk: 'What makes a truly effective teacher or mentor?' State your main claim, support it with two reasons and a concrete example from your own experience, acknowledge one competing view, and finish with a memorable summary — without looking at notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare

I believe what makes a truly effective teacher is clear, honest feedback combined with patience. This is because learners improve fastest when they know exactly what to adjust without feeling discouraged. For instance, my first English instructor corrected our pronunciation habits every day with a warm smile, and as a result our whole class gained confidence within a month. Although entertaining games can make a classroom lively, I would trade entertainment for clear guidance any day. To sum up, a great teacher shows you the next step clearly and makes you believe you can take it.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ clear Point → Reason → Example → Summary architecture throughout the talk

✓ accurate use of contrast/concession linkers (although + clause or despite + noun/-ing)

✓ natural cause and result connections (because, as a result, therefore)

✓ a crisp closing summary that leaves a clear final impression

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Use 'although / even though' before a full clause (subject + verb); use 'despite / in spite of' before a noun phrase or -ing form; use 'however' to open a new sentence.

• Use 'because' before a clause and 'because of / due to' before a noun phrase; use 'therefore / as a result' for consequences.

• Build spoken arguments on a four-part skeleton: Point → Reason → Example → Summary.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'Despite of the delay, we arrived.' → 'Despite the delay…' or 'In spite of the delay…' (Never say 'despite of'.)

→ 'Although the high price, we bought it.' → 'Despite the high price, we bought it' or 'Although the price was high, we bought it.'

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Deliver a 20-second argument on any everyday topic using 'because', 'for instance', and 'to sum up'.

• Express the same contrast idea in three ways aloud: once with 'although', once with 'despite', and once with 'however'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can switch smoothly between clause linkers (although, because) and noun/-ing linkers (despite, because of).

☐ I can organize an unscripted 90-second opinion into a clear Point → Reason → Example → Summary structure.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 8 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. Despite · 2. Despite (followed by -ing; 'Although' needs a subject + verb: 'Although she felt exhausted') · 3. however · 4. so that · 5. As a result · 6. whereas

Practice B: 1. Although the assignment was challenging, every group finished on time. · 2. Despite not being selected the first time, she applied again the following year. / Despite the initial rejection, she applied again. · 3. Despite the high cost, the hospital purchased the new scanner. · 4. answers vary — must include a clear point, a reason, and an example · 5. Despite the rain, the football match continued. / Although it was raining, the football match continued. · 6. answers vary — must close with To sum up / All in all / In conclusion

REVIEW TEST 2

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–8 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. If I _____ (know) his number, I would call him now.
2. I wish I _____ (take) that opportunity last year.
3. This method is _____ (effective) than the old one.
4. While I _____ (read — ongoing action), the lights went out.
5. When we arrived, the guests _____ (already / leave).
6. It's high time we _____ (make) a decision.
7. This option is by far the _____ (good) for our budget.
8. Unless you _____ (hurry), you'll miss the bus.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. Combine with despite: 'The exam was hard. Everyone passed.'
2. Rewrite as a second conditional: 'I don't have a car, so I can't drive you.'
3. Give polite advice to a friend who wants to quit their job without a plan. (2 modals)
4. Make it polite: 'Where is the bank?'

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Rewrite as a mixed conditional (past → present): 'She didn't save money, so she can't buy the car now.'
2. Compare with a reason: 'This course is better than that one.' (use far + reason)
3. Correct: 'Despite of the cost, we decided to proceed.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 9 · PASSIVE VOICE IN NATURAL ENGLISH

Part 5 — Describe and Explain | Speaking goal: choose between active and passive for the right focus

Compare these two sentences: 'Someone stole my bicycle outside the library yesterday' and 'My bicycle was stolen outside the library yesterday.' Both report the exact same crime. Yet the first sentence starts with an unknown stranger ('Someone'), while the second puts the spotlight immediately on what you actually care about: your bicycle.

The passive voice is not a complicated academic decoration. It is how English speakers control the camera angle of a sentence — placing the person, object, or result at the front when the doer is unknown, obvious, or less important than what happened.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these two pairs of sentences aloud with a partner and decide which version sounds more natural in each context:

• Context 1 (a news broadcast): 'Workers opened the new city hospital this morning.' vs. 'The new city hospital was opened this morning.'

• Context 2 (a personal story): 'My tea was spilled by me on my laptop.' vs. 'I spilled my tea on my laptop.'

Why does the passive sound right in Context 1, while the active sounds much better in Context 2? Tell your partner about one recent change in your neighbourhood or workplace and one small accident of your own.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Building the passive: the tense lives in "be"

To turn an active sentence into a passive one, move the object to the front so it becomes the new subject, and use 'be + past participle'.

The main verb stays in its past participle form (done, built, written, repaired) across every tense. Whenever you change the time or add a modal, you simply change the form of 'be' (is, was, will be, has been, must be).

Pattern:

Passive core: Subject (receiver of action) + form of be + past participle (+ by + agent when needed)

Across tenses: is/are done (present) · was/were done (past) · is/are being done (continuous) · has/have been done (perfect) · will/must/should be done (modal)

Natural examples:

• The clinic rooms are cleaned every evening after the last patient leaves. (present simple passive)

• The stone bridge was built in 2019. (past simple passive)

• The scholarship results will be announced tomorrow afternoon. (future passive)

• The novel was written by Atiq Rahimi. (the 'by' phrase is included because the author's identity is the key point)

Keep in mind:

→ Include 'by + person/agent' only when the identity of the doer adds important information ('The policy was signed by the minister'). Never add vague agents like 'by someone' or 'by people'.

Rule 2 — When to choose the passive (and when to stay active)

News reports, scientific descriptions, workplace updates, and polite professional announcements often use the passive to focus on events, processes, or results. The agent may be left out when it is unknown or unimportant, or included in a by-phrase when it matters.

When you are telling a lively personal story about your own actions, however, stay in the active voice: 'I lost my keys' is natural and direct, whereas 'My keys were lost by me' sounds clumsy and evasive.

Pattern:

Choose the passive when: 1. the result or receiver matters most · 2. the doer is unknown, obvious, or general · 3. you want an objective, diplomatic tone (without pointing fingers)

Natural examples:

• My wallet was stolen on the crowded bus yesterday. (doer is unknown)
• Two calculation errors were found in the budget draft. (diplomatic — focuses on the errors rather than blaming a colleague)
• Coffee beans are roasted for twelve minutes before being ground. (describing a process)

Keep in mind:

→ In everyday stories about yourself, prefer the active voice: say 'I dropped my phone' (not 'My phone was dropped by me').

Rule 3 — Objective reporting structures: It is said that … / He is said to …

When journalists, researchers, or professionals report widely held beliefs or unconfirmed claims without saying 'People say…', they use two passive reporting frames with verbs like say, believe, think, expect, report, and consider.

Pattern:

Impersonal frame: It is said / believed / reported / expected that + clause
Subject-focused frame: Subject + is/are said / believed / thought + to + base verb (or to have + past participle for an earlier past event)

Natural examples:

• It is widely believed that regular reading strengthens spoken vocabulary.
• She is said to speak five languages fluently. (= People say that she speaks…)
• The delegation is reported to have arrived in the capital last night. ('to have arrived' points to an earlier past action)

Keep in mind:

→ Notice the two infinitive options: use 'to + base verb' for something true now ('He is thought to live in Herat') and 'to have + past participle' for an earlier event ('He is thought to have left yesterday').

Part 3 · See the Difference

Active vs passive — shifting the spotlight and the tone

Compare how the focus and social effect change when we move from the active column to the passive column:

Active (focus on the doer)	Passive (focus on the event/result)	Why a speaker chooses it
Someone damaged the main gate last night.	The main gate was damaged last night.	The passive omits the unknown 'Someone' and puts the damaged gate first. Add a by-phrase only if the agent matters.
You did not lock the supply room.	The supply room was left unlocked.	The active accuses one person directly; the passive focuses calmly on the issue that needs fixing.
The board approved the new timetable.	The new timetable was approved.	In an announcement to students, what matters is the new timetable, not the internal committee.

The informal "get" passive vs the standard "be" passive

In everyday conversation, speakers often replace 'be' with 'get' for sudden, unexpected, or emotional events: 'He got promoted last month', 'Our car got stuck in the snow', 'They got married in the spring.'

In formal reports, presentations, and academic English, prefer the standard 'be' passive: 'He was promoted to senior manager last month.'

Verbs that look passive in meaning but stay active in form

A few everyday verbs describe how an object behaves without needing a passive form: 'Her new book sold out in three days', 'The stain washed out easily', 'The clinic door opened at eight.' These describe what happened naturally rather than an action performed on the object.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. The stone bridge across the valley _____ (build) in 2019.
2. The scholarship winners _____ (announce) tomorrow afternoon at two.
3. This lecture hall _____ (clean) every morning before classes begin.
4. My cousin's wallet _____ (steal) on the crowded bus yesterday.
5. A new attendance policy _____ (just / introduce) by the department.
6. All application forms must _____ (submit) before midday on Friday.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite in the passive so the bicycle comes first: 'Someone has stolen my bicycle.'
2. Rewrite in the active so the doer comes first: 'The final decision was made by the board.'
3. Rewrite in two formal ways (using 'It is said…' and 'He is said…'): 'People say that he is the strongest candidate.'
4. Correct the irregular participle mistake: 'The old courthouse was builted in 1990.'
5. Make this sentence sound natural in a personal story: 'My phone was lost by me on the way home.'
6. Report this update as a formal passive announcement: 'Engineers will close the main tunnel tomorrow for maintenance.'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'The Morning Newsroom'. Partner A is a local radio reporter delivering three short news updates about recent events in your city, campus, or workplace using natural passives. Partner B is the news editor asking follow-up questions ('Do we know who did it?', 'What will happen next?'). Then swap roles.

• Choose three news items from: a road or building project · a new rule or policy · a community event · a sports or academic achievement · a weather disruption.

• In your report, use at least two passive tenses (such as 'was opened', 'has been postponed', 'will be held') and one formal reporting frame ('It is reported that…' or '…is expected to…').

How it sounds in conversation:

A: Good morning. The new pedestrian bridge near the university was opened at eight o'clock today, and traffic along the main road has already been reduced.

B: Do we know when the second phase of the project will be completed?

A: It is expected that the cycle lane will be finished before the end of next month.

Your conversation goal: Three news items per reporter in report-style speech, with two accurate passives and one reporting structure, surviving the editor's 'who did it?' question.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ forms passives accurately across past, present perfect, and future/modal tenses

✓ mentions the agent with 'by' only when the doer's identity genuinely matters

✓ uses at least one formal reporting passive ('It is said/expected that…' or 'is said to…')

✓ answers the editor's follow-up questions clearly, switching between active and passive as needed

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Choosing smoothly between active and passive lets you link sentences together without jumping awkwardly from subject to subject.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Practise shifting one everyday object through four passive tenses aloud: 'The report is checked weekly' · 'was checked yesterday' · 'has already been checked' · 'will be checked tomorrow'.

• Pair the two formal reporting patterns until you can switch between them effortlessly: 'It is believed that the method works' ↔ 'The method is believed to work'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use the passive to keep the same topic at the front of two connected sentences: 'The solar panels were installed in May, and since then electricity costs have been cut by half.'

• Use cautious reporting verbs ('It is claimed / alleged / assumed that…') when discussing unverified news or competing viewpoints.

• Open a formal description with a compressed passive participle clause: 'Founded in 1971, the institute now trains over a thousand specialists a year.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to pick three real events from your city, school, or workplace this month — two where the result or public impact matters most (passive), and one where you want to share your own personal opinion (active). Note only the three topics and the tense of 'be' for each.

Speak without reading: Ninety-second community briefing: Report three developments that have happened (or will happen soon) in your community, campus, or workplace. Use the passive voice for the events, include one reporting structure ('It is said / expected that…'), and finish with your own active-voice comment on what should happen next.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Three important updates have happened around our campus this week. First, a new pedestrian footbridge was opened near the east gate on Monday, so morning traffic has been diverted away from the main walkway. Second, two study rooms on the third floor have been fitted with new lighting and quiet desks. Finally, it is expected that the library hours will be extended during the exam period next month. In my view, the administration should publish the new evening timetable as soon as possible so students can plan their transport home.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses at least three passive verb forms accurately across different tenses

✓ maintains a clear, objective reporting tone for the announcements

✓ includes agents with 'by' only where the doer matters

✓ shifts naturally into the active voice for the speaker's closing recommendation

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Form the passive with 'be + past participle'; the tense or modal always lives in 'be' (was built, has been built, must be built).

• Choose the passive when the result or receiver matters most, when the doer is unknown or obvious, or when you want an objective, diplomatic tone.

• Use 'It is said/believed that…' or 'Subject + is said/believed to…' to report general views formally.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'The house was builted in 1990.' → 'The house was built in 1990.' ('Built' is both the past tense and the past participle.)

→ 'My keys were lost by me.' → 'I lost my keys.' (Use the active voice for your own everyday actions.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Look around the room and describe three objects using passive sentences in three different tenses.

• Report one widely held belief about health or education in both patterns: 'It is believed that…' and '…is believed to…'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can build passive sentences accurately in present, past, present perfect, and modal forms.

☐ I know when to choose the passive for focus and when to keep my sentences active.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 9 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. was built · 2. will be announced · 3. is cleaned · 4. was stolen · 5. has just been introduced · 6. be submitted

Practice B: 1. My bicycle has been stolen. · 2. The board made the final decision. · 3. It is said that he is the strongest candidate. / He is said to be the strongest candidate. · 4. The old courthouse was built in 1990. · 5. I lost my phone on the way home. · 6. The main tunnel will be closed tomorrow for maintenance.

LESSON 10 · CAUSATIVE STRUCTURES

Part 5 — Describe and Explain | Speaking goal: talk about services, arrangements, influence and responsibility naturally

If a friend tells you, 'I cut my hair yesterday,' you picture them standing in front of the bathroom mirror with a pair of scissors. What they almost certainly meant to say is, 'I had my hair cut yesterday' — meaning they arranged for a barber or hairdresser to do the work.

Causative structures let you express two everyday realities with precision: arranging for a professional service ('have/get something done'), and describing how people influence, allow, or persuade one another to act ('make, let, have, and get').

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Compare these two sentences with a partner:

• 'I painted my living room last weekend.' vs. 'I had my living room painted last weekend.'

In which sentence did the speaker hold the paintbrush and get paint on their sleeves? Now talk with your partner about everyday tasks in your city (car repairs, tailoring, computer problems, home maintenance, cooking for a celebration): which ones do you do with your own hands, and which ones do you have done by a specialist?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Arranging a service: have / get + object + past participle

When you pay, ask, or arrange for a professional or service provider to do a job for you, put 'have' (or the slightly more conversational 'get') before the object, followed by the past participle: 'I had my watch repaired.'

Word order is crucial here: the object comes between 'have/get' and the participle ('had my watch repaired'), because putting the participle right after 'had' ('I had repaired my watch') turns the sentence into the ordinary past perfect, meaning you repaired it yourself!

Pattern:

Service causative: Subject + have / get (in any tense) + object + past participle
Questions & negatives: Where do you get your car serviced? · I haven't had the documents translated yet.

Natural examples:

• I had my suit altered by a tailor before my brother's wedding.
• She is getting her laptop keyboard replaced this afternoon.
• We need to have the heating system checked before winter sets in.

Keep in mind:

→ This exact same structure is also used when something unpleasant happens to your belongings outside your control: 'He had his passport stolen at the station' (obviously he did not arrange the theft — he was affected by it).

Rule 2 — Influencing people: make, let, have, and get

When you talk about how one person causes or allows another person to do something, English uses four key verbs — and each one carries a distinct social relationship.

'Make' expresses compulsion or an unavoidable reaction; 'let' expresses permission; 'have' expresses routine professional instruction or delegation; and 'get' expresses persuading someone or overcoming difficulty. Notice the grammar: make, let, and have take the bare infinitive (without 'to'), whereas 'get' requires 'to + verb'.

Pattern:

Compulsion / reaction: make + person + base verb (no 'to') → The coach made us run two extra laps.
Permission: let + person + base verb (no 'to') → My parents let me borrow the car.
Professional delegation: have + person + base verb (no 'to') → I'll have the receptionist call you.
Persuasion / effort: get + person + to + base verb (with 'to'!) → I finally got my brother to help me move.

Natural examples:

- The sudden applause made the speaker smile.
- Our instructor let us work in pairs for the revision task.
- The clinic director had the technician test the samples twice.
- How did you get the landlord to lower the rent?

Keep in mind:

→ Out of make, let, have, and get, only 'get' takes 'to' in the active voice: 'get someone to do something' (never 'make someone to do' or 'let someone to do').

Rule 3 — Real-world service conversations

When you walk into a repair shop, clinic, print shop, or tailor's workshop, combining causative patterns with polite modal questions gives you natural, idiomatic service English.

Pattern:

Explaining the job: I need to have / get my … repaired / checked / altered.
Checking timing & cost: How soon can I have it done? · How much do you charge to have a screen replaced?

Natural examples:

- I get my eyes tested every two years at the optician's on Main Street.
- I'm having the brakes checked tomorrow morning — could you give me a lift to work?

Keep in mind:

→ When 'make' is turned into the passive voice, the 'to' reappears: 'The teacher made us wait' → 'We were made to wait.' For 'let', we switch to 'be allowed to' in the passive: 'We were allowed to leave early.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

Doing it yourself vs arranging it vs suffering an accident

Compare what your listener pictures in these three sentences:

Sentence A	Sentence B	What actually happened
I washed my car on Saturday.	I had my car washed on Saturday.	I tightened the garden hose and washed it myself vs I took it to the car wash and paid an attendant to wash it.
I had my watch repaired.	I had my watch broken during the match.	Same grammar, opposite experience: the first is a service I arranged; the second is an accident that happened to my watch.

Four shades of interpersonal influence: make vs let vs have vs get

make + verb (force)	let + verb (allow)	have + verb (assign)	get + to + verb (persuade)	How the relationship feels
She made me rewrite the report.	She let me rewrite the report.	She had me rewrite the report.	She got me to rewrite the report.	1. Make = she forced me (I had no choice). 2. Let = I wanted to rewrite it and she gave permission. 3. Have = she assigned the task as my manager. 4. Get = she persuaded or convinced me to do it.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. I need to have my winter coat _____ (alter) before the cold weather arrives.
2. Where do you usually get your hair _____ (cut)?
3. The loud construction noise outside made me _____ (lose) my concentration.
4. The librarian let us _____ (use) the quiet conference room for our rehearsal.
5. I'm having my eyes _____ (test) at the clinic on Thursday afternoon.
6. After a long talk, she finally got her teenage son _____ (turn) off his computer before midnight.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Rewrite using have + object + past participle: 'I paid a mechanic to service my car last week.'
2. Rewrite using get (to show persuasion): 'After a long discussion, my friend agreed to drive us to the airport.'
3. Correct the mistake: 'I will get my laptop to repair tomorrow.'
4. Correct the mistake: 'The security guard made us to wait outside in the rain.'
5. Write one true sentence about something you had done recently (a service you arranged or a mishap that happened to you).
6. Write a polite question you would ask at a repair shop when your phone screen is cracked (using a causative form).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Role-play 'The Busy Repair & Service Counter'. Partner A runs a multi-service centre (handling electronics, tailoring, printing, or car repairs); Partner B is a customer who has had a chaotic week and needs three different things sorted out before a big event on Friday.

• Customer (Partner B): Explain at least three things you need to have done ('I need to have my…', 'I'm hoping to get my…'), and mention why you are in a hurry using make, let, or get.

• Service Manager (Partner A): Explain what can be done on site, what you will have a technician look at, how long it will take, and what it will cost. Negotiate until you agree on a plan, then swap roles.

How it sounds in conversation:

Customer: Good afternoon — I'm giving a conference presentation on Friday, and I need to get my laptop screen replaced and have thirty handouts bound.

Manager: We can have the handouts bound for you within an hour. As for the laptop, I'll have our senior technician check whether we have that screen in stock. If we do, we can get it fixed by tomorrow evening.

Your conversation goal: One completed service negotiation per pair: at least three things that need doing, a price and a time agreed, and one make/let/get sentence used accurately.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ uses 'have/get + object + past participle' accurately for all service requests

✓ keeps the object before the past participle ('get my screen replaced')

✓ uses make, let, have, or get (+ person) with the right verb pattern ('to' only after get)

✓ agrees clearly on timing and cost in natural spoken English

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Beyond repair shops and salons, causative patterns are essential in workplace delegation and expressive storytelling.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Say four true sentences about people in your life using make, let, have, and get — paying special attention to the bare verb after make/let/have and 'to + verb' after get.

• Practise everyday service chunks aloud until the word order is automatic: 'I need to have my passport renewed' · 'When can I get it done?'

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use 'have + person + base verb' for smooth, professional delegation at work: 'I'll have the finance team send you the updated figures this afternoon.'

• Use 'have + person + verb-ing' to describe how a speaker, book, or event affected an audience: 'His story had the whole room laughing within two minutes' · 'That documentary had me thinking for days.'

• Combine 'get round to + -ing' with a causative when talking about delayed chores: 'I finally got round to having the kitchen roof repaired.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to plan a one-minute story about a chaotic day (real or lightly invented). Jot down three keywords: one service you arranged ('had/got something done'), one unexpected mishap ('had something happen'), and one moment where someone made, let, or got someone else to help.

Speak without reading: One-minute story challenge: Tell your partner about 'A day when plans went sideways — and how we sorted it out.' Include at least two service/mishap causatives and at least two interpersonal causatives (make, let, have, get) without reading from notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Last Thursday started badly from the moment I woke up. I had had my car serviced the evening before, yet when I turned the key it still wouldn't start, so I got my neighbour to check the battery before he left for work. Then, on the bus into town, I almost had my bag taken in the crowd. When I arrived twenty minutes late, my manager made me reschedule my morning client call, but she kindly let me use her quiet office to prepare for the afternoon presentation. By five o'clock, I had the garage tow the car in and replace the starter motor — and the whole chaotic day had us laughing over dinner.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses 'have/get + object + past participle' accurately with the object in the middle

✓ distinguishes clearly between arranged services and unplanned mishaps

✓ uses make, let, have, and get (+ person) with accurate verb patterns

✓ connects the events into an engaging, easy-to-follow spoken story

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Use 'have/get + object + past participle' when you arrange for someone else to do a job (or when an unpleasant event affects your belongings).

• Use 'make + person + base verb' (force), 'let + person + base verb' (permission), 'have + person + base verb' (instruction), and 'get + person + to + base verb' (persuasion).

• In the passive voice, 'make' regains 'to': 'We were made to wait for an hour.'

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'I will get my car to repair tomorrow.' → 'I will get my car repaired tomorrow.' (Use the past participle for a service done to an object.)

→ 'She made me to wait outside.' → 'She made me wait outside.' (Never put 'to' after active 'make' or 'let'.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Name three things you would like to have done or repaired this month using full causative sentences.

• Describe one teacher or family member who made you work hard and one who let you make your own choices.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can talk about services and repairs naturally using 'have/get something done'.

☐ I can use make, let, have, and get accurately when talking about other people's actions.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 10 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. altered · 2. cut · 3. lose · 4. use · 5. tested · 6. to turn

Practice B: 1. I had my car serviced last week. · 2. After a long discussion, I got my friend to drive us to the airport. · 3. I will get my laptop repaired tomorrow. · 4. The security guard made us wait outside in the rain. · 5. answers vary (e.g. 'I had my watch battery replaced on Monday.') · 6. Could I have my phone screen replaced today? / How much would it cost to get my phone screen replaced?

LESSON 11 · GERUNDS AND INFINITIVES

Part 6 — Speak with Greater Precision | Speaking goal: choose the right verb pattern for your meaning

Listen to the difference between these two five-word sentences: 'He stopped smoking last year' and 'He stopped to smoke last year.' In the first sentence, a man gave up a habit for good. In the second, he paused in the middle of a walk in order to light a cigarette.

When you put two verbs together in English, the second verb takes either the gerund (-ing) or the infinitive (to + base verb). Once you understand the logic behind these two patterns — and the small group of verbs where choosing '-ing' or 'to' changes the entire meaning — your sentences sound effortless and precise.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these four sentence starters aloud and finish each one instinctively with the first true idea that comes to mind:

- On a quiet evening, I really enjoy…
- Before the end of this year, I hope…
- When I have an important deadline, I try to avoid…
- Next month, I've decided…

Compare your sentences with a partner. Notice that your ear probably chose '-ing' after 'enjoy' and 'avoid', and 'to + verb' after 'hope' and 'decided' without even stopping to think!

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Verbs followed by the gerund (-ing): ongoing experiences and real activities

Why do verbs like enjoy, avoid, mind, finish, keep, practise, suggest, and miss take the -ing form? Because these verbs usually look at an activity as a real, ongoing experience or a familiar action that already exists.

When you say 'I enjoy swimming' or 'He avoided answering the question', treat the verb + -ing as a single rhythmic chunk.

Pattern:

Verb + verb-ing: enjoy · avoid · consider · delay · finish · keep · mind · miss · practise · risk · suggest · give up · feel like · can't help + verb-ing

Natural examples:

- I enjoy reading for half an hour before going to sleep.
- The speaker avoided giving a direct answer to the journalist's question.
- She suggested meeting fifteen minutes earlier to check the slides.
- Would you mind opening the window slightly?

Keep in mind:

→ When a verb follows mind directly, use -ing: 'Do you mind waiting?' Other patterns exist, such as 'Would you mind if I opened the window?'

→ With 'suggest' and 'recommend', never insert 'me to': say 'She suggested going early' or 'She suggested that we go early' (never 'She suggested me to go').

Rule 2 — Verbs followed by the infinitive (to + base verb): looking forward

Now look at verbs that take 'to + base verb': decide, hope, plan, promise, agree, offer, refuse, manage, want, expect, and would like. Notice what almost all of them have in common: they point forward like an arrow toward a future intention, goal, or decision that has not happened yet.

When you decide *to leave*, promise *to call*, or hope *to pass*, the decision or hope comes first, and the action points ahead into the future.

Pattern:

Verb + to + base verb: agree ·choose · decide · expect · hope · intend · learn · manage · offer · plan · promise · refuse · seem · tend · want · would like + to + verb

Natural examples:

- After working at the bank for three years, she decided to study law.
- Despite the flat tyre, we managed to reach the examination hall on time.
- He promised to send the revised contract before five o'clock.
- I'd like to ask one follow-up question about your proposal.

Keep in mind:

→ To make an infinitive negative, place 'not' immediately before 'to': 'We decided not to travel during the storm' and 'She promised not to be late.'

Rule 3 — Verbs where -ing vs to changes the meaning

With a handful of common verbs — remember, forget, regret, stop, try, and mean — both patterns are grammatical, but they tell two different stories.

Use the timeline test: '-ing' looks back at an earlier action (or an ongoing activity/experiment), while 'to + verb' looks forward to a subsequent duty, purpose, or difficult attempt.

Pattern:

remember / forget / regret + verb-ing → looking back at an action that already happened
remember / forget / regret + to + verb → looking forward to a duty or action that comes next
stop + verb-ing → quit the activity · stop + to + verb → pause what you are doing in order to do something else
try + verb-ing → test an easy method/experiment · try + to + verb → make an effort at something difficult

Natural examples:

- I clearly remember locking the front door this morning. (I locked it first; I recall the memory now)
- Please remember to lock the front door when you leave. (remember first, then lock the door)
- He stopped buying bottled water and bought a reusable flask. (he quit the habit)
- On the drive to Herat, we stopped to buy fresh fruit by the roadside. (we paused our drive in order to buy fruit)
- If the room is too warm, try opening the balcony door. (test it as a simple experiment) vs. I tried to open the window, but the latch was painted shut. (I made an effort, but failed)

Keep in mind:

→ Also compare 'mean + to + verb' (intend: 'I didn't mean to interrupt you') with 'mean + verb-ing' (involve as a necessary result: 'Taking the early flight means waking up at four in the morning').

Rule 4 — Gerunds as sentence subjects and after prepositions

Whenever you want to use an action as the subject of a sentence ('Swimming is good exercise') or place a verb immediately after a preposition (in, at, of, for, about, without, instead of, before, after), English always chooses the -ing form.

Watch out for phrases where 'to' is actually a preposition pointing to a noun, such as 'look forward to', 'be used to', and 'object to' — because 'to' is a preposition there, any verb that follows must end in -ing!

Pattern:

Subject gerund: Verb-ing + singular verb … → Learning a language takes daily patience.
Preposition + verb-ing: interested in · good at · instead of · without · before/after + verb-ing
Phrases where 'to' is a preposition: look forward to · be/get used to · object to + verb-ing

Natural examples:

- Practising aloud for ten minutes a day builds more fluency than silent reading.
- She solved the problem without asking anyone for help.
- I really look forward to meeting your colleagues next week.
- It took me a month to get used to waking up at five.

Keep in mind:

→ Test whether 'to' is a preposition by putting a noun after it: since we say 'I look forward to the holiday' (a noun), we must also say 'I look forward to seeing you' (a gerund, which acts like a noun).

Part 3 · See the Difference

Meaning-changing pairs side by side

Say each pair aloud and picture the exact sequence of actions in your mind:

Verb + -ing	Verb + to + base verb	How the story changes
I stopped checking my phone during study hours.	I stopped to check my phone on the way to the library.	Left (-ing): I gave up the habit of checking my phone. Right (to): I paused my walk in order to look at my phone.
I remembered calling my uncle on his birthday.	I remembered to call my uncle on his birthday.	Left (-ing): I have the memory of the phone call we had. Right (to): I didn't forget my duty — I remembered first and then dialled his number.
Have you tried restarting the router?	I tried to fix the router, but it's still offline.	Left (-ing): try it as a simple method to see if it helps. Right (to): I made a difficult attempt.

Passive meaning with "need + -ing" vs "need + to be + participle"

When a person has an obligation, we use 'need + to + verb': 'I need to charge my phone.'

When an object requires a service, everyday spoken English often uses 'need + verb-ing' with a passive meaning: 'My phone battery needs charging' (= needs to be charged) · 'These windows need cleaning' (= need to be cleaned).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. Would you mind _____ (help) me carry these boxes up to the second floor?
2. During the interview, she carefully avoided _____ (criticise) her former employer.
3. After comparing both universities, we decided _____ (accept) the offer in Kabul.
4. I really look forward to _____ (hear) your thoughts on the new proposal.
5. My uncle stopped _____ (smoke) five years ago, and his health improved rapidly.
6. She tried _____ (open) the jammed locker door, but the key wouldn't turn. (a difficult attempt)

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Correct the mistake: 'I really enjoy to read historical biographies in the evening.'
2. Correct the mistake: 'We look forward to meet your team on Monday.'
3. Correct the mistake: 'My colleague suggested me to leave early before the snow started.'
4. Rewrite in two natural ways using need: 'Someone must clean this classroom before tomorrow.' (The classroom needs…)
5. Choose the right form and explain why: 'I clearly remember (posting / to post) the package on Tuesday — I still have the receipt in my pocket.'
6. Write one true sentence about your own study habits starting with 'Instead of + verb-ing…'.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Conduct a lively habits-and-decisions conversation with your partner. Adapt the questions below, listen closely to every answer, and ask at least two follow-up questions before swapping roles.

• Ask your partner: (1) What is one activity you genuinely enjoy doing when you have a free afternoon? (2) What is one habit you have stopped doing — or are trying to avoid doing — this year? (3) What is one important goal you have decided or promised yourself to achieve over the next twelve months? (4) What is something you are really looking forward to doing soon?

• In your answers, use at least four different gerund/infinitive patterns and include at least one meaning-changing verb (remember, stop, or try).

How it sounds in conversation:

A: What is one habit you've stopped doing this year?

B: I've stopped estudiar with my phone on the desk. At first I tried turning it face down, but I still kept checking it — so now I leave it in another room.

A: Did it take long to get used to working without it?

Your conversation goal: A five-question interview per role: each person answers with at least four different gerund/infinitive patterns and asks two follow-up questions.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ uses -ing and to-infinitive patterns accurately after common verbs

✓ uses '-ing' accurately after prepositions (including 'look forward to' and 'get used to')

✓ uses at least one meaning-changing verb (stop, remember, try) in the right pattern

✓ asks natural follow-up questions that keep the dialogue flowing

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Fluent speakers use gerund phrases to open sentences cleanly and use idiomatic expressions of worth, difficulty, and purpose to evaluate choices.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Practise verb patterns as complete spoken chunks rather than isolated rules: 'I enjoy reading…', 'She suggested meeting…', 'We decided to wait…', 'I look forward to seeing…'.

• Say two contrasting sentences aloud for 'stop', 'remember', and 'try' using real moments from your own week.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Open formal or reflective sentences with a multi-word gerund subject: 'Finding twenty quiet minutes every morning is easier than finding two free hours at the weekend.'

• Use evaluative -ing frames in discussions: 'It's well worth visiting…' · 'There's no point in worrying about…' · 'It's a waste of time arguing over…'

• Use 'have difficulty / trouble + verb-ing' (without a preposition): 'At first I had difficulty understanding rapid announcements at the airport.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to note five keywords: two habits you enjoy or keep doing (-ing), one unhelpful habit you stopped or avoid doing (-ing), one method you tried when learning a skill (try + -ing / to), and one firm decision you have made for the months ahead (decide / plan + to).

Speak without reading: One-minute personal reflection: 'What learning a difficult skill has taught me about myself.' Use at least three gerund patterns (including one after a preposition or as a subject) and at least two infinitive patterns, ending with a clear decision you have made for the future.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Learning English as an adult has taught me to be much more patient with myself. When I first started, I tried translating every single word in my head before speaking, which only made me hesitate. Eventually I stopped doing that and practised listening for whole phrases instead. Nowadays I really enjoy reading short articles aloud in the morning, and I keep a small notebook for expressions worth remembering. I used to avoid speaking in front of larger groups, but this term I've decided to join our department's weekly discussion circle, and I look forward to testing my voice there.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses both gerund (-ing) and infinitive (to + verb) patterns accurately

✓ uses at least one meaning-changing verb (tried, stopped, remembered) with the intended meaning

✓ includes at least one preposition + -ing or gerund subject naturally

✓ closes with a clear forward-looking decision using 'to + base verb'

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Verbs of ongoing experience and avoidance (enjoy, avoid, mind, suggest, keep, finish) take '-ing'; verbs of future intention and decision (decide, hope, plan, promise, manage) take 'to + verb'.

• With remember, forget, stop, and try, '-ing' points to an earlier or ongoing action/experiment, while 'to + verb' points to a subsequent purpose or attempt.

• After every preposition — including 'to' in 'look forward to' and 'be/get used to' — always use '-ing'.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'I enjoy to read novels.' → 'I enjoy reading novels.' ('Enjoy' always takes -ing.)

→ 'I look forward to meet you.' → 'I look forward to meeting you.' ('To' is a preposition here, so it takes -ing.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Say two contrasting sentences with 'stop' (quit vs pause for a purpose) and two with 'try' (experiment vs difficult effort).

• Finish these three phrases aloud with actions: 'I suggested…', 'I managed…', 'I look forward to…'.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can choose between -ing and to + verb automatically after common everyday verbs.

☐ I can hear and use the meaning difference after stop, remember, forget, and try.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 11 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. helping · 2. criticising · 3. to accept · 4. hearing · 5. smoking · 6. to open

Practice B: 1. I really enjoy reading historical biographies in the evening. · 2. We look forward to meeting your team on Monday. · 3. My colleague suggested leaving early before the snow started. / …suggested that we leave early… · 4. The classroom needs cleaning before tomorrow. / The classroom needs to be cleaned before tomorrow. · 5. posting (because I posted it first and I recall the memory of doing it now) · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Instead of cramming the night before an exam, I review my notes for fifteen minutes every evening.')

LESSON 12 · RELATIVE CLAUSES AND CONCISE DESCRIPTIONS

Part 6 — Speak with Greater Precision | Speaking goal: describe people, places and ideas precisely in one sentence

Listen to someone speaking in short, choppy fragments: 'I met a doctor yesterday. She studied in Delhi. She now runs a clinic. The clinic serves three mountain villages.' Every fact is clear, but the rhythm sounds robotic. Now listen to how a fluent speaker weaves those four fragments into one smooth sentence: 'Yesterday I met a doctor who studied in Delhi and now runs a clinic serving three mountain villages.'

Relative clauses (who, which, that, whose, where) and reduced clauses are the master tools for packing rich detail into clean, effortless spoken sentences.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Play a quick 60-second guessing game with your partner:

• Think of one person in the room, one well-known place in your country, and one everyday object in your bag.

• Without saying the name, describe each one in a single sentence starting with 'It's someone who…', 'It's a place where…', or 'It's something that…' so your partner can guess it immediately.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Defining relative clauses: identifying exactly which one

A defining relative clause gives essential information that tells your listener *which* person, thing, or place you mean. If you remove a defining clause from 'The woman who interviewed me was very kind', you are left with 'The woman was very kind' — and your listener has no idea which woman you are talking about.

Use 'who' (or 'that') for people, 'which' or 'that' for things, 'whose' for possession, 'where' for places, and 'when' for times. When the relative pronoun is the object of the clause ('The book [that] I read'), natural spoken English usually drops it altogether: 'The book I read was fascinating.'

Pattern:

Defining pronouns (no commas): who / that (people) · which / that (things) · whose (possession) · where (place) · when (time)

Omitting the object pronoun in speech: The colleague (who/that) I called · The course (that/which) we chose

Natural examples:

• The engineer who designed this solar pump lives in our district. ('who' is the subject — cannot be dropped)

• The article I sent you yesterday explains the new policy clearly. (object pronoun 'that/which' dropped naturally)

• That's the café where we held our first study group.

• We interviewed a candidate whose research focuses on water conservation.

Keep in mind:

→ Never repeat the object pronoun at the end of a relative clause: say 'The film we watched was great' (never 'The film which we watched it was great').

→ Never use 'what' after a noun as a relative pronoun: say 'The book that I read' (never 'The book what I read').

Rule 2 — Non-defining relative clauses: adding extra detail with a pause

Sometimes your listener already knows exactly who or what you mean (for example, 'My older brother', 'Kabul University', or 'Our new project'), and you simply want to drop in an extra piece of interesting information along the way.

In writing, we set this extra clause inside commas; in speech, we frame it with brief natural pauses. Two strict rules apply here: you can never use 'that' after a comma, and you can never omit the pronoun.

Pattern:

Non-defining (with commas / spoken pauses): Noun, who / which / whose / where …, main clause
Commenting on a whole idea: Full clause, which + singular verb …

Natural examples:

• My older brother, who works as a civil engineer in Herat, is visiting us this weekend.
• Our central library, which was renovated last year, stays open until nine in the evening.
• The flight was delayed by four hours, which meant we missed the opening session.

Keep in mind:

→ After a comma (or spoken pause) in a non-defining clause, always use 'who' for people and 'which' for things — never 'that'.

Rule 3 — Prepositions in relative clauses: formal speech vs everyday conversation

In formal presentations and writing, a preposition can move in front of 'whom' (for people) or 'which' (for things): 'the committee to which we reported'. In everyday natural conversation, put the preposition at the end of the clause and drop the pronoun: 'the committee we reported to'.

Pattern:

Formal register: preposition + whom / which → the professor with whom I worked · the topic about which she spoke
Natural spoken register: (who/that/which) … + preposition → the professor I worked with · the topic she spoke about

Natural examples:

• The organisation for which he works provides rural medical clinics. (formal)
• The organisation he works for provides rural medical clinics. (natural conversation)

Keep in mind:

→ Notice when a place needs 'where' versus 'which': 'the clinic where I work' (= at which I work — no preposition needed) versus 'the clinic which was opened last year' ('the clinic' is the subject of 'was opened', so use 'which/that', not 'where').

Rule 4 — Reduced relative clauses: making descriptions crisp and concise

When a relative clause contains 'who/which/that + be' followed by an -ing verb, a past participle, or an adjective phrase, you can make your sentence cleaner by dropping 'who/which/that + be' altogether.

Pattern:

Active reduction (-ing): the woman (who is) talking to the director → the woman talking to the director
Passive reduction (past participle): the results (which were) published today → the results published today

Natural examples:

• Anyone wishing to join the debate club should sign up by Thursday. (= Anyone who wishes…)
• The figures shown on the second slide come from this year's survey. (= The figures which are shown…)
• Students interested in the scholarship can collect a form from the office. (= Students who are interested…)

Keep in mind:

→ Only reduce a subject relative clause by turning a continuous/active verb into -ing or keeping a passive participle/adjective: never drop 'who' in front of a single past-simple active verb ('The man who called yesterday' cannot become 'The man called yesterday').

Part 3 · See the Difference

Defining vs non-defining — how a pause changes the number of sisters!

Read these two sentences aloud — pausing at the commas in the right-hand column — and notice what changes about the speaker's family:

Defining (identifies which one)	Non-defining (adds extra detail)	What your listener understands
My sister who lives in London is a paediatrician.	My sister, who lives in London, is a paediatrician.	Left (no pause/commas): I have more than one sister, and I am specifying which sister I mean (the one in London, not the one in Kabul). Right (with pauses/commas): I have only one sister, and by the way, she happens to live in London.
The laptops which were left in the lab were locked away.	The laptops, which were left in the lab, were locked away.	Left: only the laptops left in the lab were locked away. Right: all the laptops were left in the lab, and all of them were locked away.

Choosing between who, which, that, whose, and where

Pattern A	Pattern B	The key distinction
The mentor who / that guided me...	The mentor, who guided me for years,...	'That' works alongside 'who/which' in defining clauses, but is never used after a comma in non-defining clauses.
The village where I grew up...	The village that / which I visited...	Use 'where' when an action happens *in/at* the place; use 'that/which' when the place is the direct object or subject of the verb.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. The pharmacist _____ helped us find the right medicine was remarkably patient. (who / which / whose)

2. My first laptop, _____ I bought six years ago, still runs smoothly. (that / which)

3. This is the quiet courtyard _____ we used to revise before our university exams. (where / which)

4. The passenger _____ suitcase was misplaced at the airport filed a report at the desk. (who / whose)

5. The survey results _____ were published this morning surprised the whole department. (use which/that, or reduce the clause by omitting both words)

6. I really enjoyed the documentary you recommended last week. (which relative pronoun was omitted after 'documentary'?)

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Combine into one smooth sentence using who: 'The instructor is outstanding. She taught us academic speaking last term.'

2. Combine using commas (non-defining extra detail): 'My uncle is an experienced airline pilot. He has flown to over forty countries.'

3. Correct the mistake: 'My mother, that lives in Kandahar, is visiting us next Friday.'

4. Correct the mistake: 'The article what I read on the train was eye-opening.'

5. Make this sentence more concise by reducing the relative clause: 'Students who are interested in the summer internship should apply online.'

6. Describe a place you love in one or two sentences using one defining clause and one non-defining clause.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'Precision Portraits' with your partner. Take turns describing two people, two places, or two important objects from your own life without naming them first — packing your clues into relative and reduced clauses.

• For each description, include at least one defining clause (identifying who/what/where it is), one non-defining clause (adding an extra story or comment), and one reduced clause (-ing or past participle).

• Once your partner guesses or hears your portrait, work together to tighten one long two-sentence description into a single crisp sentence.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: I'm thinking of a small bookshop standing opposite our old high school, where I used to spend every Thursday afternoon. The owner, whose family has run the shop for forty years, always kept a shelf of second-hand English novels for students.

B: That sounds wonderful — did he recommend books to you, or did he let you browse on your own?

Your conversation goal: Two successful guesses per pair: each description contains one defining and one non-defining clause, and both partners leave with one improved, more concise sentence.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ chooses who, which, that, whose, and where accurately

✓ distinguishes between defining meaning and non-defining extra detail

✓ omits object pronouns or reduces clauses naturally to keep speech concise

✓ delivers clear, vivid descriptions that the partner can picture immediately

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

When you combine clause-commenting 'which', wh-clefts, and reduced clauses, your spoken descriptions gain the crisp authority of a skilled presenter.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Practise describing people and places around you with who, which, whose, and where — and deliberately drop the pronoun whenever it is the object ('the café we visited', 'the friend I called').

• Test every 'where' vs 'which' choice by checking whether the place means 'in/at which' ('the town where I lived') or acts as the direct object/subject ('the town that we visited').

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use ', which...' at the end of a spoken clause to evaluate the impact of a whole situation: 'They moved the meeting to eight in the morning, which gave everyone the afternoon free to finish their reports.'

• Use 'What...' nominal relative clauses to spotlight what matters most: 'What impressed me most was how calmly she answered the tough questions.'

• Use reduced passive and active clauses for crisp professional summaries: 'Applications received after Friday will be held for the next intake' · 'Anyone needing transport should notify the office.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to choose one person who has had a lasting influence on your life. Jot down three keywords only: who they are (defining clause), one memorable background detail about them (non-defining clause with 'who' or 'whose'), and one specific piece of advice or habit they passed on to you (reduced clause).

Speak without reading: One-minute tribute talk: Describe a person who influenced you — a teacher, family member, colleague, or friend. Use at least two defining relative clauses, one non-defining relative clause (including 'whose' or ', which'), and one concise reduced clause. Speak naturally without notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare

The person who influenced my study habits most is my uncle, who taught secondary-school physics for over thirty years. He is the person whose advice I still hear whenever I sit down to tackle a difficult project: always start with the part that scares you most. The students taught by him at our local school respected him because he never lost his patience, which made even shy learners brave enough to ask questions. Anyone working alongside him quickly learns the same quiet lesson — steady preparation beats last-minute talent every time.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses defining relative clauses (and dropped object pronouns) naturally to identify people and things

✓ includes at least one non-defining clause ('..., who...', '..., whose...', or '..., which...') accurately

✓ includes at least one concise reduced clause (-ing or past participle)

✓ paints a vivid, memorable portrait of the person and their influence

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Defining relative clauses identify essential meaning (no commas; object pronouns like 'that/who/which' are often dropped in speech).

• Non-defining relative clauses add extra information with commas/pauses — always use 'who/which/whose/where', never 'that'.

• Reduce 'who/which/that + be' before -ing verbs, past participles, and adjectives to make descriptions tighter ('the data published today').

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'The book what I read was great.' → 'The book (that) I read was great.' (Never use 'what' after a noun as a relative pronoun.)

→ 'My mother, that lives in Kandahar, called.' → 'My mother, who lives in Kandahar, called.' (Never use 'that' after a comma.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Describe two people you know: one using 'whose' and one using a non-defining clause with ', who...'.

• Take the sentence 'The students who are waiting outside have registered' and say the reduced version aloud.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can combine choppy sentences smoothly using who, which, that, whose, and where.

☐ I can drop object pronouns and reduce relative clauses naturally when speaking.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 12 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. who · 2. which · 3. where · 4. whose · 5. which / that (or omit 'which/that were' to form the reduced clause 'The survey results published this morning...') · 6. that / which

Practice B: 1. The instructor who taught us academic speaking last term is outstanding. · 2. My uncle, who is an experienced airline pilot, has flown to over forty countries. / My uncle, who has flown to over forty countries, is an experienced airline pilot. · 3. My mother, who lives in Kandahar, is visiting us next Friday. · 4. The article (that / which) I read on the train was eye-opening. · 5. Students interested in the summer internship should apply online. · 6. answers vary

REVIEW TEST 3

Cumulative review — Lessons 1–12 · 15 questions · suggested time: 20 minutes

Part A — Complete the sentences.

1. The house _____ (build) in the 1960s.
2. I had my watch _____ (repair) last week.
3. She is said _____ (speak) five languages.
4. He avoided _____ (make) the same mistake twice.
5. This is the café _____ we first met.
6. She is the teacher _____ class inspired me. (who / whose)
7. I'd rather you _____ (not/mention) this to anyone.
8. He talks as if he _____ (know) everything.

Part B — Rewrite, combine or transform.

1. Rewrite with need: 'The room must be cleaned.'
2. Rewrite as a deduction (past): 'Perhaps he missed the train.'
3. Reduce: 'Students who are interested in the course should apply.'
4. Make it formal and passive: 'People believe that the economy is improving.'

Part C — Use and communication.

1. Complete: The _____ (much) you practise, the _____ (confident) you become.
2. Correct the indirect question: 'Do you know where is the bank?'
3. Complete the causative: I _____ my hair cut yesterday.
4. Correct: 'I enjoy to read novels.'

When you finish, check your work in Appendix 5. The answers are kept separate so you can complete the test without seeing them.

LESSON 13 · REPORTED SPEECH AND REPORTING VERBS

Part 7 — Sound More Natural and Advanced | Speaking goal: report conversations and summarise information accurately and naturally

Listen to how an inexperienced speaker recounts a meeting: 'The manager said, "We have a problem." Then Sara said, "Let's delay the launch." Then the manager said, "No, we can't."' Now listen to how an experienced speaker summarizes the exact same exchange in one breath: 'When the manager explained that we had a problem, Sara suggested delaying the launch, but he insisted on keeping the original date.'

Nearly half of everyday conversation consists of telling one person what another person said, asked, promised, or advised. When you master reported speech and expressive reporting verbs, you stop reciting transcripts and start summarizing ideas with clarity and style.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Think about two real messages or conversations from your week:

• A piece of advice or a reminder a family member, teacher, or colleague gave you recently.

• A question someone asked you this week — and how you answered it.

Tell your partner about both moments without quoting the speaker's exact words ('She told me that…', 'He asked me whether…', 'They reminded me to…'). Which parts felt easy to report, and where did you pause to think?

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Stepping back in time: tense backshift and when to keep the present

When you report what someone said in the past, the original moment of speaking is now behind you. To reflect that distance, English normally shifts the verb one step back in time: present simple becomes past simple, present continuous becomes past continuous, past simple and present perfect become past perfect, 'will' becomes 'would', and 'can' becomes 'could'.

However, backshift is not a blind mechanical rule. If what the speaker said is a permanent truth, or a situation that is still clearly true right now, you can either shift the tense or keep the present tense.

Pattern:

Standard backshift: am/is/are → was/were · work → worked · worked / have worked → had worked · will → would · can → could

Forms that stay unchanged: would, could, should, might, and past perfect (had done) stay as they are

Natural examples:

• Direct: "I'm working on the budget." → Reported: He said (that) he was working on the budget.

• Direct: "We've already booked the hall." → Reported: They told us (that) they had already booked the hall.

• Direct: "I'll call you this evening." → Reported: She said she would call me that evening.

• Direct: "My sister lives in Bamyan." → Reported: He said his sister lives / lived in Bamyan. (still true today)

Keep in mind:

→ Watch the difference between 'say' and 'tell': 'say' never takes a personal object directly ('He said that he was ready' or 'He said to me…'), while 'tell' must have a person right after it ('He told me that he was ready' — never 'He said me…').

Rule 2 — Reporting questions, requests, and commands

When you report a question ('She asked me where I lived'), it is no longer a direct question — it is a statement about a question. That means you drop the question mark, drop the auxiliary 'do/does/did', and return the words to normal statement order (subject + verb)!

For Yes/No questions, link with 'if' or 'whether'. For requests and commands, use 'asked / told / warned + person + (not) to + base verb'.

Pattern:

Reported Wh- question: asked (+ person) + Wh- word + subject + verb (no inversion!)
Reported Yes/No question: asked (+ person) + if / whether + subject + verb
Reported command / request: told / asked / advised / warned + person + (not) to + base verb

Natural examples:

• Direct: "Where did you park the car?" → She asked me where I had parked (or: parked) the car.
• Direct: "Are the results ready?" → He asked whether the results were ready.
• Direct: "Please check the figures twice." → The director asked us to check the figures twice.
• Direct: "Don't touch the wet paint!" → He warned the children not to touch the wet paint.

Keep in mind:

→ Place 'not' before 'to' in negative commands: 'She told me not to worry' (not 'She told me to not worry' or 'not worry').

Rule 3 — Summarising with expressive reporting verbs

If you report every sentence with 'He said… and then she said…', your story quickly sounds repetitive. Reporting verbs like admit, suggest, promise, deny, remind, warn, apologise, and insist capture the speaker's exact attitude in a single word — provided you pair each verb with its natural grammar pattern.

Pattern:

Verb + to + base verb: agree · offer · promise · refuse · threaten + to do
Verb + person + (not) to + base verb: advise · encourage · invite · remind · persuade · tell · warn + someone to do
Verb + verb-ing (or that-clause): admit · deny · recommend · suggest + doing · apologise for / insist on + doing

Natural examples:

• He admitted making a calculation mistake in the first table. (admit + -ing)
• She promised to send the feedback before Friday morning. (promise + to + verb)
• The doctor advised my father to walk for thirty minutes every day. (advise + person + to + verb)
• Tariq suggested taking the early train to avoid the crowd. (suggest + -ing)

Keep in mind:

→ Never say 'She suggested me to go' or 'He explained me the rule' — say 'She suggested going / that we go' and 'He explained the rule to me.'

Rule 4 — Shifting time and place words naturally

When you report a conversation days or weeks later in a different place, adjust the time and place words so they match your listener's viewpoint (now → then, today → that day, yesterday → the day before, tomorrow → the next day, here → there).

Pattern:

today → that day · yesterday → the day before / the previous day · tomorrow → the next day / the following day
now → then / at that moment · last week → the week before · here → there · this → that

Natural examples:

• Direct (on Monday): "I'll finish the report tomorrow." → Reported (on Friday): She said she would finish the report the next day.
• Direct (on Monday): "I'll finish the report tomorrow." → Reported (later on Monday): She said she'll / she'd finish the report tomorrow.

Keep in mind:

→ Use common sense with time words: if you are reporting a conversation on the very same day, keep 'today' and 'tomorrow' as they are!

Part 3 · See the Difference

say vs tell vs ask — choosing the right core verb

say (+ that)	tell + person (+ that)	ask (+ person) + if / Wh- / to	How to keep them straight
He said (that) the meeting was over.	He told me (that) the meeting was over.	He asked me if the meeting was over.	'Say' focuses on the words (no personal object); 'tell' focuses on informing a person ('told me'); 'ask' reports a question or request.

Reporting later (backshift) vs reporting a still-true fact

Past situation (backshifted)	Permanent / still-true fact	Why both work
She said she was feeling exhausted.	She said she speaks three languages.	In the first, her tiredness belonged to that past moment, so we shift to 'was'. In the second, her ability to speak three languages is still true today, so 'speaks' (or 'spoke') is completely natural.

How reporting verbs compress whole sentences into one precise word

Compare how a specific reporting verb captures the tone without needing a long quote:

• "No, I definitely didn't leave the freezer door open!" → He denied leaving the freezer door open.

• "Don't forget to bring your passport tomorrow morning." → She reminded me to bring my passport the next morning.

• "Why don't we test the microphone before the guests arrive?" → He suggested testing the microphone before the guests arrived.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. "I am working on the presentation right now." → He said he _____ (work) on the presentation then.

2. "We have already submitted the application." → They told us they _____ (already / submit) the application.

3. "Where did you park the van?" → She asked me where I _____ (park) the van.

4. "Don't touch the hot Kettle!" → He warned the child _____ touch the hot kettle.

5. "I'll definitely help you revise on Saturday." → She promised _____ (help) me revise on Saturday.

6. "Let's take a ten-minute break before part two." → He suggested _____ (take) a ten-minute break.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Report this statement: 'I never drink coffee after six in the evening.' (He said…)

2. Report this question: 'When will the scholarship results be announced?' (They asked…)

3. Correct the mistake: 'He said me that the train had been cancelled.'

4. Correct the mistake: 'My colleague suggested me to apply for the fellowship.'

5. Report this sentence using the verb deny: '"No, I did not share the password with anyone."' (He denied…)

6. Report two helpful pieces of advice a teacher or family member has given you, using two different reporting verbs (such as advised, encouraged, reminded, or warned).

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'The Diplomatic Messenger'. Partner A speaks five short direct messages from everyday life (a complaint, a promise, a question, a warning, and a suggestion). Partner B listens carefully and reports each message aloud using a precise reporting verb — without repeating 'said' every time. Then swap roles.

• Partner A: create or adapt five one-sentence messages (for example: 'Why didn't the courier call me?', 'I'll send the slides by noon', 'Don't drive over the mountain pass at night', 'Why don't we meet at the library?', 'I'm sorry I missed your call').

• Partner B: report all five messages back to Partner A (or to a neighbouring pair) using at least four different reporting verbs, accurate backshift, and statement word order in questions.

How it sounds in conversation:

A (Direct): 'I'm really sorry I missed your presentation yesterday — I'll watch the recording tonight.'

B (Reported): 'She apologised for missing my presentation the day before and promised to watch the recording that night.'

Your conversation goal: Five faithfully reported messages per reporter, using at least four different reporting verbs, with one reported question and one reported command, that the listener can repeat accurately.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ uses tense backshift and time-reference shifts accurately

✓ uses statement word order (no 'do/did' inversion) in all reported questions

✓ uses at least four varied reporting verbs with their right patterns (promised to, suggested -ing, warned not to…)

✓ summarizes the meaning smoothly and naturally

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

In academic discussions, journalism, and workplace negotiations, reporting verbs also signal how much weight or skepticism you attach to someone else's words.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Practise the four core reporting-verb families as spoken chunks: 'promised / offered / agreed to do' · 'advised / reminded / warned me to do' · 'suggested / admitted / denied doing' · 'explained / pointed out that…'.

• Take three questions someone asked you today and report them aloud using 'asked me if…' and 'asked me where/when/why…'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use continuous or narrative frames to make spoken storytelling vivid: 'She kept insisting that she knew the shortcut' · 'He went on to explain how the system worked.'

• Use analytical reporting verbs in presentations and essays: 'The study points out / demonstrates / confirms that…' · 'Critics argue / question whether…'

• Distinguish neutral reporting from cautious skepticism: compare 'The minister stated that costs had fallen' (neutral) with 'The minister claimed to have reduced costs, although the audit disagreed' (cautious).

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to recall a real conversation you had recently — a family discussion, a job interview, a team meeting, or a lively debate with a friend. Jot down four keywords for what was said and pick four different reporting verbs before you speak (for example: asked, suggested, warned, promised, admitted, agreed).

Speak without reading: Ninety-second conversation recap: Retell a memorable conversation you had recently. Report at least four things that were said (including at least one question and one piece of advice or suggestion) using varied reporting verbs, and finish with your own reflection on how the conversation turned out.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Last Saturday my younger sister called to tell me that she had been offered a position at a graphic design studio. She admitted that she felt nervous about the tight deadlines, but she promised to give it her best effort for the first six months. Our father warned her not to sign the contract without checking the evening hours first, and she agreed to ask the director for a written schedule. She also asked me whether I thought she should negotiate the starting salary; I suggested showing them her portfolio from university before naming a figure. In the end, they offered her a better rate than she had expected.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ accurate backshift and time expressions throughout the retelling

✓ uses at least four varied reporting verbs with their natural grammar patterns

✓ reports questions with statement word order and advice/warnings with '(not) to + verb'

✓ ends with a clear personal comment on the outcome of the conversation

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• When reporting past speech, verbs normally step back one tense, and time/place words shift to match the listener's viewpoint.

• Reported questions return to normal statement word order (subject + verb) with 'if/whether' or a Wh- word — never invert with 'do/did'.

• Match each reporting verb to its grammar pattern: 'promised to do', 'warned me not to do', 'suggested doing', 'explained that…'.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'He said me that he was busy.' → 'He told me that he was busy' or 'He said that he was busy.'

→ 'She suggested me to take a taxi.' → 'She suggested taking a taxi' or 'She suggested that we take a taxi.'

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Report three things different people have said or asked you over the past two days.

• Say one sentence with 'warned', one with 'suggested', and one with 'asked whether' from memory.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can report statements, questions, and requests accurately without word-order slips.

☐ I can summarize conversations naturally using a variety of reporting verbs beyond 'say' and 'tell'.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 13 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. was working · 2. had already submitted · 3. had parked (or: parked) · 4. not to · 5. to help · 6. taking
Practice B: 1. He said (that) he never drank coffee after six in the evening. / He said (that) he never drinks coffee after six in the evening. · 2. They asked when the scholarship results would be announced. · 3. He told me that the train had been cancelled. / He said that the train had been cancelled. · 4. My colleague suggested applying for the fellowship. / My colleague suggested that I apply for the fellowship. · 5. He denied sharing the password with anyone. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'My teacher advised me to read aloud every morning, and my mother reminded me not to skip breakfast before an exam.')

LESSON 14 · PARTICIPLES AND ADVANCED SENTENCE PATTERNS

Part 7 — Sound More Natural and Advanced | Speaking goal: combine ideas concisely without losing clarity

Read this sentence carefully and picture what it literally says: 'Walking down the mountain road, the snowstorm started.' Grammatically, that sentence claims that the snowstorm had two legs and was walking down the mountain road! What the speaker meant, of course, was: 'Walking down the mountain road, we were caught in a snowstorm.'

Participles (-ing and past participles) allow you to compress two bulky clauses into one sleek, authoritative sentence — as long as you keep the subject clear and choose the right participle for the job.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Try combining each pair of sentences below into one smooth sentence aloud with your partner:

- Pair 1: 'She finished the presentation. Then she opened the floor to questions.'
- Pair 2: 'The lecture lasted three hours without a break. The students felt exhausted.'

Now compare: why do we call the lecture 'exhausting' (-ing) but the students 'exhausted' (-ed)? Discuss one experience you found 'exciting' or 'challenging' recently and how you felt during it.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Participle adjectives: -ing (the cause) vs -ed (the feeling)

Many everyday adjectives are built from verbs: boring / bored, confusing / confused, fascinating / fascinated, exhausting / exhausted. Confusing the two endings can lead to unintentional comedy: saying 'I am boring in class' tells your classmates that *you* put *them* to sleep!

Hold on to one simple principle: the '-ing' adjective describes the source that *causes* the feeling, while the '-ed' adjective describes how a person *feels* inside as a result.

Pattern:

Present participle adjective (-ing) → the source / cause of the experience: a confusing instruction · an inspiring talk
Past participle adjective (-ed) → the person experiencing the feeling: confused applicants · inspired listeners

Natural examples:

- The documentary about deep-sea exploration was fascinating, and the audience was fascinated.
- Working a twelve-hour shift at the hospital is exhausting, so the nurses are exhausted by evening.
- The new bus timetable is confusing — even regular commuters look confused.

Keep in mind:

→ A person can be described with '-ing' only when they are the cause of the feeling in others: 'Our history professor is very interesting' (she fascinates her students) versus 'Our history professor is very interested in ancient coins' (she feels curiosity).

Rule 2 — Participle clauses: compressing time, reason, and passive background

Instead of starting every sentence with a heavy clause ('Because she wanted to save time…', 'After he had reviewed the data…', 'The report, which was written in haste…'), you can compress the first clause into a participle phrase — provided both halves of the sentence share the exact same subject.

Use 'Verb-ing…' for an action happening at the same time or as the reason; use 'Having + past participle…' when the first action was clearly completed before the second; and use a 'Past participle…' when the opening idea is passive.

Pattern:

Simultaneous action or reason (active): Verb-ing …, subject + main verb → Walking into the hall, she spotted her friend.
Earlier completed action (active): Having + past participle …, subject + main verb → Having finished the exam, he breathed a sigh of relief.
Passive condition or reason: Past participle (or Having been + participle) …, subject + main verb → Built in 1920, the bridge still carries heavy traffic.

Natural examples:

• Realising that the train was about to leave, we ran to the platform. (= Because we realised…)
• Having lived in Kandahar for ten years, he knew every street in the old city. (= Because he had lived…)
• Warned about the approaching storm, the mountain guides postponed the climb. (= Because they had been warned…)

Keep in mind:

→ In a reduced opening clause with no stated subject, the understood subject should match the main clause: 'Walking to the station, I got soaked' (I was walking), not 'Walking to the station, the rain started.' An absolute clause names its own subject: 'With prices rising, families are worried.'

Rule 3 — Framing a whole situation: Given, Considering, and With + noun + participle

What if you want to set the stage with an outside factor that has its own subject (such as rising prices or an approaching deadline), or frame a professional judgment? English uses two clean patterns that never dangle:

1. Prepositional participle frames ('Given the tight budget…', 'Considering the weather…', 'All things considered…') which are established discourse markers that do not need to match the main subject.

2. Absolute clauses with 'With + noun + participle' ('With the exams approaching, the library is packed'), which explicitly state their own noun subject right after 'With'.

Pattern:

Evaluative frames: Given + noun phrase, … · Considering + noun phrase / that-clause, … · All things considered, …
With-absolute clause: With + noun + verb-ing / past participle, main clause

Natural examples:

• Given the limited rehearsal time, the students delivered an impressive performance.
• With winter approaching rapidly, the municipality repaired the heating pipes.
• Considering how little funding the project received, the results were remarkable.
• All things considered, moving the workshop to Saturday was the right call.

Keep in mind:

→ 'Given' and 'Considering' are exceptionally useful at the start of formal speaking responses because they let you weigh the context before stating your conclusion.

Rule 4 — Keeping compression natural in spoken English

Concision is not about sounding like a legal contract; it is about removing clutter so your key verbs stand out. In spoken English, using one or two well-placed participle openings in a two-minute talk makes you sound composed and articulate — using ten in a row makes you sound unnatural.

Pattern:

Two clauses with the same subject → Participle opening + main clause
Negative participle opening: Not knowing / Not having received …, subject + main verb

Natural examples:

• Not wanting to wake the children, we spoke in whispers.
• Not having received the agenda in advance, several members asked for extra time to read it.

Keep in mind:

→ To make any participle clause negative, place 'Not' (or 'Never') right at the front: 'Not knowing the route, I asked a taxi driver.'

Part 3 · See the Difference

-ing (the source) vs -ed (the experiencer)

-ing adjective (causes the feeling)	-ed adjective (feels the effect)	How to choose instantly
an inspiring speech	an inspired audience	The speech generates the inspiration (-ing); the audience feels it inside (-ed).
frustrating delays	frustrated passengers	The delays cause the frustration (-ing); the passengers experience it (-ed).

Full adverbial clause vs compressed participle clause

Full clause (everyday conversation)	Participle clause (crisp / formal)	What changes
After she had reviewed the patients' charts, she began her rounds.	Having reviewed the patients' charts, she began her rounds.	Both sentences mean the exact same thing; 'Having reviewed…' removes three unstressed words and sharpens the rhythm.
Because the manual was written in clear English, it was easy to follow.	Written in clear English, the manual was easy to follow.	The passive participle 'Written…' attaches directly to 'the manual'.

The subject-matching check — catching dangling participles

In a reduced participle clause with no stated subject, the understood subject should normally match the main clause: 'Opening the door, I felt the cold air' (I opened the door, and I felt the air) — not 'Opening the door, the room was cold' (which makes it sound as if the room opened the door!). Absolute clauses state their own subject, as in 'Weather permitting, we will leave at dawn' or 'With the rain pouring down, we stayed indoors.'

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. The three-hour lecture was so _____ (bore) that several people in the back row nodded off.

2. We were genuinely _____ (amaze) by how quickly the volunteers rebuilt the footbridge.

3. _____ (finish) her keynote speech, Dr Sadat invited questions from the audience. (earlier completed action)

4. _____ (warn) about the icy mountain pass, the drivers fitted snow chains before dawn. (passive participle)

5. _____ fuel prices rising this winter, many commuters are sharing rides to work. (With / Despite)

6. _____ (walk) into the laboratory, she immediately noticed the unlocked cabinet.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Compress into one sentence using Having + past participle: 'Because she had practised her talk five times, she spoke without hesitation.'

2. Compress by reducing the relative clause: 'The technician who was standing by the generator switched off the power.'

3. Repair the dangling participle so the subject matches: 'Opening the window, the fresh morning breeze cooled the room.'

4. Rewrite more concisely starting with Given: 'When you take the tight deadline into account, the team's report is very thorough.'

5. Correct the adjective mistake: 'I have always been very interesting in architectural history.'

6. Write one sentence of your own starting with 'Having + past participle…' about something you did earlier today.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Play 'The Sixty-Second Executive Briefing'. Take turns giving a calm, concise 60-second briefing to your partner on a recent project, trip, or community event — using participle structures to pack background and reasons cleanly.

• In your 60-second briefing, include: (1) one 'Having + past participle' clause for an earlier step, (2) one framing opener with 'Given…', 'Considering…', or 'With + noun + -ing', and (3) one pair of -ing and -ed adjectives.

• While you listen to your partner, check that every participle opening matches the subject that follows it, then summarize their briefing back in one sentence.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: Given the short notice we received last Monday, our student book fair went remarkably well. Having collected over three hundred donated books during the week, we set up four stalls in the courtyard. The morning setup was exhausting, but everyone felt energised when the first visitors arrived.

B: So having gathered the books in just a few days, you managed to run a busy fair despite the exhausting start!

Your conversation goal: One 60-second briefing per partner containing the three required structures, plus a listener's one-sentence report-back that matches the briefing's content.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ every reduced participle clause matches the subject of the main clause

✓ uses 'Having + past participle' and passive/active participles accurately

✓ distinguishes clearly between -ing (cause) and -ed (feeling) adjectives

✓ maintains natural spoken clarity without overloading a single sentence

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Used thoughtfully, participle and absolute phrases give formal talks, policy recommendations, and academic summaries a composed, effortless flow.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Test every -ing/-ed adjective pair on real situations from your week: tiring / tired, encouraging / encouraged, overwhelming / overwhelmed, satisfying / satisfied.

• Whenever you start a sentence with an -ing or -ed phrase, make sure the very next word after the comma is the person or thing doing (or receiving) that action.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use negative participle openings for concise reasons: 'Never having spoken in front of a camera before, he practised with a timer first' · 'Not wanting to delay the team, she sent the summary ahead.'

• Use formal absolute expressions when closing a meeting or summarizing a situation: 'Weather permitting, fieldwork will begin on Monday' · 'There being no further objections, the schedule was approved.'

• Close formal recommendations with 'Considering all the evidence,…' or 'All things considered,…' to signal a balanced final judgment.

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 45 seconds to choose one practical improvement for your school, university, or workplace (such as shifting morning hours, creating a quiet study zone, or introducing a mentorship system). Jot down three keywords only: the problem evidence ('Given…' or 'Having reviewed…'), your specific recommendation, and your closing judgment ('All things considered…').

Speak without reading: Ninety-second policy recommendation: Present one practical change to improve your school or workplace. Open with 'Given…' or 'Considering…', include at least one 'Having + past participle' clause and one -ing/-ed adjective contrast, and close with 'All things considered…'. Speak without reading.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Given the number of late arrivals during the winter months, I would recommend shifting our first morning seminar from eight o'clock to eight-thirty. Having reviewed the attendance logs from last January, our committee noticed that almost all delays occurred before eight-fifteen, when icy roads make the morning commute frustrating for drivers and passengers alike. Many tired students walk in ten minutes late, missing the opening explanation of the lecture. With classes starting just thirty minutes later, everyone could travel more safely and arrive focused. All things considered, a one-month winter trial costs nothing and would benefit the entire department.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ includes at least two accurate participle or framing structures ('Given…', 'Having reviewed…', 'With…')

✓ keeps the subject of every reduced participle clause aligned with the main clause

✓ uses -ing and -ed adjectives accurately ('frustrating commute', 'tired students')

✓ delivers a clear, composed, and persuasive recommendation

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Use '-ing' adjectives for the source that causes a feeling ('a tiring journey') and '-ed' adjectives for the person who feels it ('tired travellers').

• Participle clauses ('Walking…', 'Having finished…', 'Written in…') compress two clauses into one — make sure their understood subject matches the main-clause subject.

• Use 'Given…', 'Considering…', and 'With + noun + participle' to frame evidence and background formally.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'Opening the window, the room felt cold.' → 'Opening the window, I felt the cold air.' (The room did not open the window!)

→ 'I am very interesting in history.' → 'I am very interested in history.' (People feel '-ed' about a subject.)

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Say one sentence about your morning starting with 'Having + past participle…'.

• Describe a recent class, book, or journey using one '-ing' adjective and one '-ed' adjective.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can compress two connected clauses into a clean participle sentence without losing the subject.

☐ I can use 'Given…', 'Considering…', and -ing/-ed adjectives naturally in formal speech.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 14 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. boring · 2. amazed · 3. Having finished · 4. Warned / Having been warned · 5. With · 6. Walking

Practice B: 1. Having practised her talk five times, she spoke without hesitation. · 2. The technician standing by the generator switched off the power. · 3. Opening the window, I felt the fresh morning breeze cool the room. / When I opened the window, the fresh morning breeze cooled the room. · 4. Given the tight deadline, the team's report is very thorough. · 5. I have always been very interested in architectural history. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Having had a cup of green tea, I sat down to read Lesson 14.')

LESSON 15 · HEDGING, EMPHASIS, AND NATURAL INVERSION

Part 8 — Speak with Confidence | Speaking goal: control certainty, emphasis and formality like an educated speaker

Imagine two economists on a panel discussion. The first says, 'This tax policy will destroy small businesses.' The second says, 'The evidence suggests that this policy may well place extra pressure on small businesses — and it is the rural shopkeepers who will feel that pressure first.' Who sounds more credible?

Experienced speakers know two secrets of authority: they soften unproved claims so no one can accuse them of exaggerating (*hedging*), and they save their strongest grammatical spotlights (*cleft sentences* and *inversion*) for the one key sentence they want the audience to remember.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Read these two pairs of sentences aloud with a partner, paying attention to tone and voice stress:

• Pair 1 (Certainty): 'Working from home makes people lazier.' vs. 'Working from home can sometimes make it harder to separate rest from work.'

• Pair 2 (Spotlight): 'The practical examples helped me most.' vs. 'What helped me most were the practical examples.'

With your partner, take one controversial opinion about education or work and say it twice: first as a blunt 100% generalisation, and second as a careful, measured claim that an expert would respect.

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — Hedging: matching the strength of your claim to the evidence

In real life, very few social or economic statements are true 100% of the time for 100% of people. When you say 'Social media ruins concentration,' a listener only has to think of one exception to reject your argument.

Hedging is the art of calibrating your claim with modal expressions ('may well', 'could'), tendency verbs ('tend to', 'seem to', 'appear to'), frequency qualifiers ('in many cases', 'broadly speaking'), or impersonal frames ('the data suggests that…', 'it could be argued that…'). Hedging can make a claim sound measured when evidence is limited or a conclusion is uncertain. Academic and professional speakers often hedge; too much hedging, however, can make a message unclear.

Pattern:

Modal hedges: may / might / could + base verb · may well (= quite likely) · is likely to + verb
Tendency verbs: tend(s) to + base verb · seem(s) / appear(s) to + base verb
Evidence & argument frames: The evidence suggests that … · It could be argued that … · In most cases, …

Natural examples:

• Students who study in short daily sessions tend to retain vocabulary longer.
• Upgrading the regional roads may well reduce transport costs by twenty percent.
• The preliminary figures suggest that enrolment has risen this autumn.
• It could be argued that practical apprenticeships are just as valuable as university degrees.

Keep in mind:

→ Use one well-chosen hedge per claim, not three piled on top of each other: 'This policy may well reduce costs' sounds thoughtful; 'Perhaps this policy might possibly seem to reduce costs' sounds unsure.

Rule 2 — Spotlight emphasis: cleft sentences and emphatic "do"

In writing, you can underline or bold a word to make it stand out. In speaking, English gives you a structural spotlight called a *cleft sentence*, which splits a single sentence into two halves so the listener's ear lands squarely on the key point.

Use an 'It-cleft' ('It was the cost that delayed us') to contrast one specific person, thing, or time with others; use a 'Wh-cleft' ('What we need now is clear communication') to build anticipation before delivering your main point; or add 'do / does / did' before a base verb for warm personal emphasis.

Pattern:

It-cleft: It is / was + focused item + that / who + rest of clause → It was Mariam who solved the problem.
Wh-cleft: What + clause + is / was + focused item (or base/to-verb) → What matters most is consistency.
Auxiliary emphasis: Subject + do / does / did + base verb → I do appreciate your patience.

Natural examples:

- It wasn't the grammar rules that held me back — it was my fear of speaking aloud.
- What surprised the researchers most was how rapidly the village adopted solar power.
- We didn't win the tournament, but we did learn how to play as a real team.

Keep in mind:

→ When you speak an It-cleft or auxiliary emphasis sentence, match the grammar with vocal stress on the spotlighted word: 'It was the DEADLINE that forced our hand' · 'She DID call you yesterday.'

Rule 3 — Negative and limiting inversion: formal rhetorical power

When you place a strong negative or limiting expression ('Never', 'Rarely', 'Seldom', 'Not only', 'Only after…', 'Under no circumstances') at the very beginning of a sentence for dramatic or formal emphasis, English flips the subject and auxiliary verb into question word order.

Because inversion is a high-impact rhetorical device, treat it like a trumpet note in a speech: using it once at a key moment commands attention; using it in every paragraph sounds theatrical.

Pattern:

Negative adverbial + auxiliary + subject + verb: Never have I seen … · Rarely does a team achieve … · Seldom had we faced …
Correlative addition: Not only + did/has/is + subject + verb …, (but) … also …
Limiting 'Only' phrase: Only then / Only after + phrase/clause + did + subject + base verb

Natural examples:

- Never have I heard a more practical explanation of the issue.
- Not only did the clinic treat patients free of charge, but it also trained local nurses.
- Rarely do we get a second chance to make a first impression.
- Only after reading the contract a second time did I notice the hidden fee.

Keep in mind:

→ With 'Only after…', 'Only when…', and 'Not until…', wait until the main clause to invert the verb: 'Only when the plane landed did I relax' (do not invert 'the plane landed').

Rule 4 — Calibrating certainty and register to your audience

Notice how English organises probability and formality by meaning and context rather than on a rigid mathematical ladder. When your evidence is solid, state it firmly ('will', 'must be'); when it is probable, signal expectation ('should', 'is likely to', 'may well'); when it is one open possibility among others, keep the door open ('may', 'might', 'could').

Pattern:

Strong prediction / inference: will · must be · Expectation / high likelihood: should · be likely to · may well · Open possibility: may · might · could
Adjusting register: Formal (inversion, clefts, passives, full forms) ↔ Everyday conversation (contractions, direct active verbs)

Natural examples:

- Formal presentation: 'Not only does this approach reduce waste, but it may well lower operating costs.'
- Everyday workplace chat: 'This approach cuts waste, and it'll probably save us money too.'

Keep in mind:

→ A thoughtful hedge signals intellectual honesty — showing your listener that you are matching the strength of your claim to the strength of your evidence.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Three levels of commitment to the same prediction

Firm prediction (will)	Strong likelihood (may well)	Open possibility (could / might)	What your audience hears
The new rail link will transform regional trade.	The new rail link may well transform regional trade.	The new rail link could transform regional trade.	1. 'Will' = firm conviction. 2. 'May well' = strong likelihood based on current signs. 3. 'Could' = one realistic possibility if conditions go well.

Standard word order vs formal negative inversion

Everyday word order	Inverted emphasis (formal)	When to use it
I have never witnessed such determination.	Never have I witnessed such determination.	Same factual meaning, different impact: placing 'Never' first and inverting 'have I' elevates the sentence for a speech or key conclusion.
I understood the problem only after I visited the site.	Only after I visited the site did I understand the problem.	The 'Only after…' opening builds suspense and lands the insight ('did I understand') with sharp focus.

Moving the spotlight with cleft sentences

Direct statement	It-cleft (initial spotlight)	Wh-cleft (end spotlight)	How the focus shifts
The training budget needs urgent attention.	It is the training budget that needs urgent attention.	What needs urgent attention is the training budget.	1. Neutral statement. 2. It-cleft (contrasts the training budget with other budgets). 3. Wh-cleft (builds anticipation before naming the budget at the end).

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. _____ have I heard such a clear and fair summary of the debate. (Never / Ever)

2. Not only _____ (she / pass) the fellowship exam, but she also achieved the highest score in the province.

3. Only after reading the instructions twice _____ (I / understand) how the device worked.

4. The survey data _____ (suggest) that evening classes are popular with working parents. (hedged claim)

5. It was _____ that convinced the committee to approve the project. (spotlight 'the detailed budget')

6. Learners who practise out loud _____ (tend) to build fluency faster than those who only read silently.

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Hedge this sweeping claim so it sounds measured and credible: 'Online learning will replace classrooms everywhere.'

2. Rewrite as an It-cleft focusing on 'the practical examples': 'The practical examples made the lesson easy to follow.'

3. Rewrite using formal negative inversion starting with Rarely: 'We had rarely seen such rapid progress in a single term.'

4. Correct the word-order mistake: 'Never I have seen such a busy market.'

5. Make the same request ('I need two more days to finish the report') at two register levels: (1) to a close teammate, and (2) in a formal meeting with a senior director.

6. Write one sentence about two strengths of a person you admire starting with 'Not only + auxiliary + subject…'.

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Hold a two-person 'Future of Work and Study Panel'. Take turns answering the panel question below for one minute each, using careful hedging for predictions and at least one emphatic structure (a cleft sentence or negative inversion) for your central thesis. Then ask your partner one challenging follow-up question.

• Panel question: 'How will artificial intelligence and online tools change the way people learn and work over the next ten years?'

• In your one-minute view, include: (1) at least two hedged claims ('may well', 'tend to', 'the evidence suggests'), (2) one Wh-cleft or It-cleft ('What will matter most is…' / 'It is… that…'), and (3) one emphatic 'do/did' or inversion.

How it sounds in conversation:

A: While software tools will handle routine translation, it is human judgment and empathy that will become even more valuable. Digital platforms may well make self-study faster, yet rarely do people master persuasive communication without live human feedback.

B: That's a thoughtful point — do you think rural schools will benefit equally from those tools, or could the gap widen at first?

Your conversation goal: Two one-minute answers per partner, each containing one well-placed hedge, one accurate emphasis structure and a clear conclusion — plus one careful answer to the partner's hard follow-up question.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ hedges predictions thoughtfully without stacking too many hedges together

✓ uses at least one cleft sentence or negative inversion accurately

✓ matches the strength of claims to realistic evidence

✓ handles the partner's challenging follow-up question with composure

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

Knowing when to soften a claim and when to spotlight a conclusion is what separates mechanical correctness from genuine rhetorical authority.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Practise expressing the same observation at three levels of certainty in context: firm inference ('will / must be'), reasonable expectation ('should / may well / is likely to'), and open possibility ('may / might / could') — and state what evidence supports each level.

• Say three core inversion frames aloud until the auxiliary-before-subject rhythm feels natural: 'Never have I…' · 'Not only did…' · 'Only then did I…'.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Use 'Little did I know / realise…' to add suspense at a turning point in a spoken story: 'Little did we realise how much that five-minute conversation would change our plans.'

• Use deliberate understatement (litotes) for composed, diplomatic evaluation: 'Reaching agreement across four departments was no small achievement' · 'The initial results are not unpromising.'

• Combine a formal inverted conditional with a hedged result in policy talks: 'Were the municipality to expand the bus network, peak-hour congestion might well fall by a third.'

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take 30 seconds to prepare a two-minute formal talk on improving education or professional training in your country. Jot down three single keywords only: one realistic benefit to hedge ('may well' / 'tends to'), one core priority to spotlight with a cleft ('It is… that…' or 'What we need most is…'), and one strong observation to frame with an inversion ('Rarely…' or 'Not only…').

Speak without reading: Two-minute keynote talk: 'One practical change that would strengthen education in my country.' Include at least one hedged claim, one cleft sentence, and one negative inversion, and finish with a clear, memorable call to action. Speak without reading from notes.

Model response — speak first, then compare

If we want to strengthen education across our country over the next decade, we must look first at practical access. It is reliable internet connectivity in district schools that will determine who benefits from modern learning tools. Rarely have we seen technology advance as rapidly in our major cities as it has in recent years, yet students in smaller towns often study without updated textbooks or digital libraries. Providing solar-powered digital libraries in district centres may well be the most cost-effective educational investment of the decade. Studies suggest that when teachers can share resources easily, classroom engagement rises within a single term. What our students need most is not a more complicated syllabus, but equal access to the tools that already exist.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses hedging naturally to make predictions and claims sound credible

✓ uses at least one cleft sentence ('It is... that...' / 'What... is...') to spotlight the central priority

✓ uses one negative or limiting inversion accurately for rhetorical impact

✓ delivers a composed, persuasive two-minute talk with a strong closing line

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• Hedging ('may well', 'tend to', 'the evidence suggests', 'it could be argued') calibrates your claims to your evidence and builds credibility.
• Cleft sentences ('It was X that...', 'What matters most is...') and auxiliary 'do/did' act as vocal spotlights for key information.
• Negative or limiting openers ('Never', 'Rarely', 'Not only', 'Only after...') trigger auxiliary + subject inversion — use them sparingly for high impact.

Common traps to avoid:

→ 'Never I have seen such a crowd.' → 'Never have I seen such a crowd.' (Invert the auxiliary before the subject after a negative opener.)
→ Avoid stacking hedges ('It might possibly perhaps tend to...') or inverting every sentence — clarity and balance always come first.

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Take one prediction about your field of work or study and say it at three levels of certainty: 'will', 'may well', and 'might'.

• Say one 'What... is...' cleft sentence and one 'Not only did...' sentence from memory.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can soften sweeping claims using natural hedging expressions when the evidence is not absolute.

☐ I can spotlight my most important point using a cleft sentence or a well-placed inversion.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 15 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. Never · 2. did she pass · 3. did I understand · 4. suggests (or: suggest) · 5. the detailed budget · 6. tend
Practice B: 1. Online learning may well replace some traditional lectures, or tends to complement classroom study. (answers vary) · 2. It was the practical examples that made the lesson easy to follow. · 3. Rarely had we seen such rapid progress in a single term. · 4. Never have I seen such a busy market. · 5. answers vary (e.g. Teammate: 'Could I have two more days on the report?' / Director: 'I was wondering if it might be possible to extend the deadline by two days so we can verify the final figures.') · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Not only does my mentor listen patiently, but she also gives practical advice.')

LESSON 16 · GRAMMAR IN REAL CONVERSATION

Part 8 — Speak with Confidence | Speaking goal: bring all the course grammar together in free, accurate, confident speech

When a skilled musician walks onto the stage, they are no longer thinking about individual finger exercises — they are listening to the music and shaping the phrase. Speaking a language works the same way. Over the past fifteen lessons, you have built every core grammatical tool you need for real-world English.

This final lesson is not about learning a brand-new rule. It is about seeing how all sixteen lessons fit together on one simple mental map, and mastering the habit that keeps confident speakers moving smoothly even when they slip: natural self-repair.

Part 1 · The Speaking Hook

Start the conversation

Play a 60-second warm-up round with your partner:

• Partner A speaks for 45 seconds without stopping on 'One decision that taught me something important.'

• Partner B listens not only to the story, but also to the grammar tools Partner A uses naturally (tenses, conditionals, linkers, relative clauses, modals, or passives), and names at least three of them at the end. Then swap roles!

Part 2 · The Simple Rule

Rule 1 — The whole course on one mental map: four jobs of spoken grammar

Whenever you open your mouth to answer a complex question — in a university seminar, a job interview, a workplace meeting, or the TOEFL speaking test — you do not need to search through sixteen separate chapters in your head. Every grammar pattern in this book performs one of just four practical jobs:

1. TIME (Lessons 1, 2, 13): placing events in the present, past, future, or reported speech.

2. CHOICE & POSSIBILITY (Lessons 4, 5, 6, 11): expressing modals, conditionals, wishes, and verb patterns (-ing / to).

3. SENTENCE SHAPE & FOCUS (Lessons 3, 8, 9, 10, 12, 14): asking questions, linking arguments, shifting focus with passives/causatives, and combining ideas with relative or participle clauses.

4. TONE & PRECISION (Lessons 7, 15): comparing persuasively, hedging claims, and spotlighting key ideas with clefts or inversion.

Pattern:

TIME: tenses (L1) · narrative layers (L2) · reported speech (L13)
CHOICE: modals (L4) · conditionals (L5) · wishes & regrets (L6) · gerunds & infinitives (L11)
SHAPE: questions & follow-ups (L3) · linkers (L8) · passive (L9) · causative (L10) · relatives (L12) · participles (L14)
STYLE: comparisons (L7) · hedging, clefts & inversion (L15)

Natural examples:

• Story + reflection in four moves: 'Two years ago I was working at a small clinic (TIME — L2) when my mentor encouraged me to apply for a fellowship (TIME/CHOICE — L13/L11). Although the exam was far more demanding than I expected (SHAPE/STYLE — L8/L7), passing it changed my career — and if I hadn't taken that chance, I wouldn't be teaching here today (CHOICE — L5).'

Keep in mind:

→ Accuracy always comes before complexity: a clear, accurate sentence that fits your meaning beats a complicated structure forced into the wrong place.

Rule 2 — The three-step speaking habit and the art of self-repair

Many learners think fluency means speaking fast without ever making a mistake. In reality, even native speakers and experienced professionals start sentences that head down a blind alley. The difference is that confident speakers do not freeze, apologize, or switch back to their first language — they use a smooth self-repair phrase ('What I mean is…', 'Or rather…', 'Let me put that another way…') and keep the message moving.

In speaking assessments and professional life alike, catching and repairing a slip calmly is a sign of high linguistic control.

Pattern:

The 3-step habit: 1. PICTURE the meaning → 2. PICK the right tool (Time / Choice / Shape / Style) → 3. SPEAK the chunk whole

Natural self-repair phrases: What I mean is … · Or rather, … · Let me rephrase that — … · To put it more precisely, …

Natural examples:

• Repairing a tense slip mid-sentence: 'I have seen him yesterday — or rather, I saw him yesterday afternoon outside the library.'
• Repairing a conditional slip: 'If I would have known — sorry, if I had known about the traffic, I would have taken the train.'
• Sharpening an idea: 'The new schedule is better — or to put it more precisely, it gives working students far more flexibility.'

Keep in mind:

→ Never stop dead in silence when you notice a grammar slip. Either repair it in one smooth breath with 'or rather…' or keep moving forward so your listener never loses the thread of your message.

Part 3 · See the Difference

Freezing on a mistake vs repairing like a confident speaker

Compare how two speakers handle the exact same mid-sentence grammar slip during a speaking task:

Freezing (loses fluency)	Natural self-repair (shows control)	Why the repair works
'Despite of the rain… uh… no, wait… although rain… sorry, I forgot the word…'	'Despite the heavy rain — or rather, although it was raining heavily — the outdoor concert went ahead.'	Speaker A panics over a preposition and loses the listener. Speaker B pivots smoothly with 'or rather', repairs the structure in stride, and finishes the thought with authority.

Knowing a rule on paper vs owning it under real-time pressure

You already recognize all sixteen grammar areas when you read them quietly. The four-round speaking workout below trains your brain to summon those same patterns on your feet while your attention is focused on communicating a real idea.

Part 4 · Practice the Pattern

A. Complete each sentence with the most natural form, then say it aloud.

1. Repair the mistake and name the rule: 'I have finished my university degree in 2022.'

2. Repair the mistake and name the rule: 'If the flight will be delayed tomorrow, we will call the hotel.'

3. Repair the mistake in two ways (despite / although): 'Despite of the cold wind, we walked to the summit.'

4. Repair the mistake and name the verb pattern: 'My supervisor suggested me to attend the workshop.'

5. Repair the word order: 'Never I have felt so proud of our team.'

6. Repair the verb form after 'to': 'We really look forward to host your delegation next month.'

B. Repair, transform, or build the sentence so the meaning is clear.

1. Compress using a participle opening: 'Because he had not slept the night before, he made several small calculation errors.'

2. Report this sentence in two ways (using 'told' and 'reassured'): '"Don't worry about the deadline," she said to me.'

3. Strengthen this flat comparison using 'far', a comparative, and a 'because' reason: 'Practising out loud is better than silent reading.'

4. Rewrite as a formal passive announcement: 'The committee has changed tomorrow's examination schedule.'

5. Hedge this sweeping claim so it sounds measured: 'This new teaching method is the best for every learner.'

6. Turn this direct question into a polite indirect question: 'What time does tomorrow's rehearsal start?'

Part 5 · Pair Speaking

Speak with a partner

Run the 'Four-Round Conversation Circuit' with your partner. In each round, speak for one full minute on the prompt while deliberately weaving in the target grammar family. Your partner listens, asks one follow-up question, and notes which structures they heard.

• Round 1 — Story & Time (Lessons 1, 2, 14): Tell the story of a challenge or problem you overcame, using narrative tenses and one participle opening.

• Round 2 — Choice & Advice (Lessons 4, 5, 6): Advise a friend who is torn between two career paths or cities, using modals, conditionals, and 'If I were you / I'd rather'.

• Round 3 — Report & Focus (Lessons 9, 10, 12, 13): Summarize a recent change or conversation at school, work, or in your city, using passives, reporting verbs, and relative clauses.

• Round 4 — Persuade & Spotlight (Lessons 7, 8, 15): Argue for one practical improvement in your community, using comparisons, concession linkers, hedging, and a cleft sentence.

How it sounds in conversation:

A (Round 4): Although expanding our public library hours would require extra staffing, it is by far the most helpful step we could take for students. What many learners lack at home is a quiet desk with reliable lighting...

B: If the library stayed open until nine, how do you think students would manage transport home in winter?

Your conversation goal: Four one-minute rounds per pair: each round delivered without notes, with the target structures counted aloud and at least one self-repair noted by the listener.

What makes this conversation work:

✓ summons structures from the target grammar family naturally in each round

✓ uses self-repair phrases smoothly if a slip occurs rather than stopping

✓ connects ideas with clear signposts and reasons

✓ responds to the partner's follow-up question with confidence and accuracy

Part 6 · Say It with Greater Precision

At your highest level of spoken control, different grammar families work together inside a single breath — combining a conditional with reported speech, or opening an argument with an inversion and closing it with a cleft.

From clear accuracy to richer expression

Make the core pattern automatic:

• Go back to any earlier lesson where an exercise made you hesitate and speak those corrected sentences aloud three times without looking at the page.

• Create four personal anchor sentences — one each for Time, Choice, Shape, and Style — about your own life goals this year.

Add nuance, detail, and sharper focus:

• Combine two course structures smoothly inside one sentence: 'Had I known that the application deadline had been brought forward, I would have had my transcripts translated a week earlier.'

• Pace your rhetorical style deliberately across a two-minute talk: open with a concrete story, hedge your central prediction, and land your conclusion with a crisp cleft sentence.

• Keep three natural self-repair and refinement phrases on the tip of your tongue: 'What I mean is...', 'Let me rephrase that...', and 'Or to put it more precisely...'.

Part 7 · Real Talk Challenge

Your speaking challenge

Prepare: Take one minute to plan your culminating two-minute talk on 'How my communication has changed — and where I am heading next.' Write down only three brief keyword lines: (1) Past story (where you started and what turning point changed your approach), (2) Present habits & choices (what you do differently now and why), and (3) Future goal (what you plan to achieve next and what it will take). Choose two precision structures (such as a mixed conditional, a non-defining relative clause, or a cleft) to weave in.

Speak without reading: Two-minute culminating challenge: Speak for two minutes on 'How I have grown as a speaker — and what comes next.' Tell a concrete story from your past, explain a decision that helped you improve, and state your next goal, using structures from at least six different lessons in this course. Then exchange two follow-up questions with your partner — just as you will in the Final Speaking Assessment.

Model response — speak first, then compare

Two years ago, I used to avoid speaking English in group meetings because I was afraid of making mistakes — while others were sharing their ideas, I would translate every sentence in my head until the moment had passed. Joining a weekly speaking circle, which a colleague recommended to me, was the turning point that changed that habit. Within a month, I had met partners who corrected me encouragingly, and I realised that communication is about clarity, not perfection. Since then, I've been practising aloud almost every day, and my supervisor has noticed the difference. Next spring I'm going to take the TOEFL exam so that I can apply for a graduate programme. If I keep building one small habit at a time, the score will take care of itself. What matters most to me now is staying calm under pressure — and that comes only from using my voice every day.

Partner listening checklist:

✓ uses a wide range of course structures (at least six lessons represented) accurately and naturally

✓ moves smoothly from past narrative to present reflection to future goal

✓ includes at least one precision or emphasis structure (relative clause, conditional, hedge, or cleft)

✓ maintains confident, continuous delivery and handles follow-up questions or self-repair smoothly

Part 8 · Review and Self-Check

Core insights to carry with you:

• All sixteen lessons serve four practical communication jobs: Time, Choice, Sentence Shape, and Style.

• Follow the three-step speaking habit: picture the meaning → pick the structure → speak the phrase whole.

• When you notice a slip in real conversation, use a natural repair phrase ('What I mean is…', 'Or rather…') and keep your message moving.

Common traps to avoid:

→ Never sacrifice clarity just to show off a complicated structure — natural accuracy always comes first.

→ Never freeze in silence after a small slip — repair calmly with 'or rather…' and continue.

Close the book and try this from memory:

• Name the four communication jobs of grammar and give one example sentence of your own for each job.

• Speak for 60 seconds about a goal for next year, deliberately including one conditional, one relative clause, and one cleft sentence.

Self-check — can you do this now?

☐ I can combine grammar patterns from across the course naturally in a two-minute unscripted talk.

☐ I can answer unexpected follow-up questions and self-repair smoothly without losing confidence.

If a box is unticked: return to Part 2 · The Simple Rule for this lesson, redo the matching practice item, and check Formula Book card 16 in Appendix 1 before you move on.

Quick answers

Practice A: 1. I finished my university degree in 2022. ('in 2022' is a finished past time → past simple) · 2. If the flight is delayed tomorrow, we will call the hotel. (ordinary future condition → present simple after 'if') · 3. Despite the cold wind, we walked to the summit. / Although the wind was cold, we walked to the summit. · 4. My supervisor suggested attending the workshop. / …suggested that I attend the workshop. ('suggest' takes -ing or a that-clause, never 'me to') · 5. Never have I felt so proud of our team. (negative opener triggers auxiliary + subject inversion) · 6. We really look forward to hosting your delegation next month. ('to' in 'look forward to' is a preposition → verb-ing)

Practice B: 1. Not having slept the night before, he made several small calculation errors. · 2. She told me not to worry about the deadline. / She reassured me that I didn't need to worry about the deadline. · 3. answers vary (e.g. 'Practising out loud is far more effective than silent reading because it trains your mouth and ear to work together in real time.') · 4. Tomorrow's examination schedule has been changed (by the committee). · 5. This new teaching method may well be one of the most effective for many learners. / This new teaching method tends to work very well for most learners. (answers vary) · 6. Could you tell me what time tomorrow's rehearsal starts? / Do you know what time tomorrow's rehearsal starts?

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Part 1: Grammar knowledge · Part 2: Independent speaking task

Part 1 — Grammar knowledge (30 questions · suggested time: 35 minutes)

Section A — Complete the sentences. (12 questions)

1. I _____ (live) here since 2020.
2. When I got home, my family _____ (already / have) dinner.
3. If it _____ (be) sunny tomorrow, we'll go to the lake.
4. I wish I _____ (not/say) that yesterday.
5. The meeting _____ (cancel) yesterday afternoon.
6. You look exhausted — you _____ (must / work) all night. (past deduction)
7. She avoided _____ (make) any promises.
8. The teacher made us _____ (rewrite) the essay.
9. This is the most _____ (challenge) course I've ever taken.
10. _____ (warn) about the storm, the fishermen stayed ashore.
11. He suggested _____ (leave) before the traffic.
12. Not only _____ (she / apologise), but she also offered a refund.

Section B — Rewrite or transform. (10 questions)

13. Report: 'I'll help you tomorrow,' he said.
14. Report: 'Where did you buy it?' (She asked me…)
15. Polite question: 'When does the shop close?'
16. Third conditional: 'He didn't revise, so he failed.'
17. Passive (formal): 'Someone has stolen the documents.'
18. Cleft (focus the manager): 'The manager approved the plan.'
19. Causative: 'I paid someone to fix the roof.'
20. Inversion: 'She had rarely felt so confident.'
21. Combine with although: 'The task was difficult. They finished it.'
22. Combine with a participle: 'Because he had studied hard, he passed easily.'

Section C — Use and communication. (8 questions)

23. Choose: He (mustn't / can't) be at home — his car is gone.
24. Complete with a linker: _____ being expensive, the course is worth it.
25. Hedge the claim: 'This method is the best.' (may well / probably)
26. Compare with nuance: 'Option A is better than Option B.' (use far + give a reason frame)
27. Correct: 'The book what I read was amazing.'
28. Complete: The more you practise, the _____ (confident) you become.
29. Report advice: 'You should apply early,' she said. (She advised…)
30. Complete with the right pattern: I look forward to _____ (meet) you.

Stop here until you have completed all 30 items. The answer key is in Appendix 5.

Accept alternative answers where the exercise allows them (e.g. 'may well' / 'probably' / 'is likely to' for hedging). The Diagnostic Test is a broad starting snapshot, not a parallel form of this 30-item assessment. Do not compare the raw grammar totals as a measure of gain; compare your four speaking-rubric criterion scores instead.

FINAL ASSESSMENT — PART 2

Independent speaking task and evaluation

Speaking task (2 minutes to prepare · 2 minutes to speak, then follow-up exchange)

Speak on ONE of the following topics:

- A decision that changed your life — and what you would do differently today.
- One change that would improve education or work in your country.
- A person who influenced you, and the advice they gave you.

After your talk, a partner asks two follow-up questions. Answer them, then ask one relevant question in return. If you get stuck, repair and continue.

You may make brief notes during the preparation time. Speak without reading a script.

Evaluation rubric

Criterion	4 — Strong	3 — Good	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Grammatical accuracy	structures are consistently accurate; occasional slips do not affect meaning	generally accurate; some errors, meaning always clear	frequent errors; meaning sometimes unclear	errors dominate; meaning often unclear
Appropriate structure selection	wide range used naturally (tenses, conditionals, linkers, hedging…) for the intended meaning	good range; choices usually match the meaning	limited range; some structures forced or inappropriate	basic structures only; frequent wrong choices
Clarity	ideas well organised and easy to follow; effective linking	clear overall; some linking	ideas loosely connected; hard to follow at times	ideas listed without clear connection
Successful communication	message fully delivered; natural delivery, relevant follow-up exchange and self-repair	message delivered; answers and asks relevant follow-ups, with some hesitation	message partly delivered; responses are limited or pauses are long	message largely not delivered; little response to questions

Score: ____ / 16 Compare each criterion with your recorded Diagnostic speaking score.

Personal error analysis and improvement plan

Copy every error you made in the Final Assessment (written and spoken) into the table. An error that is analysed is halfway to being fixed.

My error	Correct form	Why it happened (rule I forgot)	My fix — where I will practise it

My next three goals:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Remember: improvement is measured by what you can do in speech — not by pages completed. Record yourself speaking for two minutes on the same topic in a month, and listen to the difference.

APPENDIX 1 · GRAMMAR FORMULA BOOK

Sixteen cards — one per lesson. Review with this book closed first.

Card 1 — Tenses for Real Communication

Present simple = facts & habits · Present continuous = around now
Past simple = finished time · Present perfect = connected to now
going to = plan · will = decision/prediction · present continuous = arrangement

Card 2 — Telling Stories

Past continuous = the scene · past simple = the events · past perfect = the earlier past
when + past simple · while + past continuous · by the time + past perfect before past simple
Shape: background → events (First... Then...) → ending/reflection

Card 3 — Questions and Follow-ups

Wh- + auxiliary + subject + verb · Yes/No: auxiliary + subject + verb
Indirect: question word + subject + verb (no inversion) — 'Do you know where the bank is?'
Follow-ups keep conversations alive: 'Really? What happened next? How about you?'

Card 4 — Modal Verbs

Modal + base verb: can/could = ability · may/could = permission · must/have to = obligation · should = advice · might = possibility
must be = certainly (positive) · might be = possible · can't be = certainly not
mustn't = prohibition ≠ can't (deduction) · Would you mind + -ing?

Card 5 — Conditionals

Zero: If + present, present · First: If + present, will + verb
Second: If + past, would + verb · Third: If + past perfect, would have + participle
Mixed: If + past perfect, would + verb · unless = if not · ordinary future if-clause: present simple

Card 6 — Wishes and Regrets

wish + past simple = present wish · wish + past perfect = past regret
wish + would = complaint/request · If only…! = strong emotion
would rather + base (me) / + past (someone else) · It's (high) time + past

Card 7 — Comparisons

comparative + than (compare two) · superlative (extreme in a group) · as + adj + as
the + comparative, the + comparative · comparative + and + comparative
far / much / slightly / by far + comparison · comparisons persuade with reasons

Card 8 — Linking and Arguments

although + clause · despite / in spite of + noun or -ing · however = new sentence
because + clause · because of + noun · therefore / as a result = consequence
Argument skeleton: POINT → REASON → EXAMPLE → SUMMARY

Card 9 — Passive Voice

be + past participle (tense lives in 'be'): is done · was done · will be done · has been done · must be done
Use: result matters · doer unknown/obvious/general · objective tone
It is said that … = He is said to …

Card 10 — Causative Structures

have/get + object + participle = arrange a service (or: something happened to me)
make + person + base (force) · let + base (allow) · have + base (instruct) · get + to (persuade)
'get' keeps 'to' — the other three don't.

Card 11 — Gerunds and Infinitives

enjoy/avoid/mind/suggest/keep + -ing · decide/hope/plan/promise/refuse + to
remember/forget/stop/try: -ing = earlier action · to = later action
Preposition + -ing — including 'to' in look forward to / be used to

Card 12 — Relative Clauses

who (people) · which (things) · that (both) · whose · where — object pronouns can drop
Defining = no commas (identifies) · Non-defining = commas (extra detail, no 'that')
Reduced: 'the man (who is) standing there' — only drop who is / which was

Card 13 — Reported Speech

Backshift one tense: present → past → past perfect · will → would · can → could
ask + if/whether or question word + statement order · told/asked + person + to
say (+ that) vs tell (+ person) · time words shift: tomorrow → the next day

Card 14 — Participles

-ing adjective = causes feeling · -ed adjective = feels it (boring lecture / bored class)
Participle clause: 'Having finished, she left.' — subject must match the main clause
Frames: Given... / Considering... / With + noun + -ing

Card 15 — Hedging, Emphasis, Inversion

Hedge: may well / might / tend to / it could be argued that ...
Cleft: It was X that ... / What I need is ... · do-emphasis: 'I do believe...'
Inversion after negative openers: Never have I... / Not only did... / Only then did...

Card 16 — Grammar in Real Conversation

Four jobs: TIME (tenses, reported) · CHOICE (modals, conditionals, wishes) · SHAPE (questions, linkers, relatives, passives) · STYLE (comparison, hedging, emphasis)
Think meaning → choose structure → say it whole
Accuracy first, then range; repair and continue: 'What I mean is...'

APPENDIX 2 · COMMON ERRORS AND CORRECTIONS GUIDE

Thirty errors that mark learners — and the fix for each

✗ Error	✓ Correction	Why
I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.	finished time needs past simple
I am knowing the answer.	I know the answer.	state verbs take simple forms
She is more taller than me.	She is taller than me.	no double comparatives
This is better then that.	This is better than that.	than (comparison) not then (time)
If it will rain, we'll stay.	If it rains, we'll stay.	present simple in an ordinary future condition
If I would have known…	If I had known…	third conditional: if + past perfect
I wish I have more time.	I wish I had more time.	wish + past for unreal present
I'd rather you don't smoke.	I'd rather you didn't smoke.	would rather + subject + past
It's time we will go.	It's time we went.	it's time + past (already late)
Despite of the cost…	Despite the cost… / In spite of the cost…	no 'despite of'
Although the cost, we bought it.	Despite the cost, we bought it.	although + clause; despite + noun
Do you know where is the bank?	Do you know where the bank is?	indirect questions use statement order
Did she called you?	Did she call you?	base verb after did
He said me that he was tired.	He told me that he was tired.	tell + person; say + that
She suggested me to wait.	She suggested waiting.	suggest + -ing (or that + clause)
I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.	'to' here is a preposition
I enjoy to read.	I enjoy reading.	enjoy + -ing
He made me to wait.	He made me wait.	make + person + base verb
I will get my car to repair.	I will get my car repaired.	have/get + object + participle
The house was builted in 1990.	The house was built in 1990.	past participle of build = built
My phone was stolen by me.	I lost my phone.	active is clearer for your own actions
The book what I read…	The book (that) I read…	no 'what' as a relative pronoun
My mother, that lives…	My mother, who lives…	'that' is not used after commas
Never I have seen such a mess.	Never have I seen such a mess.	inversion after negative openers
He mustn't be at home.	He can't be at home.	can't = deduction; mustn't = prohibition
Would you mind to open the window?	Would you mind opening the window?	mind + -ing
I am very interesting in history.	I am very interested in history.	-ed = feels; -ing = causes
Opening the window, the room was cold.	Opening the window, I felt the cold.	participle subject must match
He denied to break it.	He denied breaking it.	deny + -ing
Unless you don't hurry…	Unless you hurry…	'unless' already means 'if not'

APPENDIX 3 · ESSENTIAL SENTENCE PATTERNS FOR SPEAKING

Build answers from these skeletons until they are automatic

Function	Patterns
Experience	I have (never) … · One experience that changed me was …
Story	First … Then … After that … Suddenly … Finally …
Opinion	I believe that … because … · From my point of view …
Reason	This is mainly because … · The main reason is that …
Example	For instance … · A good example of this is …
Contrast	Although …, … · Despite + noun/-ing … · On the other hand …
Concession	It is true that …; nevertheless … · Admittedly …; even so …
Result	As a result … · This means that … · Consequently …
Hedged claim	It could be argued that … · … may well … · … tend(s) to …
Emphasis	It is … that … · What I mean is … · I do believe …
Advice	If I were you, I'd … · You might want to … · It might be worth …
Regret	I wish I had … · If only I had … · What I should have done was …
Preference	I'd rather … than … · I prefer … to … · If I had to choose, I'd …
Prediction	In the future, … will probably … · … is likely to …
Polite request	Would you mind …-ing? · Could I possibly …? · I was wondering if …
Reporting	He said (that) … · She pointed out that … · They warned me not to …
Description	…, who/which … · The person who … · …, which means that …
Comparison	… is far more … than … · The more …, the more … · … is by far the most …
Process	First, … is done; then … is … · Having been …, … · … is then …
Summary	To sum up … · All in all … · The point I want to make is …
Self-repair	What I mean is … · Let me rephrase that … · Or rather …
Ending	That's why … · This taught me that … · Looking ahead, I plan to …

APPENDIX 4 · SPEAKING SELF-ASSESSMENT AND CAN-DO TRACKER

Tick honestly: ✓ = I can do this in speech · ~ = almost · ✗ = not yet

Speaking self-assessment

Record yourself for two minutes (any topic) and rate yourself with the Final Assessment rubric. Repeat after one month and compare the recordings — that is your true progress.

Lesson	Can-do statement	Before course	After Lesson 16
Lesson 1	I can talk about habits, current situations and past experiences accurately.		
Lesson 2	I can tell a story with background, clear sequence and a meaningful ending.		
Lesson 3	I can ask polite questions and keep a conversation going with follow-ups.		
Lesson 4	I can give advice, express obligation and show degrees of certainty with the right modal.		
Lesson 5	I can discuss real possibilities, imaginary situations and unreal pasts.		
Lesson 6	I can express wishes, regrets and preferences naturally.		
Lesson 7	I can compare options and support my comparisons with reasons.		
Lesson 8	I can link ideas and build a short argument with a clear skeleton.		
Lesson 9	I can choose active or passive for the right focus in reports and descriptions.		
Lesson 10	I can talk about services, arrangements and influence using causatives.		
Lesson 11	I can use gerund and infinitive patterns accurately, including meaning changes.		
Lesson 12	I can describe people and places precisely with defining and non-defining clauses.		
Lesson 13	I can report statements, questions and commands with accurate backshift.		
Lesson 14	I can compress ideas with participles without losing clarity.		
Lesson 15	I can control certainty, emphasis and formality in formal speech.		
Lesson 16	I can use the course grammar together in free, confident conversation.		

APPENDIX 5 · COMPLETE ANSWER KEY

All exercises, review tests and the final assessment

Alternative answers are accepted where the exercise allows them. Speaking tasks are evaluated with the success criteria and rubric — not with rigid model answers.

Diagnostic

A. 1. saw · 2. has worked / has been working · 3. was cooking · 4. had worked / had been working; 'worked' is also possible with before · 5. boils · 6. were building · 7. have lost · 8. went · 9. have read · 10. had already left
B. 1. rains · 2. knew · 3. repairing / to be repaired · 4. was written · 5. leaving · 6. the station is · 7. who / that · 8. didn't smoke · 9. more intelligent · 10. did she finish
C. 1. can't · 2. Despite · 3. where I lived / where I live (if still true) · 4. may / might / could · 5. had / got

Lesson 1

Practice A: 1. saw · 2. has worked / has been working · 3. are meeting · 4. is snowing · 5. believes
Practice B: 1. I finished my assignment last night. ('last night' is a finished time) · 2. She knows three foreign languages. ('know' is a state verb) · 3. have you known · 4. I'm going to study medicine next year.

Lesson 2

Practice A: 1. was studying · 2. had already eaten · 3. called / took · 4. was walking / saw · 5. had finished · 6. were playing / was resting
Practice B: 1. While I was reading the contract, the office printer jammed. · 2. By the time we reached the station, the train had left. · 3. When I arrived at the hall, the speaker had already left. · 4. answers vary · 5. while · 6. It was raining hard, and because I had forgotten my umbrella at work, I got soaked. (answers vary)

Lesson 3

Practice A: 1. Have / tried · 2. happened · 3. the main library is · 4. costs · 5. wrote · 6. did / speak
Practice B: 1. Could you tell me where you parked your car? · 2. Do you know when the exam results will be ready? / Could you tell me when the exam results will be ready? · 3. Do you know where the nearest pharmacy is? · 4. answers vary (e.g. 'What field are you thinking of moving into?' / 'What made you decide to make a change?') · 5. Did she call you after the interview? · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'How long have you been studying English?')

Lesson 4

Practice A: 1. should · 2. could · 3. must · 4. mustn't · 5. might / may / could · 6. Would / opening
Practice B: 1. Could you open the window, please? / Would you mind opening the window? · 2. She must be at home. · 3. He might have missed the early train. / He may / could have missed the early train. · 4. He can't be at home — all his lights are off. · 5. No, not at all. / Of course not — take your time. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'You should drink some water and rest your eyes. You might also want to step outside for some fresh air.')

Lesson 5

Practice A: 1. heat / boils · 2. rains / will cancel (or: 'll cancel) · 3. were / would apologise · 4. had left / wouldn't have missed · 5. knew / would call · 6. will go / stays
Practice B: 1. Unless you register before Friday, you can't attend the seminar. · 2. If he had checked the timetable, he wouldn't have missed the ferry. · 3. If she had saved enough money last year, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy the car now. · 4. If I have free time tonight, I will review the vocabulary. · 5. answers vary (e.g. 'If I were you, I wouldn't resign until I had a signed offer in hand.') · 6. answers vary

Lesson 6

Practice A: 1. knew · 2. hadn't said · 3. owned · 4. made · 5. didn't tell · 6. were (or: was in informal speech)
Practice B: 1. I wish I had studied harder at school. · 2. I'd rather you didn't smoke near the doorway. · 3. I wish I had more free time this semester. · 4. It's already midnight — it's time we went home. · 5. reading / watching · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'He burst through the door out of breath, as if he had run all the way from the station.')

Lesson 7

Practice A: 1. shorter · 2. the worst · 3. more / faster · 4. more confidently · 5. as / as · 6. most talented

Practice B: 1. The new battery lasts twice as long as the old one. · 2. My younger brother is taller than me now. · 3. Practising with a partner is far better than studying alone because you have to respond in real time. (answers vary) · 4. answers vary (e.g. 'The more often you speak in class, the more confident you feel.') · 5. This dictionary is much clearer than my old one. · 6. answers vary

Lesson 8

Practice A: 1. Despite · 2. Despite (followed by -ing; 'Although' needs a subject + verb: 'Although she felt exhausted') · 3. however · 4. so that · 5. As a result · 6. whereas

Practice B: 1. Although the assignment was challenging, every group finished on time. · 2. Despite not being selected the first time, she applied again the following year. / Despite the initial rejection, she applied again. · 3. Despite the high cost, the hospital purchased the new scanner. · 4. answers vary — must include a clear point, a reason, and an example · 5. Despite the rain, the football match continued. / Although it was raining, the football match continued. · 6. answers vary — must close with To sum up / All in all / In conclusion

Lesson 9

Practice A: 1. was built · 2. will be announced · 3. is cleaned · 4. was stolen · 5. has just been introduced · 6. be submitted

Practice B: 1. My bicycle has been stolen. · 2. The board made the final decision. · 3. It is said that he is the strongest candidate. / He is said to be the strongest candidate. · 4. The old courthouse was built in 1990. · 5. I lost my phone on the way home. · 6. The main tunnel will be closed tomorrow for maintenance.

Lesson 10

Practice A: 1. altered · 2. cut · 3. lose · 4. use · 5. tested · 6. to turn

Practice B: 1. I had my car serviced last week. · 2. After a long discussion, I got my friend to drive us to the airport. · 3. I will get my laptop repaired tomorrow. · 4. The security guard made us wait outside in the rain. · 5. answers vary (e.g. 'I had my watch battery replaced on Monday.') · 6. Could I have my phone screen replaced today? / How much would it cost to get my phone screen replaced?

Lesson 11

Practice A: 1. helping · 2. criticising · 3. to accept · 4. hearing · 5. smoking · 6. to open

Practice B: 1. I really enjoy reading historical biographies in the evening. · 2. We look forward to meeting your team on Monday. · 3. My colleague suggested leaving early before the snow started. / ...suggested that we leave early... · 4. The classroom needs cleaning before tomorrow. / The classroom needs to be cleaned before tomorrow. · 5. posting (because I posted it first and I recall the memory of doing it now) · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Instead of cramming the night before an exam, I review my notes for fifteen minutes every evening.')

Lesson 12

Practice A: 1. who · 2. which · 3. where · 4. whose · 5. which / that (or omit 'which/that were' to form the reduced clause 'The survey results published this morning...') · 6. that / which

Practice B: 1. The instructor who taught us academic speaking last term is outstanding. · 2. My uncle, who is an experienced airline pilot, has flown to over forty countries. / My uncle, who has flown to over forty countries, is an experienced airline pilot. · 3. My mother, who lives in Kandahar, is visiting us next Friday. · 4. The article (that / which) I read on the train was eye-opening. · 5. Students interested in the summer internship should apply online. · 6. answers vary

Lesson 13

Practice A: 1. was working · 2. had already submitted · 3. had parked (or: parked) · 4. not to · 5. to help · 6. taking

Practice B: 1. He said (that) he never drank coffee after six in the evening. / He said (that) he never drinks coffee after six in the evening. · 2. They asked when the scholarship results would be announced. · 3. He told me that the train had been cancelled. / He said that the train had been cancelled. · 4. My colleague suggested applying for the fellowship. / My colleague suggested that I apply for the fellowship. · 5. He denied sharing the password with anyone. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'My teacher advised me to read aloud every morning, and my mother reminded me not to skip breakfast before an exam.')

Lesson 14

Practice A: 1. boring · 2. amazed · 3. Having finished · 4. Warned / Having been warned · 5. With · 6. Walking

Practice B: 1. Having practised her talk five times, she spoke without hesitation. · 2. The technician standing by the generator switched off the power. · 3. Opening the window, I felt the fresh morning breeze cool the room. / When I opened the window, the fresh morning breeze cooled the room. · 4. Given the tight deadline, the team's report is very thorough. · 5. I have always been very interested in architectural history. · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Having had a cup of green tea, I sat down to read Lesson 14.')

Lesson 15

Practice A: 1. Never · 2. did she pass · 3. did I understand · 4. suggests (or: suggest) · 5. the detailed budget · 6. tend

Practice B: 1. Online learning may well replace some traditional lectures, or tends to complement classroom study. (answers vary) · 2. It was the practical examples that made the lesson easy to follow. · 3. Rarely had we seen such rapid progress in a single term. · 4. Never have I seen such a busy market. · 5. answers vary (e.g. Teammate: 'Could I have two more days on the report?' / Director: 'I was wondering if it might be possible to extend the deadline by two days so we can verify the final figures.') · 6. answers vary (e.g. 'Not only does my mentor listen patiently, but she also gives practical advice.')

Lesson 16

Practice A: 1. I finished my university degree in 2022. ('in 2022' is a finished past time → past simple) · 2. If the flight is delayed tomorrow, we will call the hotel. (ordinary future condition → present simple after 'if') · 3. Despite the cold wind, we walked to the summit. / Although the wind was cold, we walked to the summit. · 4. My supervisor suggested attending the workshop. / …suggested that I attend the workshop. ('suggest' takes -ing or a that-clause, never 'me to') · 5. Never have I felt so proud of our team. (negative opener triggers auxiliary + subject inversion) · 6. We really look forward to hosting your delegation next month. ('to' in 'look forward to' is a preposition → verb-ing)

Practice B: 1. Not having slept the night before, he made several small calculation errors. · 2. She told me not to worry about the deadline. / She reassured me that I didn't need to worry about the deadline. · 3. answers vary (e.g. 'Practising out loud is far more effective than silent reading because it trains your mouth and ear to work together in real time.') · 4. Tomorrow's examination schedule has been changed (by the committee). · 5. This new teaching method may well be one of the most effective for many learners. / This new teaching method tends to work very well for most learners. (answers vary) · 6. Could you tell me what time tomorrow's rehearsal starts? / Do you know what time tomorrow's rehearsal starts?

Review Test 1

A. 1. haven't seen · 2. were waiting · 3. freezes · 4. is studying · 5. had eaten · 6. is going to rain / will rain · 7. have / known · 8. started

B. 1. must · 2. Would / closing · 3. is · 4. don't have to / needn't

C. 1. Answers vary; e.g., 'You should rest before driving.' (should + base verb) · 2. Could you tell me where you parked? · 3. must be

Review Test 2

A. 1. knew · 2. had taken · 3. more effective · 4. was reading · 5. had already left · 6. made · 7. best · 8. hurry

B. 1. Despite the exam being hard, everyone passed. / Despite the difficulty, everyone passed. · 2. If I had a car, I would drive you. / If I had a car, I could drive you. · 3. answers vary — advice with should/could/might · 4. Could you tell me where the bank is?

C. 1. If she had saved money, she could buy the car now. / …would be able to buy… · 2. answers vary — far + comparative + reason · 3. Despite the cost, we decided to proceed.

Review Test 3

A. 1. was built · 2. repaired · 3. to speak · 4. making · 5. where · 6. whose · 7. didn't mention · 8. knew

B. 1. The room needs cleaning. / The room needs to be cleaned. · 2. He must have missed the train. · 3. Students interested in the course should apply. · 4. It is believed that the economy is improving. / The economy is believed to be improving.

C. 1. more / more confident · 2. Do you know where the bank is? · 3. had · 4. I enjoy reading novels.

Final Assessment

A. 1. have lived / 've lived / have been living · 2. had already had · 3. is · 4. hadn't said · 5. was cancelled · 6. must have been working · 7. making · 8. rewrite · 9. challenging · 10. Warned / Having been warned · 11. leaving · 12. did she apologise

B. 1. He said he would help me the next day. · 2. She asked me where I had bought it. · 3. Could you tell me when the shop closes? · 4. If he had revised, he wouldn't have failed. · 5. The documents have been stolen. · 6. It was the manager who/that approved the plan. · 7. I had the roof fixed. · 8. Rarely had she felt so confident. · 9. Although the task was difficult, they finished it. · 10. Having studied hard, he passed easily.

C. 1. can't · 2. Despite · 3. This method may well be the best. / This method is probably the best. (answers vary) · 4. Option A is far better than Option B because... (answers vary) · 5. The book (that / which) I read was amazing. · 6. more confident · 7. She advised me to apply early. · 8. meeting